

A DISSERTATION

The Serenity of the Remainder

Defeat, Salvage, and the Ethics of Enough in Joss Whedon's Firefly and Serenity

vede lucciole giù per la vallea

DANTE, INFERNO XXVI.29

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The figures, the night pages and the chapter constellations were drawn for this edition. Each chapter opens on a constellation of the thinkers it sets in conversation, after the method described in the Introduction.

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that Joss Whedon's *Firefly* (Fox, 2002; fourteen episodes, eleven broadcast in its original run) and its cinematic sequel *Serenity* (Universal, 2005) constitute a philosophically coherent corpus organized around a single problem: the fate of the remainder—what persists, and how it ought to live, after a totalizing order has completed its work. The corpus stages this problem in four registers, here designated the *historical* remainder (the defeated Independents of the Unification War), the *cosmological* remainder (a humanity dispersed across the soundless Black after the exhaustion of Earth-That-Was), the *biopolitical* remainder (River Tam and the Reavers, each the unassimilable excess of the Alliance's project of perfecting the human), and the *ontological* remainder (the Sartrean superfluity of persons and things that no administration can render meaningful without residue). Each register generates a monstrous double—Lost Cause revanchism, nihilism, Reaver frenzy, reification—against which the series elaborates a redemptive counter-practice.

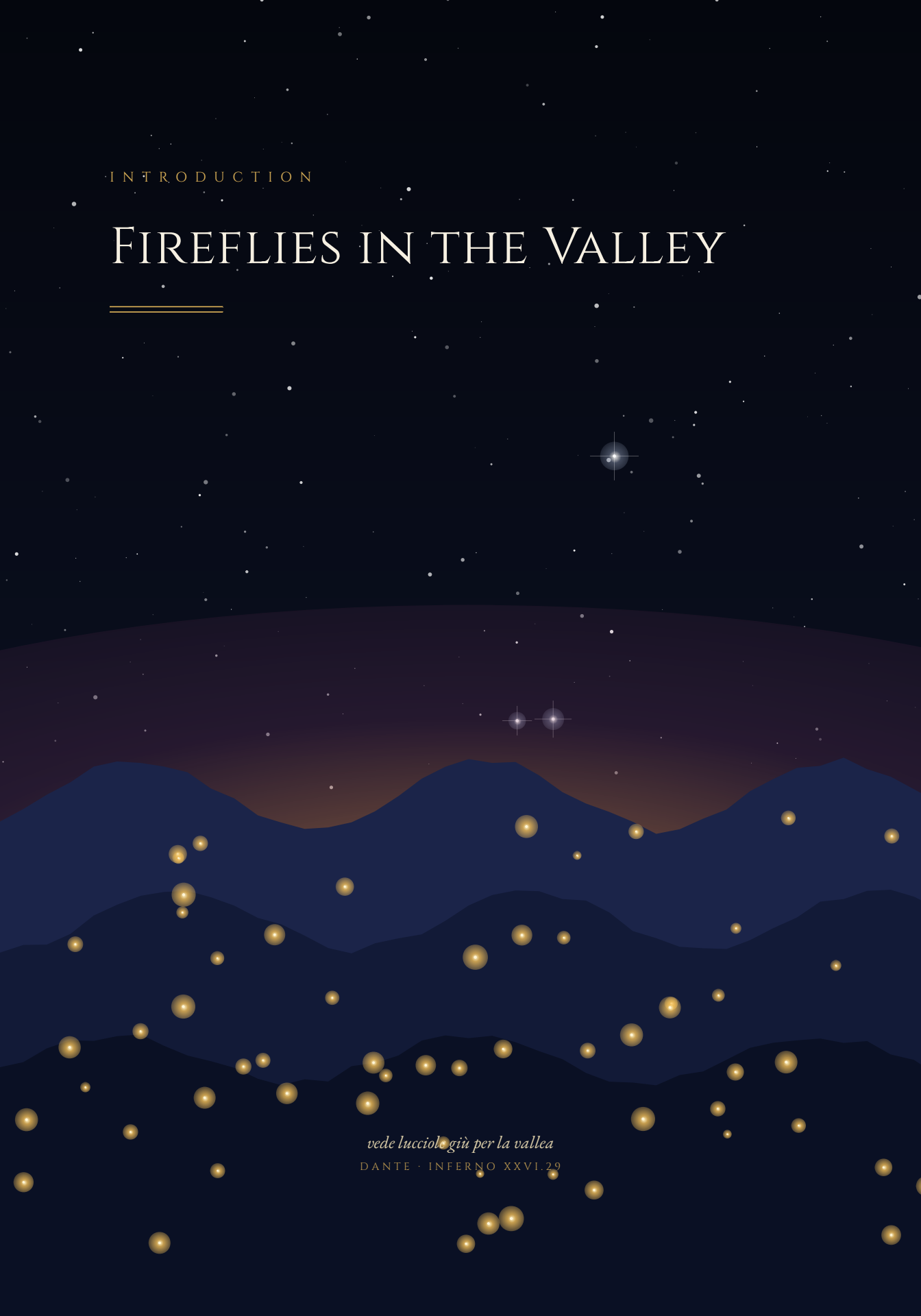
Proceeding by a constellational method that sets the corpus in dialogue with classical, early modern, modern, and Chinese sources, the thesis advances six claims. First, the name of the ship is a philosophical program: Latin *serenus* (the cloudless sky), *tranquillitas* and the Epicurean *galēnē* (the stilled sea), Epictetus's doctrine of what is "up to us," and Reinhold Niebuhr's tripartite Serenity Prayer converge in a post-defeat ethics whose three moments the series and the film enact in sequence. Second, the corpus is formally a *Lucanian Western*: an epic of the vanquished cast in the episodic mode of romance, opposed, after David Quint, to the Virgilian and Turnerian teleologies of imperial and frontier conquest. Third, the Alliance is an Augustan *imperium sine fine* whose pacifying agent, the Pax, literalizes Tacitus's indictment of empires that make a desolation and call it peace; the Pax is a counterfeit *ataraxia*, and its twin products—the quietly dead and the frenzied Reavers—reproduce with uncanny precision the two faces of the Freudian death drive. Fourth, the film's revision of the Reavers' origin relocates evil from the Nietzschean abyss to the administrative state, recapitulating modern theodicy's passage from Lisbon to the camps. Fifth, the ship constitutes a *salvage polity*: an elective, mobile micro-sovereignty of care whose constitutive practice is repair rather than replacement, and whose survival depends on what Zhuangzi called the usefulness of uselessness and James C. Scott the art of not being governed. Sixth, the series' Sinicization, justly criticized as techno-Orientalist ornament, harbors an unintended Daoist and Mencian critique of the meddling state more exact than any the show articulates in English.

These claims converge in the dissertation's central proposition: that *Firefly* opposes to the Alliance's meliorist ideal of the *better*—an infinite comparative that issues, when realized, in a perfected and therefore lifeless world—an *ethics of enough*, articulated jointly by Epicurean *autarkeia*, Daoist *zhi zu* (知足, knowing sufficiency), Camusian measure, and the pilot's closing insistence that continued flight suffices. Against the administered serenity of the Pax it sets the achieved

serenity of the remainder: a tranquillity that is mortal, practiced, compatible with grief and rage, and won only after defeat. The dissertation concludes that the corpus's material history—network mishandling, cancellation, fragmentation, and fan-driven resurrection—performs its own argument: the show survives, in Georges Didi-Huberman's sense, as a firefly whose intermittent light outlasted the searchlight of the network.

INTRODUCTION

Fireflies in the Valley



vede lucciole giù per la vallea

DANTE · INFERNO XXVI.29

Victrix causa deis placuit sed victa Catoni.

The conquering cause pleased the gods; the conquered cause, Cato.

LUCAN, BELLUM CIVILE 1.128

Auferre, trucidare, rapere falsis nominibus imperium, atque ubi solitudinem faciunt, pacem appellant.

To rob, to slaughter, to plunder they call by the false name of empire; and where they make a desolation, they call it peace.

TACITUS, AGRICOLA 30.5

Le silence éternel de ces espaces infinis m'effraie.

The eternal silence of these infinite spaces terrifies me.

PASCAL, PENSÉES (LAFUMA 201)

禍莫大於不知足。

There is no calamity greater than not knowing what is enough.

LAOZI, DAODEJING 46

1.1

Lucciole: Dante, Pasolini, Didi-Huberman

In the twenty-sixth canto of the *Inferno*, Dante looks down into the eighth ditch of Malebolge and likens the flames that enwrap the fraudulent counselors to the fireflies a peasant sees at dusk from a hillside, scattered down along the valley (*vede lucciole giù per la vallea*, *Inf.* 26.29). From within one such flame Ulysses recounts how he roused his aging companions with a little oration—*fatti non foste a viver come bruti, / ma per seguir virtute e canoscenza*, "you were not made to live as brutes, but to pursue virtue and knowledge" (26.119–20)—and how, past the Pillars of Hercules, "we made wings of our oars for the mad flight" (*de' remi facemmo ali al folle volo*, 26.125), until a mountain rose out of the unpeopled sea and the waters closed over the ship. In February 1975 Pier Paolo Pasolini converted the disappearance of fireflies from the Italian countryside, extinguished by pesticides and the poisoning of the rivers, into the emblem of an anthropological catastrophe: the passage from a clerical-fascist regime that had coerced bodies while leaving popular forms of life intact to a consumerist "new power" that dissolved those forms from within ("Il vuoto del potere in Italia," collected as "L'articolo delle lucciole" in *Scritti corsari*). In 2009 Georges Didi-Huberman, writing against Pasolini's despair and against what he diagnosed as the apocalyptic register of Giorgio Agamben's political thought, insisted instead on the *survivance* of the fireflies: minor, intermittent, unspectacular lights that persist beneath the blinding projectors of power and are visible only to those who decline to be dazzled (*Survivance des lucioles*).

The constellation is not ornamental. *Firefly* takes its title from an obsolescent class of transport ship whose drive glows at the stern like the abdomen of the insect. Its prologue is set in a valley—Serenity Valley, on the planet Hera—where the Independent army was broken in the decisive engagement of the Unification War, and its protagonist names his ship after that valley. Its crew are smugglers, thieves, and confidence artists: fraudulent counselors in Dante's exact sense, practitioners of the cunning intelligence the Greeks called *mētis*, who make wings of their engines for a flight their civilization regards as mad. Its privileged figure of knowledge is a young woman who is, clinically and politically, mad. And its narrative culminates, in *Serenity*, in a voyage past the limit of the inhabited worlds in pursuit of a forbidden *canoscenza* concerning a planet named Miranda. Unlike Dante's Ulysses, the crew returns. The difference between the foundering of the Ulyssean ship and the survival of the Firefly is the subject of this dissertation.

1.2

The Object and Its Corpus

The corpus comprises fourteen episodes produced in 2002 and the feature film of 2005, and its broadcast history is itself a datum of interpretation. Fox declined the two-hour pilot, reportedly

judging it insufficiently brisk and its captain insufficiently likable; commissioned a hastily written replacement opener, "The Train Job"; broadcast the episodes out of narrative order beginning on 20 September 2002 in the Friday-evening slot customarily reserved for programs not expected to survive; and announced its cancellation on 12 December, after eleven broadcasts, airing the original pilot last, on 20 December. Three episodes did not air in the original American run; they were first broadcast in the United Kingdom, on the Sci-Fi Channel, in 2003, and Whedon used the last days of production to reshoot scenes for one of them, "Heart of Gold." The complete series appeared on DVD in December 2003; its commercial success, together with an organized fan campaign, persuaded Universal Pictures to finance *Serenity*, released on 30 September 2005. The order adopted here is the narrative order restored by the DVD release.

NO.	TITLE	WRITTEN BY
1	"Serenity" (two-part pilot)	Joss Whedon
2	"The Train Job"	Joss Whedon and Tim Minear
3	"Bushwhacked"	Tim Minear
4	"Shindig"	Jane Espenson
5	"Safe"	Drew Z. Greenberg
6	"Our Mrs. Reynolds"	Joss Whedon
7	"Jaynestown"	Ben Edlund
8	"Out of Gas"	Tim Minear
9	"Ariel"	Jose Molina
10	"War Stories"	Cheryl Cain
11	"Trash"	Ben Edlund and Jose Molina
12	"The Message"	Joss Whedon and Tim Minear
13	"Heart of Gold"	Brett Matthews
14	"Objects in Space"	Joss Whedon
Film	*Serenity* (2005)	Joss Whedon (writer-director)

Three delimitations follow. First, the Dark Horse comics (from *Those Left Behind*, 2005, onward) and later tie-ins are treated as continuations rather than as evidence; where they bear on a disputed question, such as Shepherd Book's past, they are noted and bracketed. Second, paratexts illuminate intention without being permitted to legislate meaning; chief among them is Whedon's DVD commentary on "Objects in Space," in which he describes his adolescent encounter with Sartre's *La Nausée* as formative and frames the episode as an essay on the human investment of objects with significance. Third, "Whedon" functions throughout as a metonym for a collaborative authorship that included, among the writers, Tim Minear, Ben Edlund, Jane Espenson, Jose Molina,

Cheryl Cain, Drew Z. Greenberg, and Brett Matthews; the composer Greg Edmonson; the cinematographer David Boyd; the visual-effects artists of Zoic Studios; and an ensemble whose performances supplied much of the corpus's thought. This decentering is methodological before it is ethical (Barthes 1967; Foucault 1969), but it has acquired ethical weight through the public allegations about Whedon's conduct set out in the next paragraph. The object of this study is the corpus, which—like every remainder examined below—exceeds the intentions and the reputation of its maker.

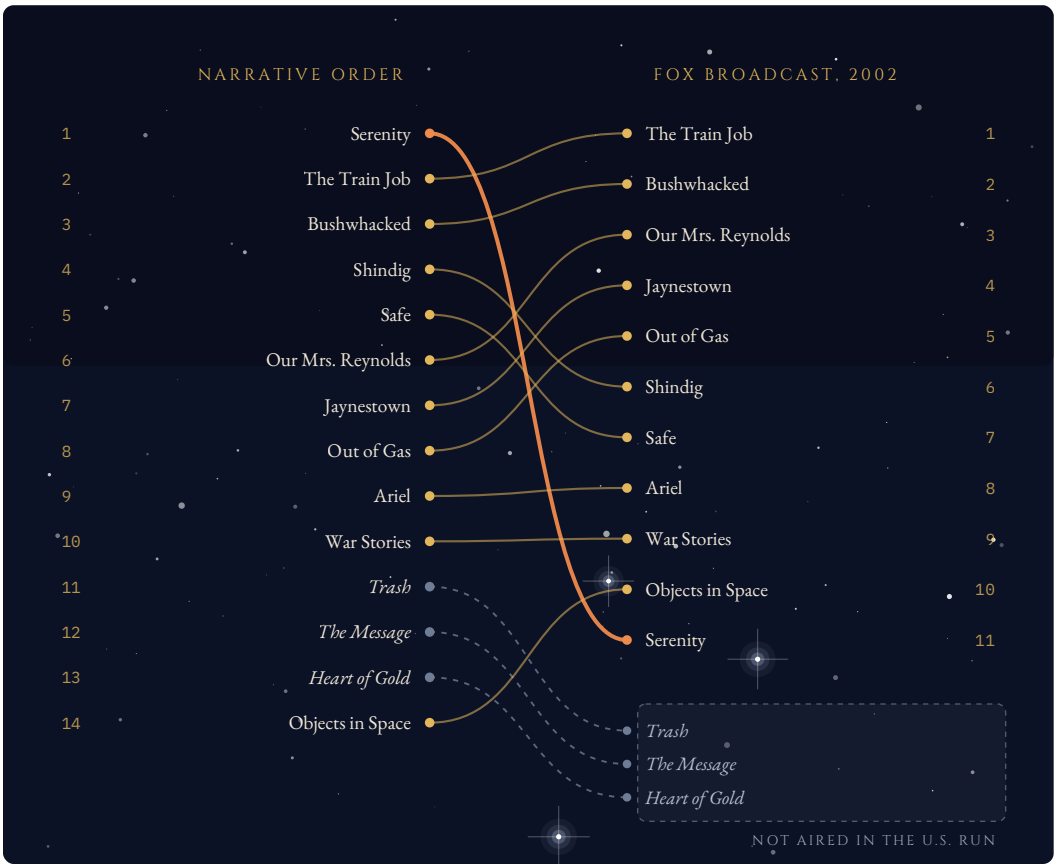


FIGURE 1 *Two orders.* Left, the narrative order restored by the DVD release; right, the order in which Fox broadcast the series in 2002. The pilot, first in the story, aired last, and three episodes did not air in the original American run.

The allegations, which this dissertation reports rather than adjudicates, are these. In 2017 Whedon's former wife, Kai Cole, published an essay at *The Wrap* accusing him of infidelity throughout their marriage and of hypocrisy as a self-professed feminist. In 2020 Ray Fisher, who played Cyborg in *Justice League* (2017), alleged that Whedon's treatment of that film's cast and crew during its reshoots was gross, abusive, and unprofessional, and his claims led to an investigation by WarnerMedia; in 2021 Gal Gadot said in an interview on Israeli television that Whedon had threatened her career during the same production. In February 2021 Charisma Carpenter alleged

that Whedon had abused his power on the sets of *Buffy the Vampire Slayer* and *Angel*, including by making threats to fire her while she was pregnant. Sarah Michelle Gellar and Amber Benson publicly supported her, Benson describing *Buffy* as a toxic environment whose toxicity began at the top; Michelle Trachtenberg, who joined *Buffy* as a teenager, alleged that his behavior toward her had been inappropriate and that a rule was made barring him from being alone in a room with her. Days later Jose Molina, who wrote "Ariel" and co-wrote "Trash," described Whedon as casually cruel to his writers, alleging that he found it funny to make female writers cry in notes sessions and boasted of making one writer cry twice in a single meeting. Molina's statement named no production, but he had written for Whedon on *Firefly*, and it was widely reported as extending to that show's writers' room. In a 2022 interview with *New York* magazine, Whedon rejected Fisher's account, denied threatening Gadot, denied calling Carpenter fat while conceding that he had not been "mannerly" toward her over her pregnancy, denied Trachtenberg's allegation, and spoke about the affairs Cole had described. These accounts bear on this study in a specific way: much early criticism read River and Inara through Whedon's reputation as a feminist auteur, and that reputation is treated here as a datum to be examined rather than a premise. Sources: The Hollywood Reporter; PinkNews; Looper; Yahoo News; Yahoo News, on the 2022 interview.

1.3

Method: Constellation Rather Than Illustration

The method is constellational rather than illustrative. The genre of "popular culture and philosophy" typically treats a narrative as a repository of examples for doctrines already settled elsewhere: Mal as an instance of Sartrean freedom, the Alliance as an instance of Hobbesian sovereignty. Such readings are not false, but they invert the relation that makes a work worth thinking with, subordinating its singular configuration to the generality of the doctrine. Walter Benjamin's epistemo-critical prologue to the *Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels* (1928) proposed instead that ideas stand to phenomena as constellations stand to stars: the idea is not abstracted from its instances but appears in their arrangement, and the arrangement is the critic's labor. Adorno generalized the figure into a principle of negative dialectics—thinking in constellations rather than subsuming the particular under the concept, so that what the concept cannot absorb remains legible. The method is apt for a work set among the stars; it is apter still for a work whose own subject is the nonidentical.

Three procedures implement it. The *philological* attends to names, toponyms, and etymologies, on the premise that a fictional world built under the pressure of weekly production discloses its unconscious in its onomastics: Serenity, Londinium, Persephone, Osiris, Bellerophon, Ariel, Miranda, Jubal Early. The *genealogical*, in the sense Nietzsche bequeathed to Foucault, traces the descent of motifs—the ship of state, the defeated army, the pacified city, the oracle-girl—without presuming that descent confers identity. The *formal* treats sound design, camera, score, and seriality as philosophical articulations in their own right: the corpus thinks not only in what its characters

say but in the silence of its exteriors, the hand-held hesitation of its space photography, the fiddle and acoustic guitar of its score, and the episodic drift imposed—and then interrupted—by its conditions of production.

1.4

The State of the Question

Scholarship on *Firefly* has developed principally within Whedon studies, a field institutionalized by the journal *Slayage* (founded in 2001 by Rhonda V. Wilcox and David Lavery) and consolidated for this corpus by the collections edited by Jane Espenson (*Finding Serenity*, 2005; *Serenity Found*, 2007), Rhonda V. Wilcox and Tanya R. Cochran (*Investigating Firefly and Serenity: Science Fiction on the Frontier*, 2008), and Dean A. Kowalski (*The Philosophy of Joss Whedon*, 2011), together with J. Michael Richardson and J. Douglas Rabb's monograph *The Existential Joss Whedon* (2007). Six lines of inquiry predominate. Genre criticism situates the series within the space Western and the revisionist Western, generally by way of Turner and Slotkin. Existentialist readings, the most philosophically developed, attend to freedom, responsibility, and the absence of transcendent sanction. A libertarian reception, signaled when the Libertarian Futurist Society honored *Serenity* in 2006 with its first Special Prometheus Award to a film, approved by a vote of its membership and citing the film's portrayal of resistance fighters against "oppressive collectivism," reads the Alliance as an indictment of the administrative state. Postcolonial critiques interrogate the construction of the Reavers as a displaced figure of the frontier "savage" and the show's appropriation of Chinese language and material culture in the near-absence of Asian performers. Feminist analyses address Inara's profession, River's infantilization and weaponization, and the distribution of competence and desire among the series' women. Fan studies, finally, treat the self-styled Browncoats as an exemplary case of audience mobilization, from the campaign that produced the film to the "Can't Stop the Serenity" charity screenings benefiting Equality Now.

Several earlier contributions bear directly on the arguments advanced here. Lyle Zynda's "We're All Just Floating in Space" (in *Finding Serenity*, 2005) read "Objects in Space" through existentialist philosophy, and Leigh Adams Wright's "Asian Objects in Space" (in the same collection) asked whether a world furnished with Asian objects makes room for Asian people. Agnes B. Curry's "'We Don't Say "Indian"': On the Paradoxical Construction of the Reavers" (*Slayage* 7.1, 2008) documented that Whedon was explicit about the parallel between the Reavers and Hollywood's Indians. In *Serenity Found* (2007), Michael Marano's "River Tam and the Weaponized Women of the Whedonverse" connected River to the other engineered heroines of Whedon's work, and Jacob Clifton's "Signal to Noise" read the film as a parable about media and the struggle over who controls the channel. This dissertation builds on each, and departs from them chiefly in integrating their concerns into a single account of the remainder.

Five lacunae motivate the present study. First, classical reception is nearly absent: the corpus's relation to Virgil, Lucan, and Tacitus—who between them define the Latin literature of empire,

civil war, and pacification—has gone unexamined, although the Alliance's capital world is called Londinium and its pacifying agent is called the Pax. Second, the biopolitical core revealed in *Serenity* has not been integrated with the existential layer of the series; the two are usually treated as successive emphases rather than as two faces of one problem. Third, the Chinese philosophical archive—Laozi, Zhuangzi, Mencius, the Legalists—has not been consulted, although the show's world is premised on a Sino-American fusion. Fourth, the ship as a political form has been described sentimentally, as "found family," rather than theorized. Fifth, the corpus's normative content remains under-specified: critics agree on what the show opposes but not on what it affirms.

1.5

The Argument: The Remainder and Its Measure

The dissertation's organizing concept is the *remainder*. In arithmetic the remainder is what is left over when a division does not come out even; the film's central revelation is, among other things, a remainder of exactly this kind—the tenth of one percent of Miranda's population on whom the Pax did not have its intended effect. In the prophetic and Pauline traditions the remnant (Hebrew *she'ar*, Greek *leimma*) is the fraction of a people that survives catastrophe and bears its promise (Isa. 10:20–22; Rom. 11:5). In Adorno the nonidentical is what any concept, applied to a particular, leaves over. In Sartre the *de trop* is the superfluity of existence that no essence justifies. In Benjamin's theses on history the vanquished are the remainder that the victors' historiography omits, and Whedon described the series in nearly those terms, as a show not about the people who made history but about the people history stepped on (as quoted in Curry 2008). In Didi-Huberman, *survivance* names the persistence of the minor beneath the spectacular; Chapter 10 acknowledges an earlier and independent sense of the word, that of the Anishinaabe theorist Gerald Vizenor. The Alliance's telos, this dissertation argues, is a *society without remainder*: a world in which every person is legible, every affect regulated, every planet integrated, every aggression neutralized—a world the Pax briefly achieved on Miranda, where it took the form of a planet of quiet corpses. *Firefly* is an art of the remainder: a sustained inquiry into what persists after defeat, after the exhaustion of Earth, after the death of God, and after the state's attempt to perfect the human; into the monstrous forms the remainder can assume; and into the practices by which it can live without becoming monstrous.

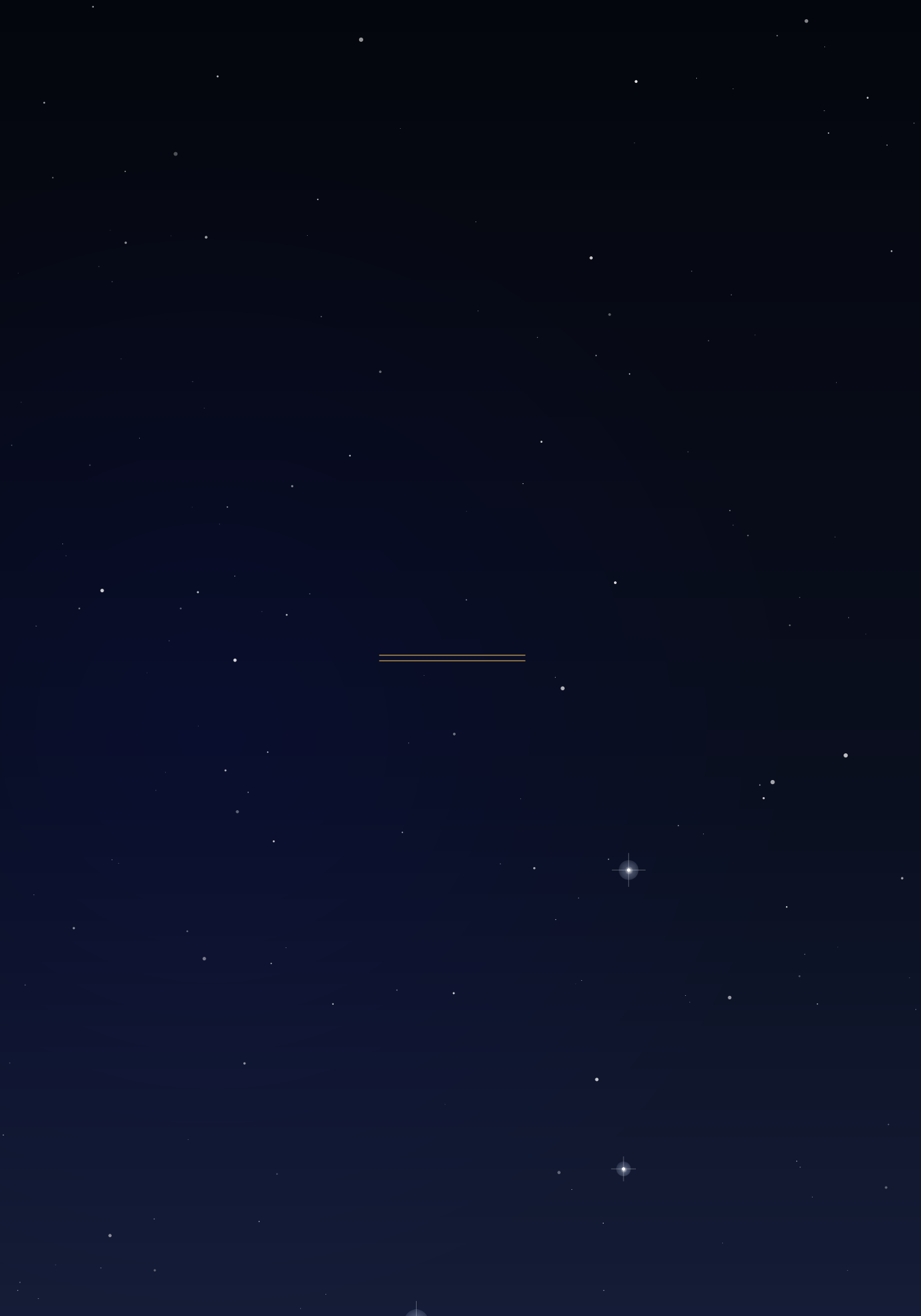
The argument proceeds through four coinages. The *Lucanian Western* designates the corpus's form: an epic of the defeated, anti-providential and episodic, in which the losers of a civil war are the moral center and the victors' telos is exposed rather than fulfilled. The *two serenities* designate its axiological core: the administered serenity of the Pax, chemical and terminal, against the achieved serenity of the remainder, practiced and mortal. The *salvage polity* designates its political form: the ship as a micro-sovereignty of elective care, bounded by the hull and constituted by repair. The *ethics of enough* designates its normative horizon: sufficiency (*autarkeia*, *zhi zu*, *satis*) against the infinite comparative of the "better" that drives the Alliance's *imperium sine fine*. Stated

in a sentence, the thesis is this: **Firefly and Serenity elaborate a philosophy of the remainder whose form is the Lucanian Western, whose institution is the salvage polity, and whose ethic is the serenity of enough—the precise antithesis of an empire that, having resolved to make people better, discovers that a perfected humanity is a dead one.**

1.6

Architecture of the Dissertation

Part One (Chapters 1–4) reconstructs the genealogies on which the corpus draws. Chapter 1 reads the name of the ship through the ancient grammar of tranquillity, from Epicurus and Lucretius through Epictetus and Seneca to Niebuhr. Chapter 2 reads the Black through Pascal, Sartre, Camus, Kierkegaard, and Nietzsche. Chapter 3 defines the Lucanian Western against Turner, Slotkin, the Lost Cause, and the classical Western, and recovers the English revolutionary genealogy of the Browncoats' formal name. Chapter 4 reads the Alliance as an Augustan order through Virgil, Tacitus, Augustine, and Milton. Part Two (Chapters 5–9) turns to the corpus's core: Chapter 5, the longest, reads Miranda through biopolitics, the Frankfurt School, Derrida, Freud, the dystopian tradition, *The Tempest*, and the history of theodicy; Chapter 6 reads River as oracle, weapon, and passenger on a ship of fools; Chapter 7 examines the economy of care borne by the Companion, the Shepherd, and the mechanic; Chapter 8 theorizes the ship as polis; Chapter 9 rereads the Sino-American 'verse against its own Orientalism. Part Three (Chapter 10) assembles the theory of the remainder, formulates the principles of the salvage polity and the ethics of enough, and confronts the strongest objections. A brief conclusion returns to the last exchange of the pilot.

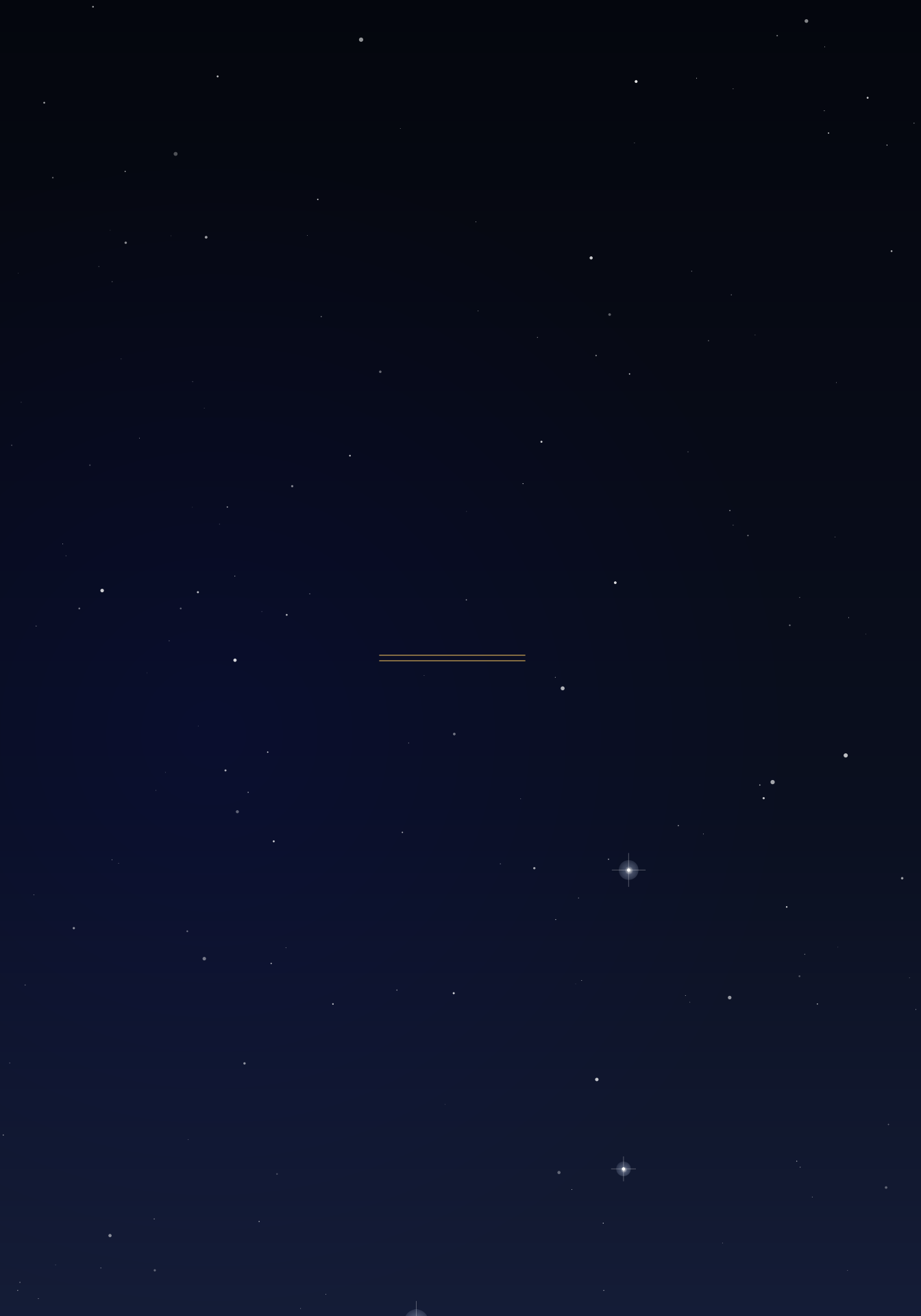


PART ONE

Genealogies

Part One reconstructs the four inheritances the corpus reworks: the ancient grammar of tranquillity, the modern experience of an indifferent cosmos, the American mythology of the frontier, and the Roman literature of empire and civil war.



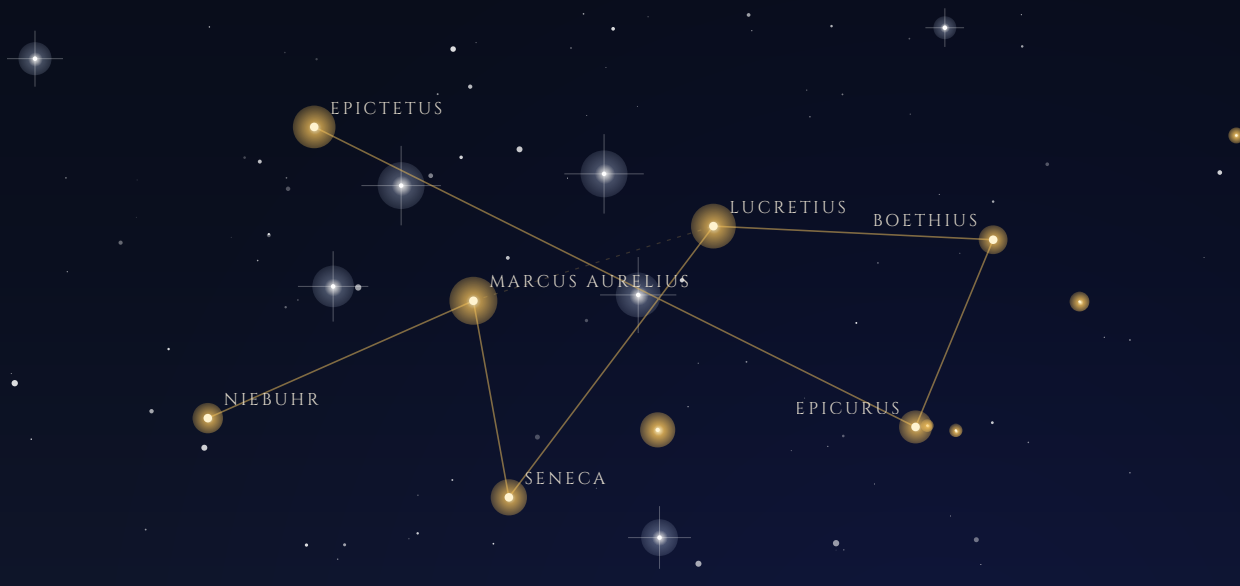


CHAPTER

I

Serenus

Sky, Sea, and the Ancient Grammar of Tranquillity



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER I

The name of the ship is the corpus's first philosophical proposition, and it is a proposition about how the defeated may live. This chapter reconstructs the lexicon from which the name descends, distinguishes the two serenities the corpus sets in collision, and argues that the series and the film enact in sequence the three moments of a post-defeat ethics whose ancient form is Epictetan and whose modern form is Niebuhrian.

1.1

The Etymology of a Ship

Latin *serenus* is, before it is anything else, a meteorological adjective: it describes a sky without cloud, weather that is clear, bright, and still. The neuter substantive *serenum* names the clear sky itself, and the abstract *serenitas* migrates across the history of the language from the firmament to the countenance and thence to the throne, becoming under the late empire an honorific of the emperor (*serenitas vestra*) and surviving in the "Serene Highness" of European courts. Its companions in the vocabulary of tranquillity share the same atmospheric origin. Latin *tranquillitas* denotes first the calm of the sea, a windless surface; Greek *galēnē* is the stillness of the water after a storm, and the Epicurean tradition adopted it as the image of an untroubled soul. Antiquity thus borrowed its central images of inner peace from the two elements across which ancient voyagers moved, the sky above and the sea beneath. A ship called Serenity, sailing a black ocean that is also a sky, gathers both elements into a single word.

The name passes, moreover, from the throne to the defeated. What was once the courtly address of emperors becomes the name of a salvaged freighter flown by a veteran of the losing army—an appropriation that, like much in the corpus, is at once ironic and sincere. And the name is first the name of a battlefield. Serenity Valley, on the planet Hera, is where Sergeant Malcolm Reynolds and Corporal Zoe held their position after the Independent command had capitulated, awaiting relief that did not come. To name the ship for the valley is a gesture of extraordinary density: it consecrates defeat as the keel of the voyage, converts the site of loss into the condition of motion, and stakes a claim—ironic, aspirational, or memorial, the corpus never decides—to the tranquillity that the valley conspicuously did not afford.

1.2

Galēnē and Ataraxia: The Epicurean Calm and Its Counterfeit

For Epicurus the end of life is pleasure, understood not as the pursuit of stimulation but as the absence of pain in the body (*aponia*) and of disturbance in the soul (*ataraxia*) (*Letter to Menoeceus* 131). The Hellenistic schools conceived philosophy as a therapy of the soul, a medicine for false belief and unbounded desire (Nussbaum 1994), and the Epicureans compressed their therapy into the *tetrapharmakos* preserved by Philodemus: god is not to be feared, death is not to be worried

over, the good is easily procured, the terrible is easily endured (*PHerc.* 1005). The term is exact. The fourfold remedy is a drug compounded of propositions rather than substances, administered through study, conversation, and friendship—"of all the things wisdom provides for the blessedness of a whole life, by far the greatest is the possession of friendship" (*Principal Doctrines* 27)—within a community that withdrew from the city under the maxim *lathe biōsas*, "live unnoticed."

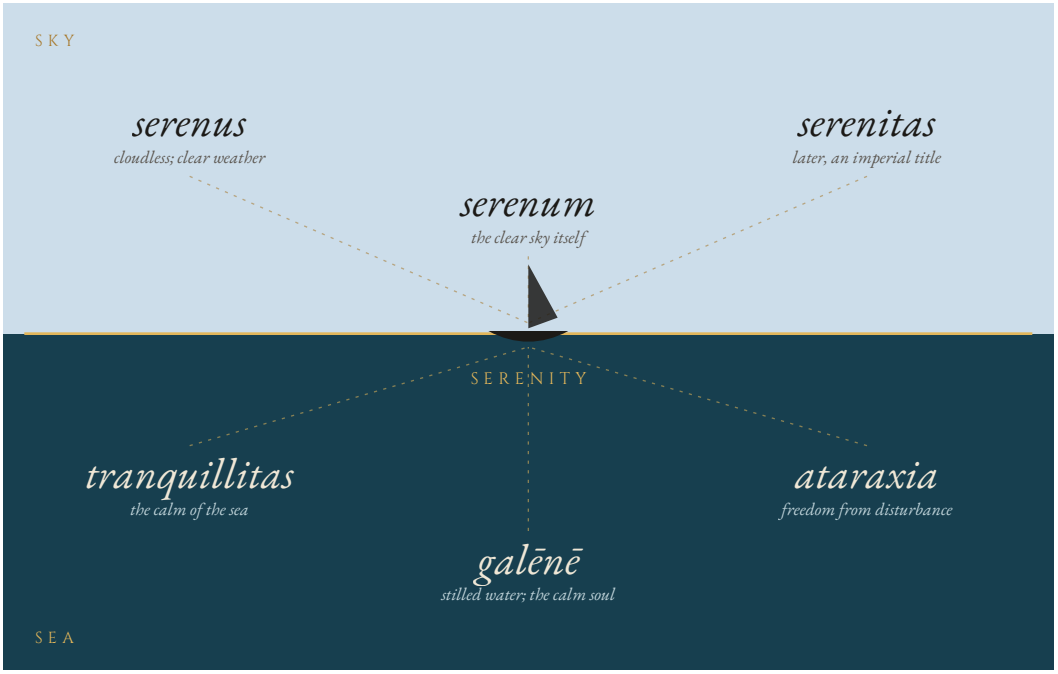


FIGURE 2 *Serenus and tranquillitas.* Antiquity drew its words for inner calm from the two elements a voyager crosses, the cloudless sky above and the stilled sea below. A ship called Serenity sails a black ocean that is also a sky.

The juxtaposition with the Pax is exact as well. G-23 Paxilon Hydrochlorate, dispersed through the atmospheric processors of Miranda, was designed to calm a population and weed out its aggression. Both the Epicurean remedy and the Alliance's agent promise freedom from disturbance; both conceive tranquillity as the removal of what agitates. They differ in their route, and the difference is everything. The Epicurean drug acts through the subject's understanding and therefore preserves the subject who understands; the Pax acts upon the subject from outside, through the air he breathes, and therefore abolishes the subject it pacifies. The Mirandans attained a chemical *ataraxia* so complete that they ceased to want work, food, speech, and one another, and lay down where they were. The Reavers, the remainder of the same procedure, attained its inverse: *tarachē*, disturbance, absolute and permanent.

This is the first and most fundamental antithesis of the corpus, and the name of the ship already inscribes it. There are two serenities: the *administered* serenity of the Pax, chemical, total, and terminal; and the *achieved* serenity of the remainder, practiced, partial, and mortal—a tranquillity compatible with grief, rage, desire, and humor, won after defeat rather than imposed in ad-

vance of it. The film titled *Serenity* is the drama of their collision. Even the Epicurean maxim finds its echo: the crew's first discipline is to live unnoticed, to fly beneath the attention of cruisers, and their tragedy in the film is that River's knowledge makes them conspicuous.

1 . 3

Clinamen: The Physics of Misbehavior

Lucretius supplies the corpus with its physics of freedom. Atoms falling straight downward through the void, he argues, would never meet; there must be a swerve (*clinamen*), a deviation by the least possible angle at no fixed time and no fixed place (*incerto tempore … incertisque locis*, *De Rerum Natura* 2.218–19), which breaks the decrees of fate (*fati foedera*, 2.254) and grounds the free will of living things (*libera … voluntas*, 2.256–57). Without the swerve, the cosmos would be a rain of parallel trajectories, each perfectly determined and perfectly alone.

The Alliance's universe is a universe of straight lines: of teleology, integration, the trajectory of civilization outward from the Core. "I aim to misbehave," Mal's declaration on the eve of the film's final assault, is in this light a declaration of swerve—deviation by a minimal angle from a line that is otherwise fate. Wash's piloting, figured in his last-act mantra as "a leaf on the wind," is a poetics of the swerve: not the force that cuts through the medium but the yielding that slips through it. Louis Althusser's late "materialism of the encounter" (1982) radicalized the Lucretian doctrine into an ontology in which every world is the effect of an aleatory encounter that happens to "take hold." "Out of Gas" is the corpus's Althusserian episode. Its flashbacks narrate the crew's formation as a sequence of accidents: Kaylee discovered in the engine room with the previous mechanic, whom she supersedes by repairing the drive on the spot; Jayne recruited in mid-robbery when Mal outbids his employers with a larger share and a room of his own; Inara renting a shuttle; Zoe skeptical of the ship, of the pilot, and of the pilot's moustache. Nothing in this genesis is necessary. The crew is an encounter that took hold, and its persistence is never guaranteed by the circumstances of its origin.

1 . 4

What Is Up to Us: Epictetus and the Inalienable Sky

Tōn ontōn ta men estin eph' hēmin, ta de ouk eph' hēmin: "Of things that are, some are up to us, and some are not up to us" (Epictetus, *Encheiridion* 1.1). Not up to us are body, property, reputation, and office; up to us are judgment, impulse, desire, and aversion—the faculty Epictetus calls *prohairesis*, moral choice. The doctrine's authority derives in part from its author's condition. Epictetus was born a slave and served Epaphroditus, a freedman of Nero; Celsus, as preserved by Origen, tells how his master twisted his leg until it broke, and how Epictetus, who had warned calmly that it would break, observed afterward that he had said so (*Contra Celsum* 7.53). The *Dis-*

courses give the doctrine its most compressed form: "You will chain my leg, but my choice not even Zeus can overpower" (1.1.23).

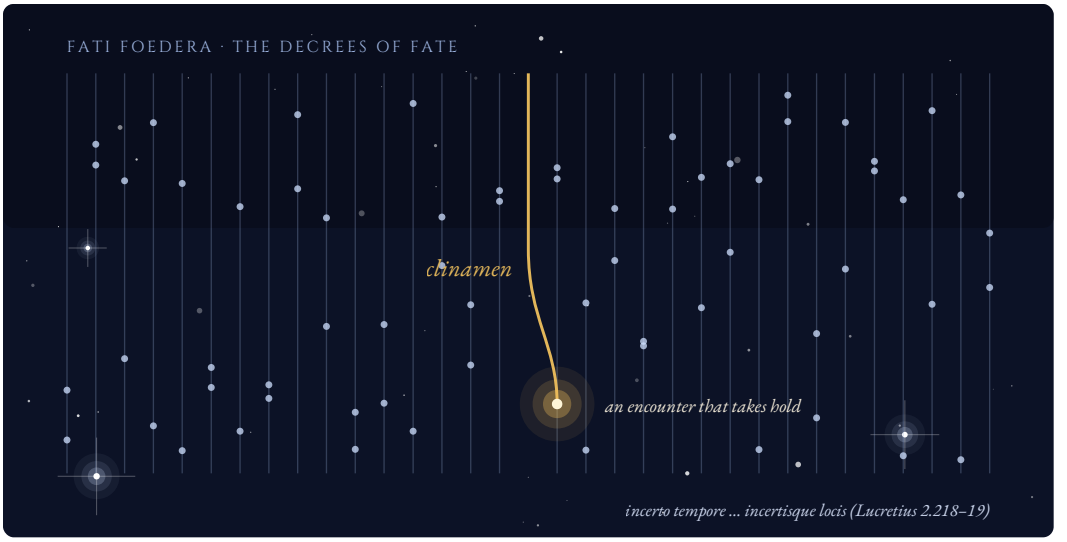


FIGURE 3 *The swerve.* Lucretius's atoms fall in parallel and never meet until one deviates by the least possible angle, at no fixed time or place (*De Rerum Natura* 2.216–93). Misbehavior, in the corpus, is a swerve from a line that is otherwise fate.

The theme ballad of *Firefly*, written by Whedon and performed by Sonny Rhodes, is structurally Epictetan. Its verses inventory a sequence of dispossessions—of affection, of land, of place—before terminating in a possession that cannot be confiscated, figured as the sky. The structure is precisely that of the *Encheiridion*: a catalogue of what can be taken, followed by the one thing that cannot. The sky in this figure is the *prohairesis* externalized as a landscape, the Stoic "inner citadel" (Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 8.48) turned inside out and stretched across the Black. Boethius, consoled in prison by Philosophy, heard Fortune insist that her wheel turns and that one who consents to ride it may not complain of the descent (*Consolatio* 2 pr. 2); the Browncoat condition is Boethian in exactly this sense, a fall from fortune answered by an inner possession.

The corpus quotes the structure of Stoicism without adopting its psychology. Mal is not a sage: he is angry, sardonic, attached, jealous, and frequently cruel, and nothing in the series suggests that the passions are to be extirpated. What the series retains from the Stoics is the line between the alienable and the inalienable, not the *apatheia* that was to follow from drawing it. The result is a Stoicism of the defeated rather than of the sage—a Stoicism with its passions intact—and that modification is the first sign of the corpus's characteristic synthesis.

1.5

From the Porch to the Prayer: Niebuhr and the Threefold Structure

The Serenity Prayer, attributed to Reinhold Niebuhr, composed in the early 1930s and disseminated through Alcoholics Anonymous from the 1940s, asks for serenity to accept what cannot be changed, courage to change what should be changed, and wisdom to distinguish the one from the other (Sifton 2003). It is a Christian transposition of the Epictetan dichotomy, but it adds a term the Stoics did not need: courage. Where the Stoic draws the line between what is up to us and what is not and then rests, the Niebuhrian petition draws the same line in order to act on the near side of it. The prayer thus converts a doctrine of acceptance into a theology of action bounded by acceptance.

The corpus enacts the prayer's three petitions in sequence. The fourteen episodes are an education in the first: the war is lost, Earth is gone, the job is the job, and survival requires the acceptance of all three. The film is an education in the second: having learned what happened on Miranda, Mal abandons flight for confrontation. The hinge between them is wisdom, and the film locates it in three figures—Book, who dies urging Mal to believe in something; River, who knows; and Inara, who refuses to let Mal's courage become indistinguishable from the Operative's zeal.

PETITION	ANCIENT ANTECEDENT	MOMENT IN THE CORPUS	EXEMPLARY FIGURES	FAILURE MODE
Serenity to accept what cannot be changed	Epictetus, *Encheiridion* 1; Epicurean *ataraxia*	The series: the war lost, Earth gone, the job as discipline	Mal the survivor; Zoe	Resignation; the administered acceptance of the Pax
Courage to change what should be changed	Lucretian *clinamen*; Camusian revolt	The film: the end of running, the assault on the signal	Mal the insurgent; Mr. Universe	Monomania; the Reaver mask
Wisdom to know the difference	Aristotelian *phronēsis*; Daoist knowing when to stop	Haven and its aftermath	Book; River; Inara	Ideology: treating everything as changeable, as the Operative does

Niebuhr's political theology supplies the corpus's second register. *Moral Man and Immoral Society* (1932) argued that individuals are capable of genuine altruism, while groups—classes, nations, states—are more egoistic than their members and more adept at dressing egoism as idealism. *The Children of Light and the Children of Darkness* (1944) added that the idealists, underestimating self-interest, are both foolish and dangerous, while the cynics, understanding it, recognize no law above it. *The Irony of American History* (1952) diagnosed the peculiar peril of a powerful nation convinced of its innocence, whose virtues become vices precisely through the power to impose them. The Alliance is Niebuhr's ironic nation transposed to the scale of a star system: a Sino-American superpower whose children of light, persuaded of their benevolence, administer it by atmospheric processor. The crew, conversely, is the community small enough for moral relations—

Niebuhr's moral man at the scale where morality remains possible—and Mal is a realist without illusions who has not consented to become a cynic.

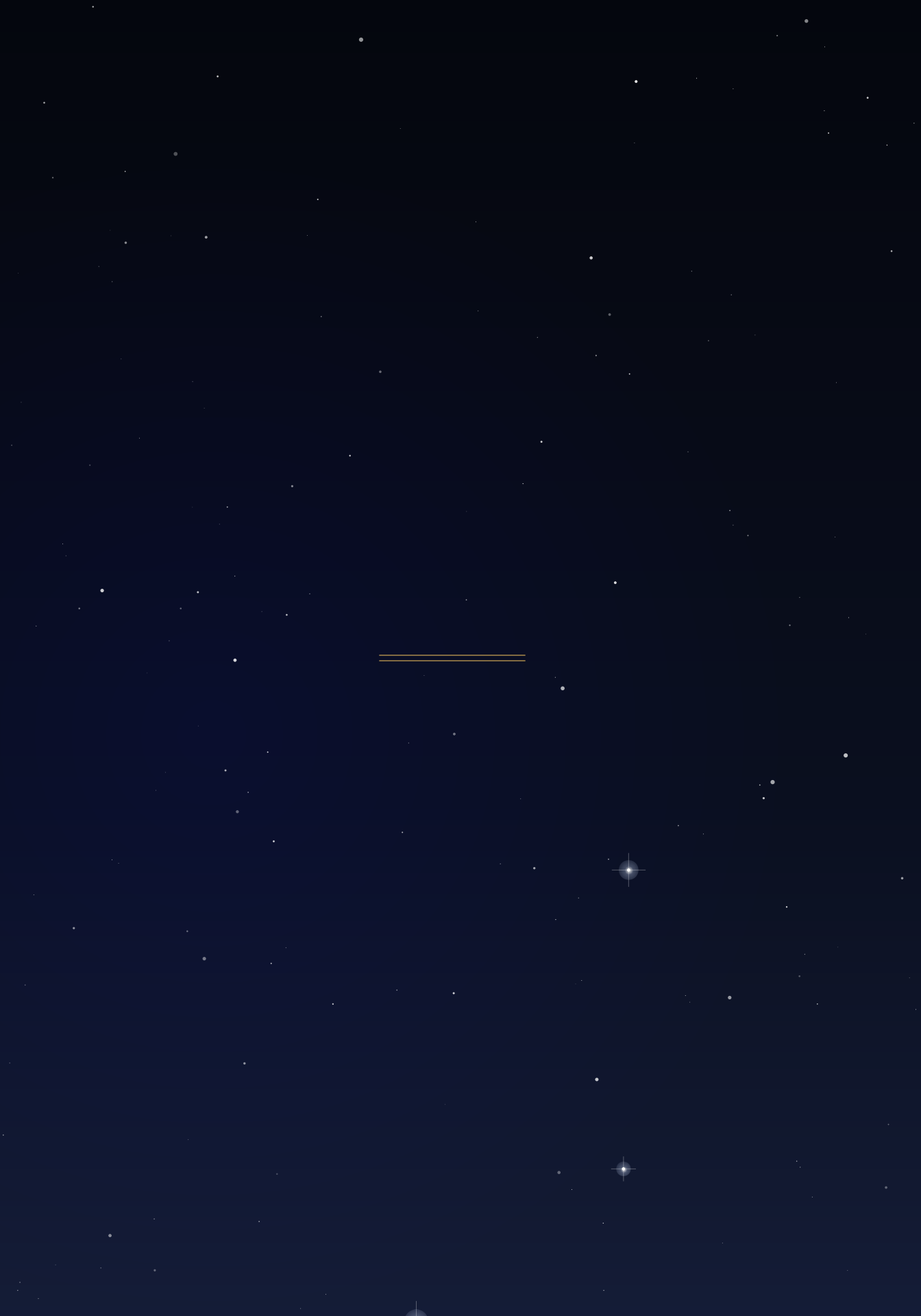
1.6

Serenity Valley: The Consecration of Defeat

The pilot's prologue shows a soldier who kisses a small crucifix before the assault; the series shows a captain who has no use for prayer. Between them lies a valley whose name inverts the most familiar valley of Western devotion. The psalmist walks through the valley of the shadow of death and fears no evil, for God is with him (Ps. 23:4); Mal walks out of Serenity Valley having concluded that God was not. The name of the battlefield becomes, in retrospect, an anti-psalm—a serenity that God did not grant—and to rename the ship after it is to carry that theological wound as one's address.

The practice has a precise structure. The Stoics recommended the *praemeditatio malorum*, the rehearsal of evils before they arrive, so that misfortune would find the mind prepared (Seneca, *Ep.* 91; Cicero, *Tusc.* 3.29). Mal's naming is its inversion, a *postmeditatio*: the evil has already arrived, and the name ensures that it will be rehearsed after the fact, every time the ship is hailed. It is neither forgetting nor vengeance. Forgetting would surrender the past to the victors' historiography; vengeance would bind the future to the past in the manner of the Lost Cause. The name keeps defeat present as the condition of a life that continues. Its two temporalities—memorial and aspirational, the battle and the hope of tranquillity—are held together without resolution, and this unresolved double tense is the corpus's first figure of the remainder.

The serenity the ship names is therefore neither the sage's *apatheia* nor the Pax's chemical calm. It is a third thing: the serenity of those who lost, who know what is not up to them, who keep the wound in the name, and who reserve the right to swerve. The next chapter examines the medium in which that serenity must be achieved—the Black, and the silence that fills it.

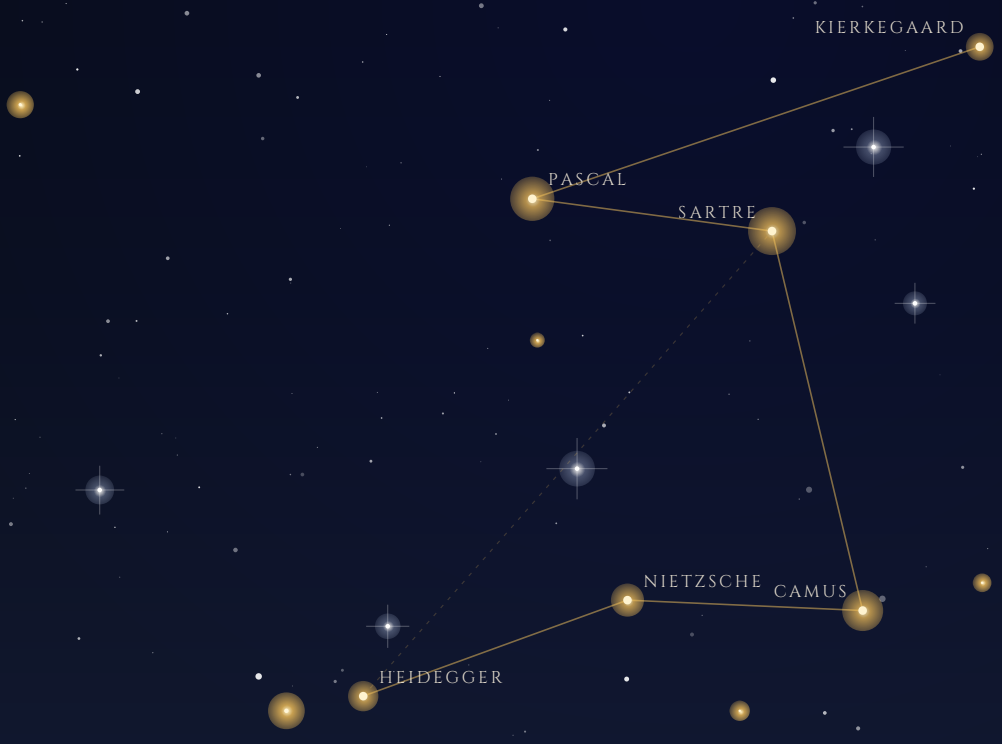


CHAPTER

II

The Black

Silence, Nausea, and the Absurd Frontier



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER II

The Black is at once the corpus's cosmos and its theology: an infinite, silent, meaningless medium in which every meaning must be made and every made meaning remains exposed. This chapter reads its form (silence), its ontology (nausea), its ethics (bad faith and revolt), its faith (Kierkegaard), and its terror (Nietzsche's abyss), and argues that the existentialism of the series is completed—and transformed—by the politics of the film.

2.1

The Silence of Infinite Spaces

Pascal's fragment on the eternal silence of infinite spaces (Lafuma 201) gives voice to the terror of the post-Copernican subject before a cosmos that no longer addresses him; in the apologetic design of the *Pensées*, the terror is a lever meant to move the reader toward the wager. *Firefly* retains the terror and withholds the wager. Its exterior space photography is, by deliberate choice, soundless. The convention inaugurated by *Star Wars* (1977), in which ships roar past the camera as though the vacuum were air, is refused; engines ignite in silence, cruisers pass in silence, and the Reaver vessel of the pilot drifts by in a silence more menacing than any score. The refusal is not a pedantry of physics but an ontological statement: the cosmos does not answer. Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) had also silenced space, but it scored the silence with Johann Strauss and Richard Strauss, transfiguring the void into a ballroom and a cathedral. *Firefly* declines even that sublimation. Greg Edmonson's score of fiddle and acoustic guitar belongs to the porch and the campfire—instruments of human proximity—and it sounds inside the hull. Outside there is nothing.

The camera completes the argument. The effects artists of Zoic Studios simulated a human operator in space: zooms that overshoot their subject, focus that hunts, lens flares, a frame that seems to struggle to keep a ship in view. The cosmos thus appears not from the vantage of a god but from that of a witness—finite, embodied, fallible—an aesthetic soon made emblematic by the reimagined *Battlestar Galactica* (2004–2009). Sound and image together literalize what Camus called the absurd: the confrontation between the human longing for clarity and the unreasonable silence of the world (*Le Mythe de Sisyphe*, 1942). Human noise within, cosmic silence without: the hull is the line along which the absurd is drawn.

Nietzsche supplies the frame for the corpus's post-terrestrial condition. In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §124 he writes: "We have left the land and gone aboard ship! We have broken down the bridge behind us—more, we have broken down the land behind us! … Woe, when homesickness for the land overtakes you, as if there had been more freedom there—and there is no more 'land'!" The aphorism immediately precedes the parable of the madman (§125), who asks whether we are not straying as through an infinite nothing, and whether we do not feel the breath of empty space. Earth-That-Was is Nietzsche's vanished land, and the Black is the infinite nothing through which its heirs stray. The corpus opens after two deaths—the exhaustion of Earth and the absence of God from Serenity Valley—and it never stages a return to either.

2.2

Nausea in the Cargo Bay: "Objects in Space"

In the public garden of Bouville, Antoine Roquentin stares at the root of a chestnut tree until its name, its function, and its classification fall away and existence itself is laid bare as *de trop*—superfluous, contingent, unjustified, there for no reason (Sartre, *La Nausée*, 1938). Whedon, who has publicly identified as an atheist and who received an award for cultural humanism from the Humanist Chaplaincy at Harvard in 2009, has described his adolescent reading of the novel as formative, and "Objects in Space," the final episode of the series, is his most explicit attempt to dramatize its insight; Lyle Zynda's existentialist reading of the episode (2005) is an earlier account on which the reading offered here builds. The episode opens with River walking barefoot through the sleeping ship, hearing the unspoken interiors of the crew, and descending to the cargo bay, where she picks up what she perceives as a stick. The crew perceive a loaded gun. The horror of the scene lies wholly in the gap between perception and name: the object has shed its function in River's hands, and for an instant everyone else is forced to see that its being-a-weapon was never a property of the thing but a function of a human project.

The episode then introduces its antagonist, the bounty hunter Jubal Early, who boards the ship to take River for the Alliance's reward. Early is an amateur ontologist: he muses on the nature of things, interrogates his captives with oblique questions, and asks Simon whether what is happening seems right to him. He is also the corpus's most chilling figure of reification—a man who prices persons as cargo, and whose threat to rape Kaylee, made to force her compliance, is staged with a seriousness that refuses to make it entertainment. River defeats him by a ruse that is also an ontological provocation: she claims, over the ship's intercom, to have dissolved into the vessel, to be no longer aboard the ship but the ship itself. The episode ends with Early thrown from the hull, drifting alone in the Black and talking to himself—an object in space.

Three modes of objecthood are thus set in play. The first is Sartrean nausea, River's de-naming of things, which exposes the contingency of every meaning. The second is the Heideggerian tool analysis (*Sein und Zeit*, 1927, §16): equipment that is ready-to-hand withdraws into its use and becomes conspicuous only when it breaks. "Out of Gas" is the corpus's Heideggerian episode; when the catalyzer on the compression coil fails and life support begins to die, the ship ceases to be a transparent instrument and appears as what it is—a fragile world whose every part is suddenly obtrusive. The third mode is reification, the reduction of persons to things, embodied by Early and finally visited upon him. Against all three stands a fourth: Kaylee's animism, her insistence that the ship is "she," that the engine speaks, that a machine can be loved. Heidegger's late lecture "Das Ding" (1950) distinguished the mere object from the thing that gathers earth and sky, mortals and divinities; Serenity is a thing in this sense, gathering cargo and the Black, a mortal crew and a preacher's faith. The episode's argument is that meaning lives neither in objects nor in a sovereign subject but in the relations of care by which persons invest things and one another. Existence pre-

cedes essence; the gun is a gun only within a human project; the ship is "she" only because someone keeps her flying.

2.3

Inverted Bad Faith

Sartre's analysis of bad faith (*L'Être et le néant*, 1943, pt. 1, ch. 2) describes the denial of one's freedom through identification with one's facticity: the café waiter whose movements are a little too precise, who plays at being a waiter as an inkwell is an inkwell. Mal exhibits a peculiar variant that this dissertation calls *inverted bad faith*. He claims a facticity of cynicism—he is in it for the money, he is no longer a Browncoat, he is no hero—in order to evade the responsibility of his own ideals. Ordinary bad faith disowns one's capacity for wickedness; Mal's disowns his capacity for goodness. His acts refute his self-description at every turn: he returns the medicine he was hired to steal in "The Train Job"; he flies back into hostile country to recover Simon and River in "Safe" on the ground, as he puts it, that they are on his crew; he fights a duel in "Shindig" for the honor of a woman he insults daily. *L'existentialisme est un humanisme* (1946) supplies the verdict: a person is nothing other than the sum of his acts, and the coward is responsible for his cowardice. By the same logic the cynic who keeps acting justly is not a cynic.

Inara presents the mirror case. The Companion's role is a performance of extraordinary refinement, and the series repeatedly suggests that she uses it to defer an acknowledgment of what she feels for Mal. Yet the role is also a chosen vocation and, as Chapter 7 argues, a form of sexual sovereignty; it cannot be reduced to an alibi. The romance between them is a duet of mutual bad faith —each playing a part, cynic and courtesan, to avoid the exposure that love requires—and its structure is recognizably Sartrean. In the analysis of concrete relations with others (*L'Être et le néant*, pt. 3, ch. 3), love appears as the project of being loved, an attempt to capture the other's freedom without abolishing it, and therefore a perpetual conflict. The series never resolves the conflict, and its refusal is consistent: a resolution would require one of them to surrender the role through which each preserves a freedom the 'verse otherwise threatens.

2.4

Revolt and Measure: Camus

Camus's *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* rejects both physical suicide and the "philosophical suicide" of the leap into faith, and derives from the absurd three consequences: revolt, freedom, and passion. Sisyphus, conscious of the futility of his labor and persisting in it, must be imagined happy. *L'Homme révolté* (1951) grounds revolt in the slave's refusal: the rebel's no implies a yes, an affirmation of a limit and of a value held in common, so that from individual revolt arises solidarity—I rebel, therefore we exist. The same book diagnoses the century's distinctive pathology as *logical*

crime: murder committed not in passion but with a perfect alibi, justified by a philosophy of history that promises a future in whose name any present may be sacrificed. Its final part, "La pensée de midi," opposes to that pathology the Mediterranean virtue of measure.

Mal's revolt conforms to Camus's typology with unusual precision. It begins in a refusal—Serenity Valley, the Unification Day brawl that opens "The Train Job"—and the refusal implies a we, the crew, without ever hardening into a system or a program. The Operative is its antithesis, the logical criminal par excellence: a killer whose every killing is justified by an impeccable alibi, the better world in whose name he acts. *La Peste* (1947) adds a typology of responses to catastrophe that the crew reproduces almost figure for figure. Dr. Rieux fights the plague without faith, from what he calls common decency; Simon fights the Academy's damage to his sister on the same footing. Father Paneloux wrestles in two sermons with the meaning of innocent suffering; Shepherd Book carries the same burden more quietly. Tarrou asks whether one can be a saint without God and resolves never to side with the executioners; Mal, who would reject the word "saint" with contempt, asks the same question by his conduct. The journalist Rambert tries repeatedly to escape the quarantined city to rejoin his beloved, and then stays, because it would be shameful to be happy alone; Inara repeatedly leaves the ship and returns.

In November 1946 Camus published in *Combat* a series of articles under the title "Ni victimes ni bourreaux"—neither victims nor executioners. The phrase formulates the crew's ethic exactly. Miranda presents the two terms of the alternative in their purest form: a population pacified into victimhood and an Operative who executes in the name of its pacification. The film's climax is the refusal of both.

2.5

The Knight of Loyalty: Kierkegaard

Frygt og Bæven (1843) distinguishes the tragic hero from the knight of faith. The tragic hero—Agamemnon at Aulis, Jephthah, Brutus—sacrifices a beloved particular to a higher ethical universal, the state or the people, and remains within the ethical: he is understood, admired, and wept for. The knight of faith, Abraham on Mount Moriah, stands in an absolute relation to the absolute that suspends the ethical itself, and cannot make himself understood. The Operative is a tragic hero in the strict Kierkegaardian sense. He sacrifices particulars—Dr. Mathias, the settlers of Haven, Mr. Universe, River—to the universal of the state's future, and he understands himself perfectly; he is articulate, even eloquent, about the necessity of what he does. Mal exhibits, without God, the structure of the knight of faith: an absolute relation to particular others that suspends the universal—law, state, even the common good as it might be calculated. This dissertation calls him a *knight of loyalty*. Kierkegaard's absolute is God; Mal's is the particular person who is on his crew, and the inversion is the corpus's most consequential theological secularization.

Shepherd Book supplies the Kierkegaardian counterweight. The *Afsluttende uvidenskabelig Efterskrift* (1846) insists that truth is subjectivity, that what matters in religious existence is the

how of belief rather than its what. Book's dying counsel to Mal—that it matters less what one believes than that one believes—is a recognizably Kierkegaardian "how," though secularized: Kierkegaard's how is infinite passion directed toward a paradox, while Book's is commitment as such. The film knows the danger in this formula. It is Book who identifies the Operative as a believer, and therefore as an adversary who will not stop. Commitment alone cannot be the criterion, since the Operative is more committed than anyone. The corpus will need a further criterion, which Chapter 10 identifies as the remainder's measure.

2.6

The Abyss Before the Retcon: Nietzsche

Before *Serenity*, the series offers a metaphysical account of the Reavers. In the pilot and again in "Bushwhacked," Mal describes them as men who went to the edge of the galaxy, looked into nothing, and became it. In "Bushwhacked," the sole survivor of a Reaver attack on a transport begins, after witnessing the atrocity, to mutilate himself in their manner, and Mal explains that the man has looked into the void and must now become what he saw. The account is pure Nietzsche: "Whoever fights monsters should see to it that he does not thereby become a monster. And when you gaze long into an abyss, the abyss also gazes into you" (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse*, 1886, §146). The Reaver of the series is the human being who has encountered the infinite nothing of the madman's parable and has become its instrument—nihilism passed from despair into destruction without passing through creation.

Nietzsche had also described the opposite response. In the prologue to *Also sprach Zarathustra* (1883), the last man asks what love is, what creation is, what longing is, what a star is—and blinks; the last men announce that they have invented happiness, and blink. Comfortable nullity and destructive frenzy are the two forms of nihilism after the death of God: the one that no longer wants anything and the one that wants only to destroy. They anticipate, with startling exactness, the two outcomes of the Pax: the Mirandans who lay down and the Reavers who rose. The film's retcon does not abolish this Nietzschean schema; it relocates its origin. The void did not make the Reavers; the state did, and in the same act it manufactured the last men. The series poses nihilism as a cosmic condition; the film discloses it as an administrative product. Part Two will argue that this displacement—from the abyss to the air processor—is the corpus's decisive philosophical event.

CHAPTER

III

The Lucanian Western

Frontier Mythology from the Side of the Vanquished



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER III

The Western is the founding epic of the United States, and like every founding epic it was written from the side of the victors. *Firefly* rewrites it from the side of the vanquished. This chapter reconstructs the frontier mythology the corpus inherits, shows how the corpus suspends its central mechanism, confronts the Confederate trace in its conception, assembles a comparative grammar of the classical and revisionist Western, and proposes a generic category—the Lucanian Western—adequate to what the corpus actually does. It closes by recovering, from the English Revolution, a genealogy for the Browncoats' formal name that the Confederate reading obscures.

3.1

Wagon Train from the Stars

"The existence of an area of free land, its continuous recession, and the advance of American settlement westward, explain American development." Frederick Jackson Turner's paper of 1893 made the frontier the crucible of American democracy and individualism and, by announcing on the evidence of the 1890 census that the frontier had closed, converted it at the moment of its disappearance into a national myth. The myth was reopened twice in the century that followed: rhetorically, when John F. Kennedy told the 1960 Democratic convention that the nation stood on the edge of a New Frontier, and generically, when Gene Roddenberry pitched *Star Trek* as "Wagon Train to the stars." Roddenberry's frontier is the state's frontier. Starfleet is cavalry, survey party, and diplomatic corps at once; its ships extend the reach of the Federation, and its explorers are the vanguard of the center.

Firefly's frontier is the frontier of those the center expelled. Its border worlds are not the Federation's vanguard but the Alliance's hinterland: the destination, as the series' expository framing puts it, of the resisters who drifted outward after the war. Turner's frontier functioned, in one of his more durable hypotheses, as a safety valve that drained discontent from the settled East; the Rim performs the same function, but the corpus reveals the valve to be a dumping ground. The frontier is not the crucible of democracy but the site of abandonment. It is lawless, governed by local tyrants—Magistrate Higgins in "Jaynestown," Rance Burgess in "Heart of Gold," Adelai Niska from his orbital fortress—and visited by the Alliance only intermittently and coercively, by cruiser, by Cortex surveillance, by the bounty system. This dissertation calls it a *frontier of abandonment*.

Henry Nash Smith's *Virgin Land* (1950) traced the agrarian myth of the garden that the frontier was supposed to become. The 'verse literalizes the myth's founding fantasy. Its worlds were terraformed: the land was not taken from anyone, because it was manufactured. Terraforming is *terra nullius* made true—the colonial fantasy of an empty continent realized without the colonial crime. The corpus nonetheless finds that its frontier requires a "savage," and in the Reavers it supplies one. Chapter 10 returns to what this substitution reveals.

3.2

Violence Without Regeneration

Richard Slotkin's trilogy (*Regeneration Through Violence*, 1973; *The Fatal Environment*, 1985; *Gunfighter Nation*, 1992) reconstructed the structure of the American frontier myth: separation from the metropolis, regression to a savage condition, regeneration through violence against the savage, and return to found or renew civilization. *Gunfighter Nation* traced that structure into the twentieth century, where it organized the imagination of counterinsurgency abroad. *Firefly* suspends the third term. Its violence is pragmatic, abrupt, frequently comic, and never redemptive. In "The Train Job," having warned Niska's henchman Crow, Mal kicks him into the ship's engine intake when he refuses terms; the next henchman becomes instantly reasonable, and the scene's black comedy depends entirely on its refusal of any heroic framing. In "War Stories" Niska tortures Mal until his heart stops and then revives him in order to continue—a resurrection performed by the torturer's machinery, regeneration through violence reduced to its literal and obscene minimum. The violence of the series leaves residue rather than renewal: Mal's trauma, Zoe's grief, the film's dead.

The corpus was produced in the months after September 2001 and released as a film during the Iraq War, and critics have read its Alliance—identity cards, Cortex surveillance, an Operative whose mandate places him beyond law—against the security measures of the Bush administration: the USA PATRIOT Act of October 2001; the presidential military order of 13 November 2001 authorizing the indefinite military detention of non-citizens suspected of terrorism, which Giorgio Agamben took as a paradigm in *Stato di eccezione* (2003); the detention camp at Guantánamo Bay, in use from January 2002; the Justice Department memoranda of 2002 that construed executive power so as to permit coercive interrogation; and the invasion of Iraq in March 2003, which President Bush's second inaugural address of January 2005 placed within a declared policy "to seek and support the growth of democratic movements and institutions in every nation and culture, with the ultimate goal of ending tyranny in our world." The parallel with *Serenity*'s opening classroom, in which the Alliance narrates its expansion as the bringing of civilization to worlds that did not ask for it, is close. The reading is legitimate but not exhaustive. Libertarian and conservative viewers have read the same Alliance as an indictment of the administrative and welfare state, and the corpus's target is broader than either reading: any technocratic paternalism convinced that its benevolence licenses the remaking of others, a disposition that has had liberal, conservative, and revolutionary incarnations alike.

3.3

The Machine in the Garden and the Law of Uneven Development

Leo Marx's *The Machine in the Garden* (1964) organized American pastoral around the "interrupted idyll," the moment—exemplarily, Hawthorne's notebook entry of 1844 in Sleepy Hollow—when a locomotive's whistle shatters the reverie of the landscape. "The Train Job" stages the idyll interrupted twice over: a steam train crossing open country is robbed by a spaceship hovering above it, the machine in the garden despoiled by a machine in the sky. The juxtaposition of horses and spaceships, six-shooters and hovercraft, which casual viewers took for a genre gimmick, is in fact a model of history. Trotsky's "law of uneven and combined development" (*History of the Russian Revolution*, 1930, ch. 1) held that backward regions do not repeat the stages of advanced ones but combine archaic and modern forms, as Russian peasant agriculture coexisted with some of the largest factories in Europe. The 'verse is uneven and combined development made visible: the gleaming towers of the Core and the cattle drives of the Rim are integrated by the same communications network and policed by the same cruisers.

Ernst Bloch's *Erbschaft dieser Zeit* (1935) drew the political consequence. Not all people, Bloch observed, live in the same Now; groups that inhabit the residue of older social forms carry "non-synchronous" contradictions—resentments and unfulfilled hopes from the past—that can be captured by reaction, as Bloch saw fascism capturing the German peasantry and petty bourgeoisie, or redeemed by a politics that recognizes the utopian surplus in their grievances. The Browncoats are Bloch's non-synchronous people. Their remainder can go either way. It can harden into revanchist myth, or it can preserve, in the form of a defeated cause, a hope that the victors' present has not fulfilled. The corpus's treatment of its own Confederate inheritance is the test of which way it goes.

3.4

The Killer Angels, the Lost Cause, and the Name of Jubal Early

Whedon has cited Michael Shaara's novel *The Killer Angels* (1974), a narrative of Gettysburg told from both sides, as a point of origin: the wish to follow soldiers of a defeated cause into the world after their war, drifting west. The structural borrowing raises what may be called the Lost Cause problem. Edward A. Pollard's *The Lost Cause* (1866) gave its name to a postbellum mythology that recast the Confederacy as a noble, doomed defense of constitutional liberty and agrarian virtue, overwhelmed by numbers rather than defeated in its principle, and that erased slavery from the account of the war's cause. The mythology's most tireless propagandist was General Jubal Anderson Early (1816–1894), who through his writings and his leadership of the Southern Historical Society did more than any other single figure to fix its canonical narrative.

The mythology's function was political, not merely nostalgic. As David W. Blight has shown (*Race and Reunion: The Civil War in American Memory*, 2001), the Lost Cause made reconciliation between white Northerners and white Southerners possible on terms that abandoned the citizenship of Black Americans, and it supplied ideological cover for the segregation and disenfranchisement that Southern legislatures imposed after Reconstruction. From 1894 the United Daughters of the Confederacy carried the narrative into monuments and school textbooks.

Firefly's most nihilistic antagonist, the bounty hunter of "Objects in Space," bears that name. Whether homage, private joke, or exorcism, the name has a precise effect within the corpus: its final episode personifies the Lost Cause as a bounty hunter who sells a fugitive girl back to the state that tortured her, and ends by casting him into the void. The Lost Cause is lost a second time. Mal, by contrast, never mythologizes his war. He remembers it as a wound rather than a glory; there is no anthem on his bridge and no flag; the brown coat functions less as a uniform than as a mourning garment. The difference between Malcolm Reynolds and Jubal Early is the difference between memory and myth—between a ship named Serenity and a cause named Glory.

The bounty hunter's office sharpens the point. What Early comes to do—seize a fugitive for a reward and return her to those who held her—is the office the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 imposed on the free states, under which federal commissioners decided the claims of those seeking to recover people who had escaped slavery and were paid more for ruling in the claimant's favor. The corpus never names chattel slavery, but the bounty hunter who comes for River bears the name of the man who labored hardest to erase slavery from the memory of the war.

The objection nonetheless stands, and Chapter 10 returns to it; the title of Evelyn Vaughn's essay "The Bonnie Brown Flag" (2007), which echoes the Confederate marching song "The Bonnie Blue Flag," registers the same connection. To code the defeated as Confederate-adjacent while deleting slavery from their cause repeats, structurally, the Lost Cause's own deletion; the casting of Zoe, a Black woman, as Mal's comrade in arms can be read as a reparative revision of Lost Cause iconography or as its alibi. The corpus displaces unfreedom onto other sites—the indentured mudders of Canton, the women treated as property in "Heart of Gold," the experimental subject of the Academy—and presents the Browncoat cause as self-government against unification. Section 3.7 argues that this presentation has a genealogy older and more radical than the Confederacy, and that the name the corpus gives its defeated army points to it.

3.5

A Comparative Grammar of the Western

John Ford's *Stagecoach* (1939), which Whedon has cited as a model for his ensemble, sends a coach across Apache country carrying a prostitute driven out of town, an alcoholic doctor, an escaped outlaw, a Southern gambler, a meek whiskey salesman repeatedly mistaken for a clergyman, an embezzling banker who lectures his fellow passengers on government interference, and an officer's pregnant wife. The correspondences with Serenity's company are visible, and so are the inversions:

the courtesan is the most respectable person aboard; the doctor is sober and exiled for his virtue; the clergyman is suspected of being something other than a clergyman. The faceless Apache threat that encircles Ford's coach is the template for the Reavers, with all that implies. Ford's coda, in which the doctor remarks that the outlaw and the prostitute have been spared the blessings of civilization, announces the ambivalence toward civilization that the corpus inherits.

Ford's *The Searchers* (1956) supplies Mal's dark double. Ethan Edwards, a Confederate veteran who would not surrender his saber, spends years hunting the Comanche who abducted his niece, intending to kill her as contaminated. Ethan is the soldier who refused the surrender and became a genocidal monomaniac: the Lost Cause as racial terror. Mal also refused the surrender, and the corpus's achievement is to have imagined that refusal without Ethan's hatred. His rescues of River invert Ethan's search: he protects the girl whom the 'verse regards as contaminated. Clint Eastwood's *The Outlaw Josey Wales* (1976) supplies the closest structural analogue: a Missouri farmer whose family is murdered by Union raiders, who rides with the bushwhackers, refuses to surrender, and goes west pursued, gathering a found family—an elderly Cherokee, a Navajo woman, a Kansan grandmother and her granddaughter—until he makes peace with the Comanche chief Ten Bears by recognizing a shared betrayal by governments. The corpus's third episode, "Bushwhacked," carries in its title the name of those Missouri guerrillas.

Ford's *The Man Who Shot Liberty Valance* (1962) ends with a newspaperman's resolution to print the legend rather than the fact. "Jaynestown" is its comic and finally grave rewriting: the mudders of Canton venerate Jayne as a Robin Hood because a strongbox he jettisoned to lighten his escaping ship fell among them, and Mal concludes that the legend matters less for what it says about Jayne than for what the mudders need from it. Eastwood's *Unforgiven* (1992), with its dime novelist manufacturing gunfighter legends and its prostitutes pooling their savings to put a bounty on the men who mutilated one of them, anticipates both "Jaynestown" and "Heart of Gold," in which Nandi's women hire Mal against Rance Burgess. Robert Altman's *McCabe & Mrs. Miller* (1971), in which a shrewd madam's frontier enterprise is crushed by a mining company, supplies Nandi's other ancestor. Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai* (1954) and its American remake *The Magnificent Seven* (1960) supply the siege structure of "Heart of Gold" and a coda the corpus internalizes: Kurosawa's surviving samurai conclude that the victory belongs to the farmers, not to them. The hired defenders are the remainder of their own victory. The Japanese word for the masterless samurai, *rōnin* (浪人), means literally "wave person," one who drifts on the waves; Serenity's crew are rōnin of the Black.

Sergio Leone's *The Good, the Bad and the Ugly* (1966) renders the American Civil War as absurd slaughter, a bridge fought over to no purpose, and in doing so supplies the visual grammar of Serenity Valley. Leone filmed his Westerns largely in the Andalusian deserts of Almería, in the same southern Spanish region that holds Córdoba—Roman Corduba, where Lucan was born. Sam Peckinpah's *The Wild Bunch* (1969) ends with outlaws outlived by modernity choosing a suicidal last stand; Serenity's crew make their last stand at Mr. Universe's complex and survive, and the difference is the corpus's refusal of the beautiful death. Fred Zinnemann's *High Noon* (1952) and its science-fiction transposition, Peter Hyams's *Outland* (1981), stage the marshal abandoned by his

community; in *Outland*, set on a mining colony on Io, the company distributes a drug that raises productivity before inducing psychosis—the two outcomes of the Pax prefigured in corporate form. Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979), finally, gave science fiction its working-class ship, a crew of haulers treated as expendable by distant capital, aboard a vessel named for Conrad's *Nostromo*, the great novel of imperial "material interests."

3.6

Epic and Romance: The Lucanian Western Defined

David Quint's *Epic and Empire* (1993) distinguishes two traditions of epic. The Virgilian epic of the victors narrates history as a linear teleology issuing in empire; the epic of the losers—Lucan's *Bellum Civile*, Ercilla's *La Araucana*, d'Aubigné's *Les Tragiques*—tends toward the open, episodic, wandering structure of romance. For the victors, history has a plot; for the defeated, history is a sequence of contingencies without a telos. Romance, on Quint's account, is the form of the vanquished.

Lucan's poem is the paradigm. It announces wars "more than civil" (*bella … plus quam civilia*, 1.1); it abolishes the divine machinery that Virgil had used to guarantee Rome's destiny, so that no god intervenes and history is left to force and fortune; it makes the defeated Cato its moral center, and marches him through a Libyan desert where serpents kill his soldiers in grotesque and inventive ways (Book 9); it stages, in the witch Erictho's reanimation of a corpse, a necromantic horror unmatched in classical poetry (Book 6); and it breaks off unfinished, its author forced to suicide by Nero in AD 65. Lucan's anti-providentialism is the silent Black; his grotesque is the Reaver; Cato's desert march is the crew's wandering; his unfinished poem is a cancelled series.

The Lucanian Western may accordingly be defined by five features: the defeated side of a civil war as moral center; the absence of providence; episodic, romance-like wandering in place of progress; violence that regenerates nothing; and the exposure, rather than the fulfillment, of the victors' telos. The series is a romance of the defeated in its very format. The job-of-the-week structure that network television imposed is, structurally, the errancy of romance: each episode a contingent adventure, no arc toward foundation. Cancellation completed the resemblance by leaving the series a fragment, like Lucan's poem or Spenser's *Faerie Queene*. The film then converts romance into epic, gathering the crew's drift into a single telos—Miranda—but it is an epic against epic. It ends not by founding an empire but by exposing one; its telos is a revelation, not a foundation.

3.7

The Independents: Putney, the Diggers, and Milton

The Browncoats are formally the Independents. In the English Civil War the Independents—congregationalists, the party of Cromwell and of much of the New Model Army—defended the

autonomy of local congregations against a national Presbyterian settlement and pressed for toleration. Their army debated its own political future at Putney in the autumn of 1647, where Colonel Thomas Rainsborough declared that "the poorest he that is in England hath a life to live, as the greatest he." Beyond them stood the Levellers, with their *Agreement of the People*, and in 1649 Gerrard Winstanley's Diggers, who dug the commons of St George's Hill on the principle that the earth had been made a common treasury for all (*The True Levellers Standard Advanced*). John Milton defended the liberty of unlicensed printing in *Areopagitica* (1644) and, on the eve of the Restoration, published *The Readie and Easie Way to Establish a Free Commonwealth* (1660)—a manifesto issued at the moment of defeat.

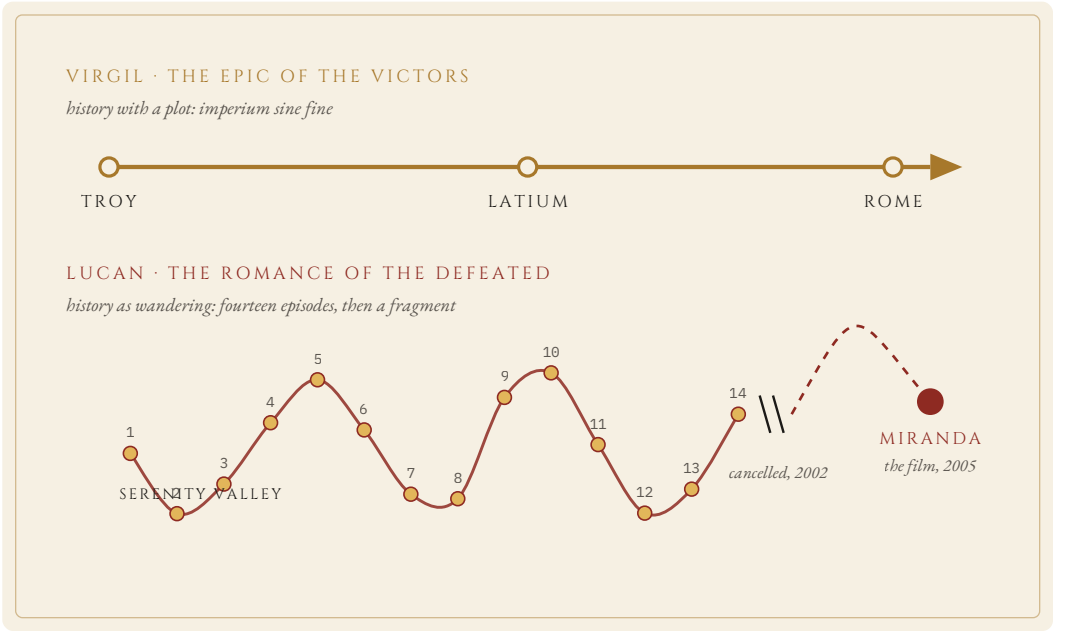
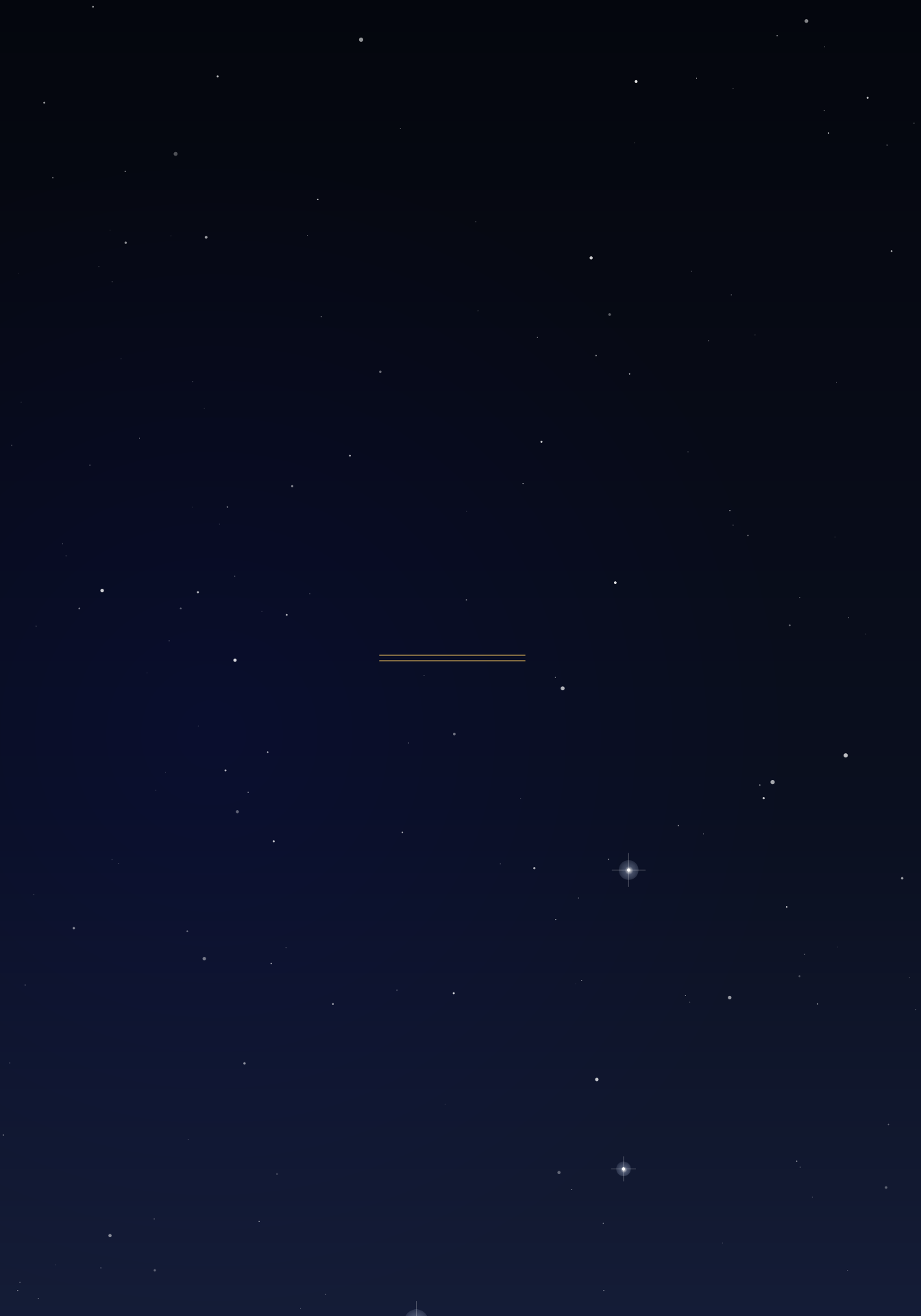


FIGURE 4 *Epic and romance.* After Quint (1993): the epic of the victors runs straight from catastrophe to empire; the epic of the defeated wanders episode by episode and breaks off. The film gathers the series' wandering into one line, which ends in a revelation rather than a foundation.

That radical-republican tradition passed, through the commonwealthmen of the eighteenth century, into the ideology of the American Revolution (Bailyn 1967), and Lucan was among its canonical texts: Thomas May's English translation of 1627 made the *Pharsalia* a republican scripture (Norbrook 1999). The Confederacy appropriated the rhetoric of 1776 for a slaveholding republic. The name *Independents* therefore reaches past the Confederacy to the lineage the Confederacy misappropriated. The proposition of this section is that the Browncoats are better understood as Independents in the Putney sense than as Confederates in the Lost Cause sense: partisans of local self-government against unification, whose defeated cause is integrated rather than racial, and whose corpus locates mastery in the Alliance's Academy and in the Rim's own tyrants rather than in the defeated. The objection of Section 3.4 is not thereby dissolved, but its terms are changed.

The question is no longer whether the show sanitizes the Confederacy but which of the traditions converging in its defeated army the show chooses to remember.

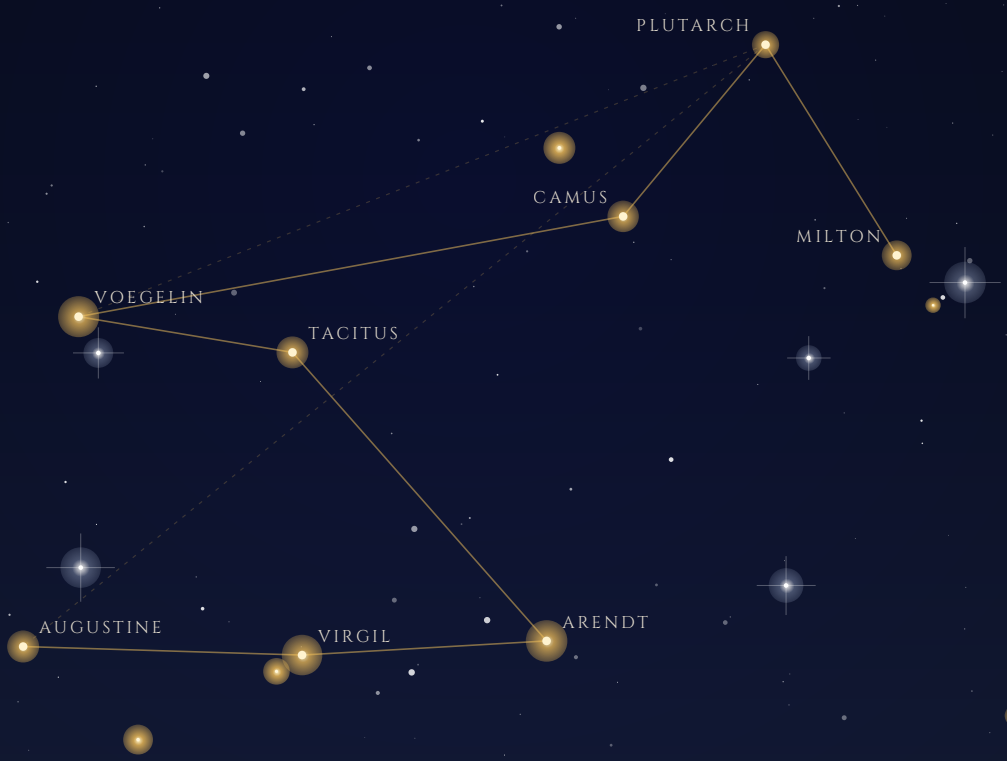


CHAPTER

IV

Imperium Sine Fine

The Alliance as Augustan Order



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER IV

The Alliance is not an evil empire in the manner of *Star Wars*. It does not delight in cruelty, and it does not know itself as wicked; it understands its expansion as the gift of peace and civilization to worlds that have not yet learned to want them. It is, in a word, Augustan. This chapter reads the Alliance through the Latin literature of empire—Virgil's mandate, Tacitus's indictment, Augustine's arithmetic—reads its Operative as a figure of imperial piety, and closes with Milton, whose epic of the defeated supplies both a typology of post-defeat politics and the corpus's own answer to it.

4.1

The Virgilian Classroom

In the first book of the *Aeneid*, Jupiter promises the descendants of Aeneas a dominion unlimited in space and time: *his ego nec metas rerum nec tempora pono: / imperium sine fine dedi*—"for these I set no bounds of place or period: I have given empire without end" (1.278–79). In the sixth, the shade of Anchises charges the Roman to rule the peoples with his power and names the Roman arts: *pacique imponere morem, / parcere subiectis et debellare superbos*—"to impose the custom of peace, to spare the subjected and to war down the proud" (6.852–53). Peace, in the Virgilian formula, is not found but imposed; it is a *mos*, a habit, laid upon peoples who must be taught it. The Alliance's pacifying agent bears the name of that imposition.

Serenity opens in a classroom. A holographic teacher recounts the founding history of the 'verse—Earth-That-Was could no longer sustain its population; the central planets formed the Alliance; the Alliance now brings the benefits of civilization to the outer worlds—and a young River objects that people do not like to be meddled with, that the Alliance is in their homes and in their heads without the right to be, that "we're meddlesome." The scene then dissolves: the classroom was a dream induced inside the Academy, and the student who objected is strapped to a table while the Alliance's scientists observe her. The pedagogical *Aeneid* is installed in the very subject being remade. The Alliance's founding myth is Virgilian in its structure. Earth-That-Was is Troy, the burned city whose survivors carried their household gods to a new land; the Central Planets are Latium; the Unification War is the war in Latium; the Browncoats are the Rutulians of Turnus, the inhabitants who resisted the settlers' destiny. The *Aeneid* ends with Aeneas killing the suppliant Turnus in a fury (12.938–52): the empire's founding act is the killing of the defeated who asks for mercy. Serenity Valley is the 'verse's version of that ending, and the series is what the *Aeneid* never narrates—the life of the Rutulians after the poem is over.

4.2

Londinium

The Alliance's capital world is called Londinium, the Latin name of the city founded around AD 47–50 as a Roman outpost in Britannia and burned in AD 60 or 61 by the rebels of Boudica. The toponym is a palimpsest of *translatio imperii*, the transfer of empire that medieval and early modern political theology traced from Babylon to Rome and from Rome to its successors. Rome's colonial town became the metropole of the British Empire; the British Empire's successor was the United States; and the successor of the United States—in the corpus, the Sino-American Alliance—is seated on a world named for Rome's colony. Its twin, Sihnon, Inara's home world, carries in its name an echo of the Sino- of Sino-American. The 'verse's two central worlds are thus Anglo and Sino, and the first of them wears the name by which the empire once called a frontier town at the edge of its known world. The colony that became the metropole now administers colonies of its own.

4.3

Calgacus at Serenity Valley

Before the battle of Mons Graupius in AD 83 or 84, Tacitus has the Caledonian chieftain Calgacus address his army (*Agricola* 29–32). The Caledonians, he tells them, are the last of the lands and the last of liberty—*nos terrarum ac libertatis extremos* (30.3)—protected until now by their very remoteness. The Romans are the robbers of the world (*raptores orbis*, 30.4), who, having exhausted the land, now ransack the sea; and the speech culminates in the sentence that serves as this dissertation's second epigraph: to rob, to slaughter, to plunder they misname empire, and where they make a desolation they call it peace. The Caledonians lost. Tacitus, son-in-law of the victorious general, gave the best speech of the work to the defeated. The double vision of the imperial historian—serving the empire, granting its enemies the most eloquent indictment of it ever written—is *Firefly*'s own position, a work produced within a media empire that gives its eloquence to the Rim.

The correspondences are exact. The Rim is Calgacus's last land of liberty, defended by distance, the friction of the Black; the Alliance is a robber of worlds whose expansion is narrated as pacification; and Miranda is the *solitudo*, the desolation made and called peace. The drug's name is not subtle, but its subtlety is not the point. Its point is that the Tacitean sentence, which in Tacitus is a metaphor for conquest, is in *Serenity* a literal description of a public-health measure.

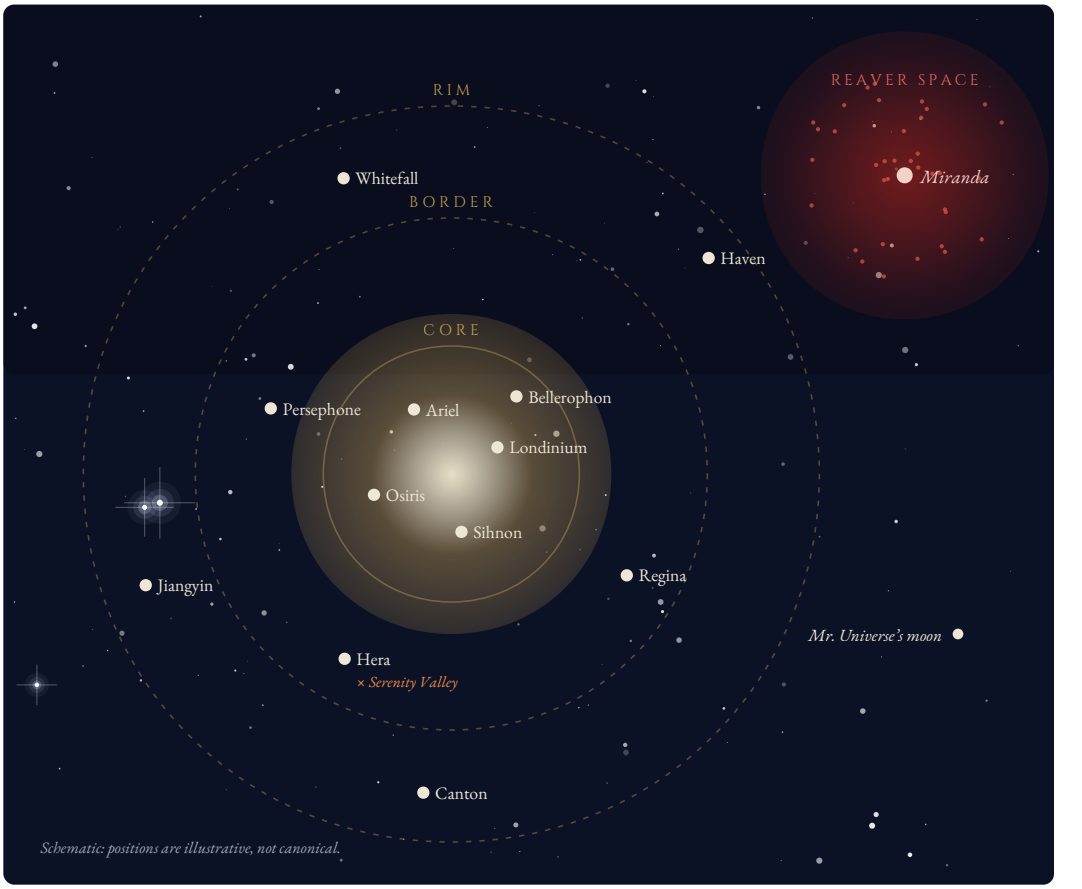


FIGURE 5 *The 'verse, schematically.* Worlds named in the series and the film, arranged by their relation to the Core. The rings are interpretive, not a canonical map; Miranda lies beyond Reaver space at the edge of the system.

4.4

The Operative: Pietas, Political Religion, and the City He Will Not Enter

The Operative describes himself as having no name and no rank—his identification names only an office, Operative of Parliament— he believes in a world without sin; he knows himself to be a monster and accepts that the better world he serves will have no place in it for him. He kills with a sword and frames his killings as honorable deaths. In the film's opening he paralyzes Dr. Mathias with a nerve strike and lets him fall on his upturned blade: the Roman death by the sword of Cato and Brutus, administered by the state to its own servant. His model is Aeneas. Virgil's hero is defined by *pietas*, a duty to gods, father, and fatherland that requires him to abandon Dido and to kill Turnus, and he never sees Rome, which will be founded generations after his death. Moses, too, sees the promised land from Pisgah and dies outside it (Deut. 34:4). The Operative is the

founder excluded from the foundation, and his self-exclusion is the guarantee of his sincerity: he does not kill in order to enjoy the world his killing makes.

Arendt's analysis of "Ideology and Terror," added to *The Origins of Totalitarianism* in 1958, identifies the structure. Ideology is the logic of an idea that claims to explain the total movement of history; terror is the execution of that movement's law, the removal of whatever obstructs it. The Operative is ideology's executor, not its theorist; he does not ask what the better world will be, only what stands in its way. Eric Voegelin had named the same structure from the side of theology. *Die politischen Religionen* (1938) read the modern mass movements as religions of the inner world, and *The New Science of Politics* (1952) diagnosed their characteristic operation as the immanentization of the eschaton: the transposition of Christian hope for the end of history into an innerworldly program to be completed by human hands. A world without sin is the eschaton immanentized. It is therefore fitting that Shepherd Book is the character who recognizes the Operative for what he is—a believer—and warns that he will not stop: it takes a theologian to recognize a political theologian.

Augustine supplies the arithmetic by which the corpus weighs the Operative's employer against its protagonist. *Remota itaque iustitia quid sunt regna nisi magna latrocinia?*—justice removed, what are kingdoms but great robberies? (*De civitate Dei* 4.4). Augustine illustrates with the pirate whom Alexander asked by what right he infested the sea, and who replied that because he did it with a small ship he was called a robber, while Alexander, doing it with a great fleet, was called emperor (*quia id ego exiguo navigio facio, latro vocor; quia tu magna classe, imperator*). Mal, with a small ship, is a thief; the Alliance, with a great fleet, is a government. The corpus does not conclude that the thief is therefore just; it concludes that the distinction between them cannot rest on the size of the fleet.

4 . 5

Refusing Cato

After the Caesarian victory at Thapsus in 46 BCE, Cato the Younger withdrew to Utica, read Plato's *Phaedo* twice through, and stabbed himself; when physicians bound the wound, he tore it open (Plutarch, *Cato Minor* 68–70). Seneca made the death a spectacle worthy of the gods (*De Providentia* 2.9–12) and the Stoic paradigm of freedom through death; Lucan made Cato the moral center of the defeated cause. The Lucanian tradition thus offers the defeated a single noble exit, and *Firefly* refuses it. Mal survives the surrender. He refuses, in the film, the dignified death the Operative offers his victims. He lives defeated, and the corpus treats that survival not as cowardice but as the harder and more serious choice.

Camus opened *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* by declaring suicide the one truly serious philosophical problem, and answered that the absurd man refuses it, because suicide accepts the verdict that revolt contests. Mal's closing words in the pilot—that being still in flight is enough—are the anti-Catonian ethic in its plainest form. The corpus extends the refusal to the deaths it does depict.

Wash dies abruptly, impaled through the cockpit glass seconds after his impossible landing, his last words unremarkable; Book dies among the ruins of a burning settlement. Neither receives the beautiful death of epic. The corpus withholds the *kalos thanatos* as firmly as it withholds the Catonian suicide, because both make death meaningful in a way that the Black does not permit.

4.6

Pandemonium and the Paradise Within

Milton's Satan, waking on the burning lake after his defeat, rallies his lieutenant with the question whether all is lost because the field is lost, and answers it with an appeal to the unconquerable will (*Paradise Lost* 1.105–06). The rhetoric is the rhetoric of Serenity Valley, and Mal's defiance has at moments a Satanic timbre. Milton refuses to endorse that rhetoric; so does the corpus. The council in Pandemonium (Book 2) offers instead a typology of post-defeat politics. Moloch counsels renewed open war. Belial counsels ignoble ease, the endurance of defeat in hope that the victor's wrath will cool. Mammon counsels the building of a rival kingdom in Hell from Hell's own riches, boasting that greatness will appear most conspicuous when it creates great things of small, useful of hurtful, prosperous of adverse (2.257–60). Beelzebub, voicing Satan's design, counsels indirect war through the corruption of the newly created world.

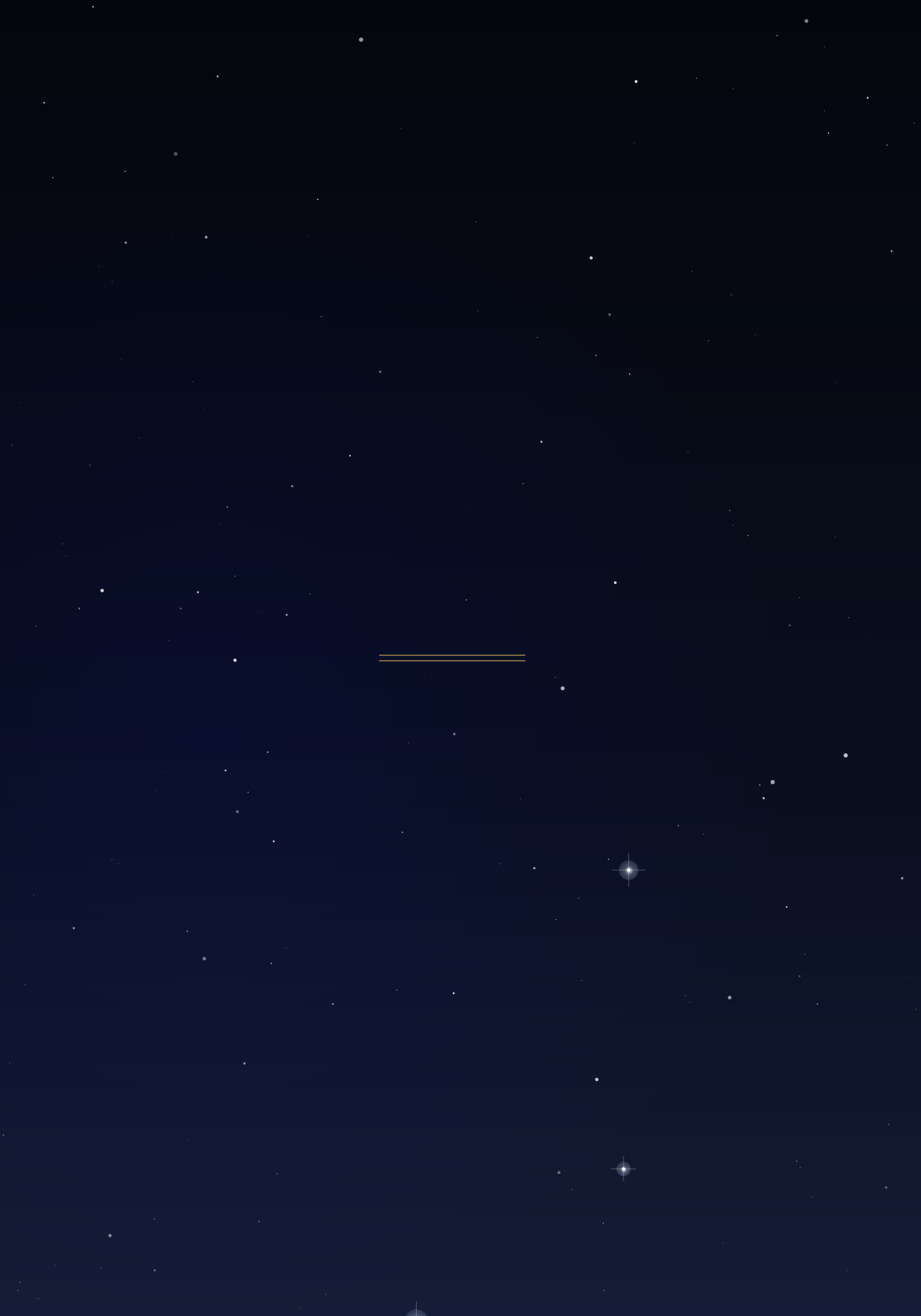
The Rim's politics after the Unification War map onto the council with some precision. Moloch's irredentism is largely absent from the series, and its absence is significant: there is no Browncoat underground. Belial's resignation is the condition of most of the Rim's population. Mammon's infernal enterprise is the career of Niska, of Badger, of Magistrate Higgins and Rance Burgess—the crime lords and local tyrants who built kingdoms from the war's wreckage. Beelzebub's subversion is the nearest to Mal's misbehavior, but Mal seeks to corrupt nothing. His position is not in Book 2 at all. It is in Book 12, in the archangel Michael's consolation to the expelled Adam—"A paradise within thee, happier far" (12.587)—and in the poem's final image of the pair who, "hand in hand with wand'ring steps and slow, / Through Eden took their solitary way" (12.648–49). Milton, blind and defeated after 1660, a partisan of the Independents in their ruin, resolved his epic of the defeated into an inner paradise and a wandering in the world. That resolution is the corpus's own: an inalienable sky within, and a ship without a harbor. The genealogy traced in Chapter 3 thus closes its circle. The Browncoats are Independents, and their poet is the Independent who lost.

PART TWO

The Biopolitical Core

Part Two turns from the corpus's inheritances to its center: the planet Miranda, the young woman who carries its secret, the forms of care that sustain the crew, the ship as a political form, and the Chinese philosophical archive that the 'verse invokes without reading.





CHAPTER

V

Miranda

Pax, Pharmakon, and the Dialectic of Enlightenment



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER V

Miranda is the corpus's center of gravity: the place where its existential, political, and theological concerns converge and are transformed. This chapter reads the revelation of *Serenity* through eleven lenses—biopower, the state of exception, the dialectic of enlightenment, the pharmakon, the death drive, the dystopian archive, the problem of the utopia built on a victim, Shakespeare's onomastics, the history of theodicy, and the Hobbesian theory of obligation—and argues that together they disclose a single structure: the attempt to produce a society without remainder, and the return of the remainder in monstrous form.

5.1

The Revelation

The crew reach Miranda by passing through Reaver space, and they find a world without ruin. Its cities are intact, its streets clean, its buildings undamaged. Its population of some thirty million colonists lies where it fell: in offices, in kitchens, on benches, in beds, unmarked by violence and long dead. In a sealed facility they recover the recorded testimony of Dr. Caron (played by Sarah Paulson), a member of the Alliance team sent to learn what had gone wrong. Her account is clinical and then desperate. The Alliance had introduced G-23 Paxilon Hydrochlorate into the planet's air processors to calm the population and weed out aggression. It worked. People stopped fighting; then they stopped working, stopped eating, stopped talking, stopped wanting anything at all, and lay down and died. In a tenth of one percent of the population the agent produced the opposite effect, raising aggression beyond madness, and those survivors became the Reavers. Before the recording ends, she insists, knowing she will not live to report it, that people must know the program was meant for the best, to make people safer—the plea of Niebuhr's children of light and of the logical crime Camus anatomized—and then they reach her. By the film's own figures the remainder was some thirty thousand people, a tenth of one percent of thirty million, set against nearly thirty million dead.

The crew carry the record to the moon of the information broker Mr. Universe, whose relay can broadcast it across the 'verse. The Operative murders Mr. Universe before the broadcast, but the dead man has left word of a backup transmitter, and his motto—"Can't stop the signal"—becomes the film's last argument. Mal holds the transmitter while the Alliance fleet and the Reaver armada he has lured into its path destroy one another overhead. The signal goes out. The Alliance does not fall. Its crime is now public, and the Operative, having watched the record, stands down. His last act in the film is to supply the medical aid and materials with which Serenity is repaired. He tells Mal that the broadcast has weakened the government and that he will try to persuade Parliament the Tams are no longer a threat, but he warns that they may be hunted anyway, in retribution. Every element of this sequence is philosophically overdetermined, and the remainder of this chapter takes them in turn.

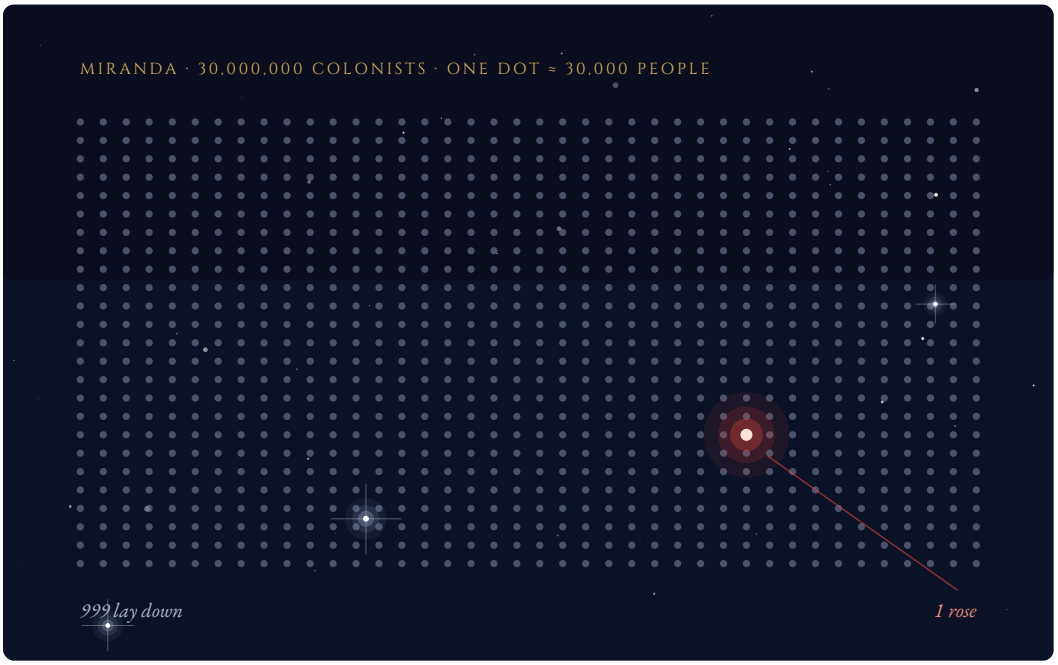


FIGURE 6 *The remainder.* By the film's own figures, the Pax killed some thirty million colonists by pacifying them, and turned a tenth of one percent, some thirty thousand people, into Reavers. Each dot stands for thirty thousand people.

5.2

Biopower and the Milieu

The final part of Foucault's *La Volonté de savoir* (1976) describes the transformation of sovereign power, defined by the right to take life or let live, into a power over life that fosters life or disallows it to the point of death. The lecture of 17 March 1976 at the Collège de France formulated the inversion as a shift from "make die and let live" to "make live and let die," and identified state racism as the caesura that biopower introduces into the biological continuum of the population to decide who must live and who may die. The lectures of 1977–78 (*Sécurité, territoire, population*) added the concept that most precisely describes the Pax: the *milieu*. Apparatuses of security, Foucault argued, do not act directly on individual bodies, as discipline does; they act on the environment in which a population lives, regulating the circulation of things, persons, and contagions.

The Pax is a technology of the milieu. It disciplines no one; it modifies the air. Peter Sloterdijk's *Luftbeben* (2002) dates the twentieth century from 22 April 1915, when German troops released chlorine gas at Ypres, and calls the new mode of violence *atmoterrorism*: the attack not on the body but on the conditions of the body's life, the environment it must breathe. The Pax is benevolent atmoterrorism, the Ypres principle administered by public-health officials. The corpus had prepared the insight. "Out of Gas" is an episode about air: Serenity's life support fails, and the crew's survival depends on the repair of a single part. In "Out of Gas" the air is a precarious com-

mons maintained by care; on Miranda it is an instrument of administration. The two episodes are inverse images, and between them lies the whole difference between the salvage polity and the Alliance. The Academy, meanwhile, retains the older disciplinary apparatus analyzed in *Surveiller et punir* (1975)—examination, observation, the dossier, the normalizing gaze—and River's recorded sessions are its archive.

5.3

The Camp-Planet and the Werewolf

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) begins from Carl Schmitt's definition of the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception (*Politische Theologie*, 1922) and from the Greek distinction between *zoē*, bare biological life, and *bios*, a qualified form of life. Its central figure, the *homo sacer* of archaic Roman law, is a life that may be killed without the killing counting as homicide and that cannot be sacrificed; its paradigm of modern sovereignty is the camp, "the nomos of the modern," a space in which the exception becomes the rule and political life is reduced to bare life. Miranda is a camp-planet: a world whose population was reduced to *zoē*, regulated at the level of breath by its own government, and then abandoned by that government, which concealed the planet behind Reaver territory and removed it from the public record.

Agamben's chapter on "The Ban and the Wolf" adds the figure that the Reavers incarnate. The outlaw of Germanic and Anglo-Saxon law was called *wargus* or *wulfesheafod*, wolf-man or wolf's head: a being who, excluded by the sovereign ban, inhabits a threshold between human and beast and may be killed by anyone. The Reavers are the sovereign's werewolves, produced by the sovereign decision and banished to the edge of the system. River is *homo sacer* in her own way, a life that any bounty hunter may seize. And the Operative, without name or rank, acting in a zone where law and violence are indistinguishable, is the state of exception in person.

The corpus shows the exception devouring its own servants. In "Ariel," after Jayne has sold Simon and River to the Alliance, two men in blue gloves arrive at the hospital, kill the Alliance officers who had taken the fugitives into custody with a device that causes fatal internal bleeding, and set out after the Tams. The secret apparatus answers to no law, not even that of its own state, and its first victims in the series are that state's own agents.

5.4

Enlightenment's Return to Myth

Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialektik der Aufklärung* (1944/1947) advanced two theses: myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology. The domination of external nature, pursued without limit, turns into the domination of human beings and finally of inner nature, the repression of drives in the name of self-preservation. The Pax is the domination of in-

ner nature completed by chemistry, and its product is myth in the most literal sense. The series introduces the Reavers as the stuff of campfire stories, half-believed in the Core; the film discloses that the boogeymen of the Rim were made in a laboratory. Enlightenment's highest achievement, the rational regulation of aggression, produced the monster of folklore.

The book's first excursus reads the *Odyssey* as the prehistory of bourgeois reason. Odysseus, bound to the mast, hears the Sirens' song while his rowers, their ears stopped with wax, row on; the master's enjoyment of art becomes impotent contemplation, and the workers' labor is purchased at the cost of their deafness. Odysseus's cunning before the Cyclops—his self-naming as "Nobody"—is self-preservation through self-effacement. *Serenity* inverts the scene. Its resolution is to unstop the rowers' ears: the knowledge the Alliance reserved for its masters is broadcast to everyone, and the signal is the Sirens' song released from the mast. The book's chapter on the culture industry finds its literalization as well. At the Maidenhead bar, a commercial for Fruity Oaty Bars carries a subliminal signal that triggers River's conditioning, and she disables a roomful of patrons; the advertisement is the delivery system of state programming, seeded by the Operative across the Alliance's commercial broadcasts to flush her out.

Two older formulations complete the diagnosis. Kant observed that out of timber so crooked as that from which man is made, nothing entirely straight can be built (*Idee zu einer allgemeinen Geschichte*, 1784, sixth proposition). Isaiah Berlin, who borrowed Kant's image for a late title (*The Crooked Timber of Humanity*, 1990), diagnosed in "Two Concepts of Liberty" (1958) the pathology of positive liberty: the division of the self into a "real" rational self and an empirical one, in whose name the empirical self may be coerced for its own liberation. Mal's credo, in his speech before the final assault, is that the Alliance will try again to make people better, and that he does not hold to that. It is Berlin's refusal in a frontier idiom. The Pax is positive liberty completed by chemistry: the liberation of a population's "true," peaceable self from its aggressive empirical self, carried through to the point where nothing empirical remained.

Karl Popper had drawn the same line from the side of liberal epistemology. *The Open Society and Its Enemies* (1945) opposed piecemeal social engineering, which attacks particular evils and learns from its mistakes, to utopian engineering, which remakes society according to a blueprint of the good and cannot learn, because the blueprint admits no error. The Alliance's better humanity is a blueprint, and Miranda is utopian engineering conducted on a planet, with no way back once the air has been changed.

5.5

Pharmakon and Pharmakos

Jacques Derrida's "La pharmacie de Platon" (1968; collected in *La Dissémination*, 1972) reads the myth of Theuth in the *Phaedrus*, in which writing is offered to the king as a *pharmakon* for memory and judged by him a poison. Derrida's argument turns on the word's undecidability—remedy and poison at once—and on its cognates: the *pharmakeus*, sorcerer or poisoner, an epithet

hurled at Socrates; and the *pharmakos*, the scapegoat expelled from the city in the Athenian Thargelia to purify it. The Pax is the *pharmakon* in its purest form: a remedy for aggression that is a poison for life itself. River is the *pharmakos*, the expelled and hunted girl who carries the city's secret in her body. Simon, the physician, is the *pharmakeus* whose love for his sister is also pharmacological; he sedates her, titrates her, manages her, and the corpus does not pretend that care and control can be wholly disentangled.

The series had already organized its moral economy around medicine. In "The Train Job" the crew steal a shipment of Pescaline D bound for the mining town of Paradiso, whose workers suffer from a degenerative disease contracted in the mines, and Mal returns it when he learns its purpose. In "Ariel" they rob a Core hospital, and Simon's scan of River's brain reveals that the Academy has stripped her amygdala. In "Safe," Simon is abducted by hill folk who need a doctor, and Book is saved because an Alliance identity card commands immediate treatment aboard a cruiser. In "Our Mrs. Reynolds" Saffron drugs Mal with her lips; in "The Message" a former comrade smuggles cultivated organs inside his own body; in "War Stories" Niska's torture is a medical procedure; in "Heart of Gold" Simon delivers a child under siege. Medicine is the currency of power in the 'verse, and the Pax is its sovereign coinage. Chapter 1's antithesis returns here at full scale: the Epicurean *tetrapharmakos* was philosophy as therapy; the Pax is pharmacology as government.

The *pharmakos* also appears in the series in its archaic form. In "Safe," the hill settlement whose leader, the Patron, has abducted Simon to serve as its doctor turns on River when her uncanny perceptions unsettle the villagers; the Patron and his people condemn her as a witch and bind her to a stake on a pyre. Simon climbs onto the pyre beside her, and Mal's crew arrive in time to stop the burning. The scapegoat rite that Derrida found beneath the Athenian festival is enacted on the frontier, and the corpus's answer to it—a brother who chooses to burn with his sister, and a crew who come back for both—is the salvage polity's first full appearance.

5.6

The Two Faces of the Death Drive

In *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920) Freud posited a drive that seeks to return the organism to an inorganic state, and named its tendency to reduce internal tension to zero the "Nirvana principle," borrowing the phrase from Barbara Low. In *Das Unbehagen in der Kultur* (1930) he argued that the same drive, turned outward, appears as aggression and destructiveness, and that civilization is the struggle between Eros, which binds living things into ever larger unities, and this drive to undo them. Civilization's price is the renunciation of aggression, paid in guilt and discontent.

The Pax splits the death drive into its two Freudian manifestations with diagrammatic exactness. In the 99.9 percent it realized the Nirvana principle—tension reduced to zero, desire extinguished, death. In the 0.1 percent it released the drive outward as destruction unbound. The Alliance attempted not to sublimate aggression but to abolish it, and Freud would have predicted the result: the repressed returns, and in the form most hostile to what repressed it. Herbert Marcuse's

Eros and Civilization (1955) distinguished the basic repression any civilization requires from the "surplus repression" imposed by a particular regime of domination. The Pax is surplus repression made atmospheric. Against it the corpus sets Eros: the binding force that, as Chapter 7 shows, circulates through Kaylee's love of the ship, Wash and Zoe's marriage, and the unconsummated intensity between Mal and Inara.

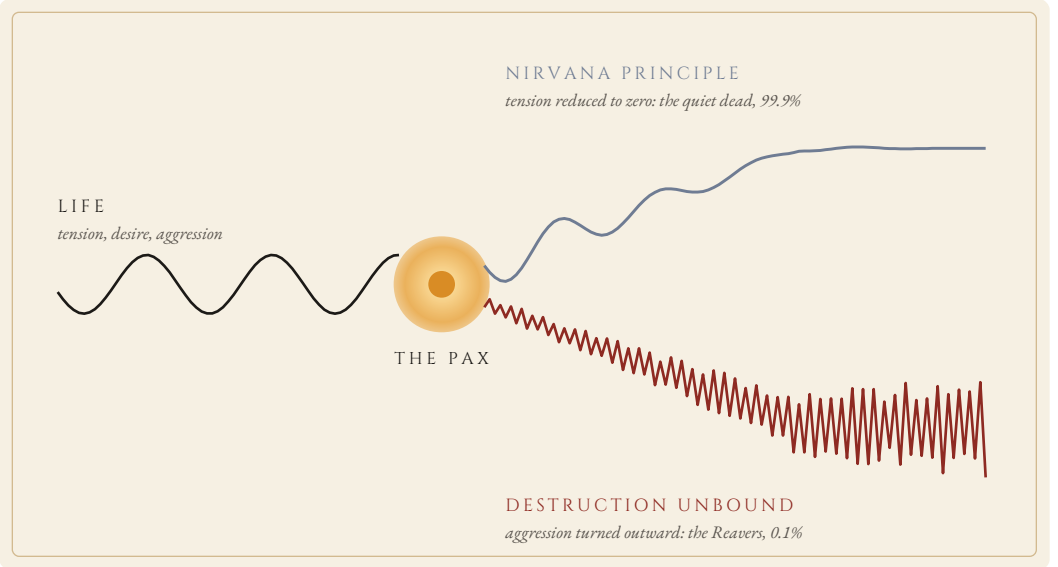


FIGURE 7 *The Pax and the death drive.* The agent splits Freud's death drive into its two forms: tension reduced to zero in the many, and destruction released outward in the few.

5.7

The Dystopian Archive

The corpus belongs to a tradition of dystopian fiction whose central question is the price of administered happiness. Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21, first published in English in 1924) opens with the One State's announcement that its spaceship, the *Integral*, will carry its mathematically infallible happiness to other planets and bring their inhabitants, who may still live in the savage condition of freedom, under the beneficent yoke of reason. The Alliance's mission to the outer worlds is the *Integral*'s mission. Zamyatin's state completes its project with the Great Operation, a surgical removal of the faculty of fancy that turns citizens into perfectly contented machines. River's surgery is its mirror image: the Academy removed not her imagination but her capacity to filter what she perceives, because it wanted a weapon rather than a citizen. The two operations converge on a single premise—that the soul is a technical object.

Aldous Huxley took the title of *Brave New World* (1932) from Miranda's line in *The Tempest*, and his World State governs through soma, the drug that provides a holiday from reality. His Savage, raised on Shakespeare, ends by claiming before the World Controller the right to be unhappy.

The Pax is soma perfected: no longer a holiday from reality but a permanent holiday from life. In Anthony Burgess's *A Clockwork Orange* (1962) the Ludovico Technique conditions the violent Alex into incapacity for violence, and the prison chaplain objects that goodness which is not chosen is not goodness, and that a man who cannot choose has ceased to be a man. The Pax is the Ludovico Technique administered to a planet. Orwell's Party proclaimed that war is peace; the Alliance named its lethal agent after peace, and the corpus records the result.

Two further precedents deserve special notice. Cordwainer Smith was the pen name of Paul Linebarger, a Sinologist, godson of Sun Yat-sen, and author of the standard manual *Psychological Warfare* (1948), whose science fiction imagined a far future of Sino-Western fusion governed by the Instrumentality of Mankind. In "Scanners Live in Vain" (1950), space travelers have their sensory nerves surgically severed to endure the Great Pain of Space; in the later stories the Instrumentality, finding that a perfected and painless humanity has grown listless, undertakes a "Rediscovery of Man," deliberately reintroducing risk, disease, old languages, and unhappiness ("Alpha Ralpha Boulevard," 1961). Smith had imagined, forty years before *Serenity*, both a Sino-Western future and the lesson of Miranda. Iain M. Banks's Culture novels (*Consider Phlebas*, 1987; *Use of Weapons*, 1990), finally, describe a post-scarcity utopia whose section Special Circumstances performs the dirty work of benevolent intervention in less developed civilizations. The Operative is an agent of Special Circumstances in the service of a benevolence that is post-freedom rather than post-scarcity. And *Star Trek*'s Prime Directive, forbidding interference in the development of other cultures, names exactly what the Alliance lacks; River's "we're meddlesome" is the Prime Directive's complaint voiced from the receiving end.

5.8

The Grand Inquisitor at the Far-Off Edge of Things

In Dostoevsky's *Brothers Karamazov* (1880), Ivan's Grand Inquisitor reproaches the returned Christ for having burdened humanity with freedom. The Church has corrected his work: it gives the masses bread, miracle, mystery, and authority, and they are happy as children, while the few who govern them bear alone the unhappy knowledge of good and evil. The Operative is the Inquisitor's servant. He too bears the knowledge so that others need not, and he too has excluded himself from the happiness he administers. The chapter that precedes the legend, "Rebellion," supplies the answer the corpus gives him: Ivan refuses any future harmony purchased with the tears of a single tortured child and respectfully returns his ticket.

William James restated the problem in "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891). If we were offered a world in which millions were kept permanently happy "on the one simple condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture," James argued, an independent moral emotion would make us feel how hideous the enjoyment of that happiness would be. Ursula K. Le Guin made James's thought experiment into a parable, "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), in which a radiant city's happiness depends on the

misery of a single child kept in a basement, and some citizens, having seen the child, quietly leave. River is the child in the basement of the Core's prosperity, kept beneath the gleaming worlds where her parents dine. Simon is the one who walks away: he abandons wealth, career, family, and the Core itself to retrieve her. And James's phrase locates the victim precisely where the corpus does: on the far-off edge of things, which is to say on the Rim.

5.9

This Thing of Darkness: The Tempest

Two worlds of the 'verse, Ariel and Miranda, bear the names of characters from *The Tempest*—names that Shakespeare's play had already lent to moons of Uranus. Miranda's first speech in the play is a lament for a shipwreck she has watched from the shore: she has suffered with those she saw suffer (1.2). Her most famous exclamation comes when she first sees the shipwrecked courtiers—"O brave new world, / That has such people in't!"—and her father's reply is four dry words: "'Tis new to thee" (5.1). Huxley took his title from that exclamation; the planet Miranda is the brave new world in Huxley's sense, the world made new by those who believed they knew what people should be.

Ariel is the spirit whom the witch Sycorax confined in a cloven pine for twelve years, and whom Prospero released into a service from which Ariel begs, again and again, for liberty (1.2). River is Ariel: a being of extraordinary powers imprisoned by one master and "freed" by another whose care is also governance; and the episode titled "Ariel" takes the crew to the planet of that name, where the theft that funds their survival discloses what was done to her brain. Caliban, the island's dispossessed native, tells Prospero that he was taught language and that his profit from it is that he knows how to curse (1.2). Chapter 9 argues that the Rim's use of Mandarin, chiefly for profanity, is Calibanic speech. Prospero's final acknowledgment of Caliban—"this thing of darkness I / Acknowledge mine" (5.1)—names exactly what the Alliance refused for a generation and what the broadcast compels: that the Reavers are its own. Prospero's abjuration of his art ("this rough magic / I here abjure," 5.1) is echoed in the Operative's standing down.

The postcolonial afterlife of *The Tempest*—Octave Mannoni's *Psychologie de la colonisation* (1950), George Lamming's *The Pleasures of Exile* (1960), Aimé Césaire's *Une tempête* (1969), Roberto Fernández Retamar's "Calibán" (1971)—read Caliban as the colonizer's creation rather than the island's native monstrosity. Frantz Fanon had argued in *Les Damnés de la terre* (1961) that the colonist fabricates the colonized subject he claims to have found. The film's revision of the Reavers' origin literalizes Fanon: the "savage" of the frontier was manufactured by the civilization that feared him.

5.10

From Lisbon to Miranda

Susan Neiman's *Evil in Modern Thought* (2002) organizes the history of modern philosophy around the problem of evil and two catastrophes that structure it: the Lisbon earthquake of 1755, paradigm of natural evil, which shattered the confidence of Leibnizian theodicy; and Auschwitz, paradigm of a moral evil so administratively produced that it outran the categories of intention and guilt. In the debate that followed Lisbon, Rousseau answered Voltaire's despairing poem with an observation that relocated the problem: nature had not assembled twenty thousand houses of six and seven stories in that place (letter of 18 August 1756). The suffering was social before it was natural. Neiman credits Rousseau with the first move by which modern thought transferred the problem of evil from God and nature to human institutions.

The corpus's revision of the Reavers recapitulates that transfer. In the series, the Reavers are a Lisbon-type evil: the void maddens those who stare into it, and the cosmos is simply hostile. In the film, they are a Miranda-type evil: administered, authored, concealed. The revision is not a continuity patch but a philosophical event, and its consequence is practical. What is produced politically can be refused politically. The cosmos cannot be held to account; a government can. The film's turn from serenity to courage—from the first petition of Niebuhr's prayer to the second—follows directly from the discovery that the Reavers have authors. What Miranda demands is not a theodicy but an anthropodicy: an accounting of human, and specifically state, responsibility.

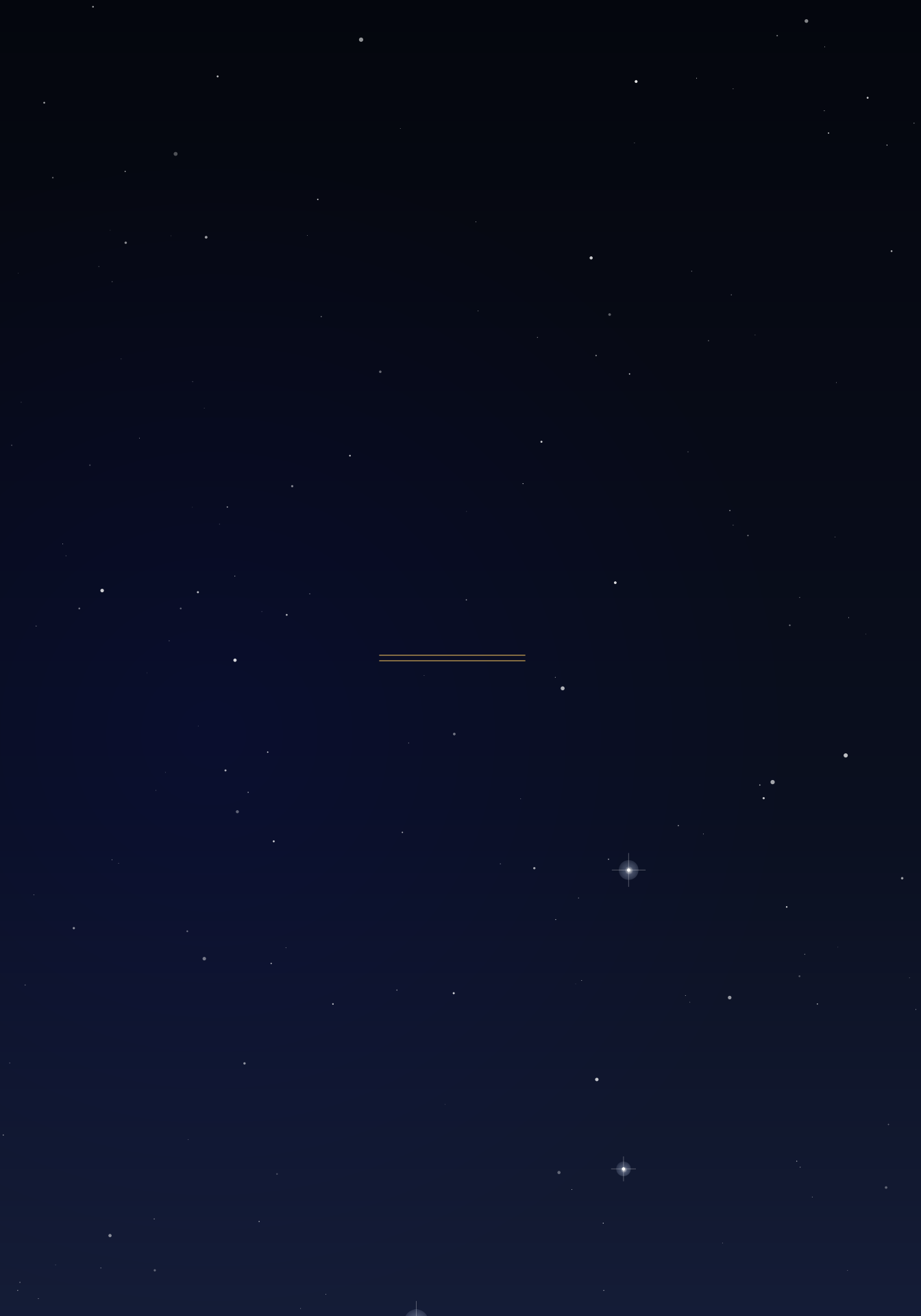
5.11

The Autoimmune Leviathan

Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) grounds sovereignty in the escape from a condition of war in which the life of man is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short" (ch. 13). Subjects surrender their liberty to the sovereign in exchange for protection, but two limits survive the exchange. "A covenant not to defend myself from force, by force, is always void" (ch. 14); and "the obligation of subjects to the sovereign is understood to last as long, and no longer, than the power lasteth by which he is able to protect them" (ch. 21). Carl Schmitt compressed the principle into a formula he called the *cogito ergo sum* of the state: *protego ergo obligo* (*Der Begriff des Politischen*, 1932).

Two Hobbesian conclusions follow, and neither favors the Alliance. On the Rim, where the Alliance protects no one from Reavers, crime lords, or local tyrants, the obligation of its subjects lapses by Hobbes's own logic; Mal's disaffection is not anarchism but Hobbesian consistency. On Miranda the sovereign turned its power against the lives it existed to protect, and the covenant was dissolved not by the subjects but by the sovereign. Jacques Derrida's late concept of autoimmunity (*Voyous*, 2003)—a living system that destroys its own protections—names the result. The Alliance is an autoimmune Leviathan. It manufactured the war of all against all that sovereignty exists to

prevent, released it at the edge of its system, and then governed the Rim in part through the terror its own creation inspired, without acknowledging authorship. The Reavers are the state of nature as a state product, and in that inversion the political philosophy of the corpus reaches its sharpest point.

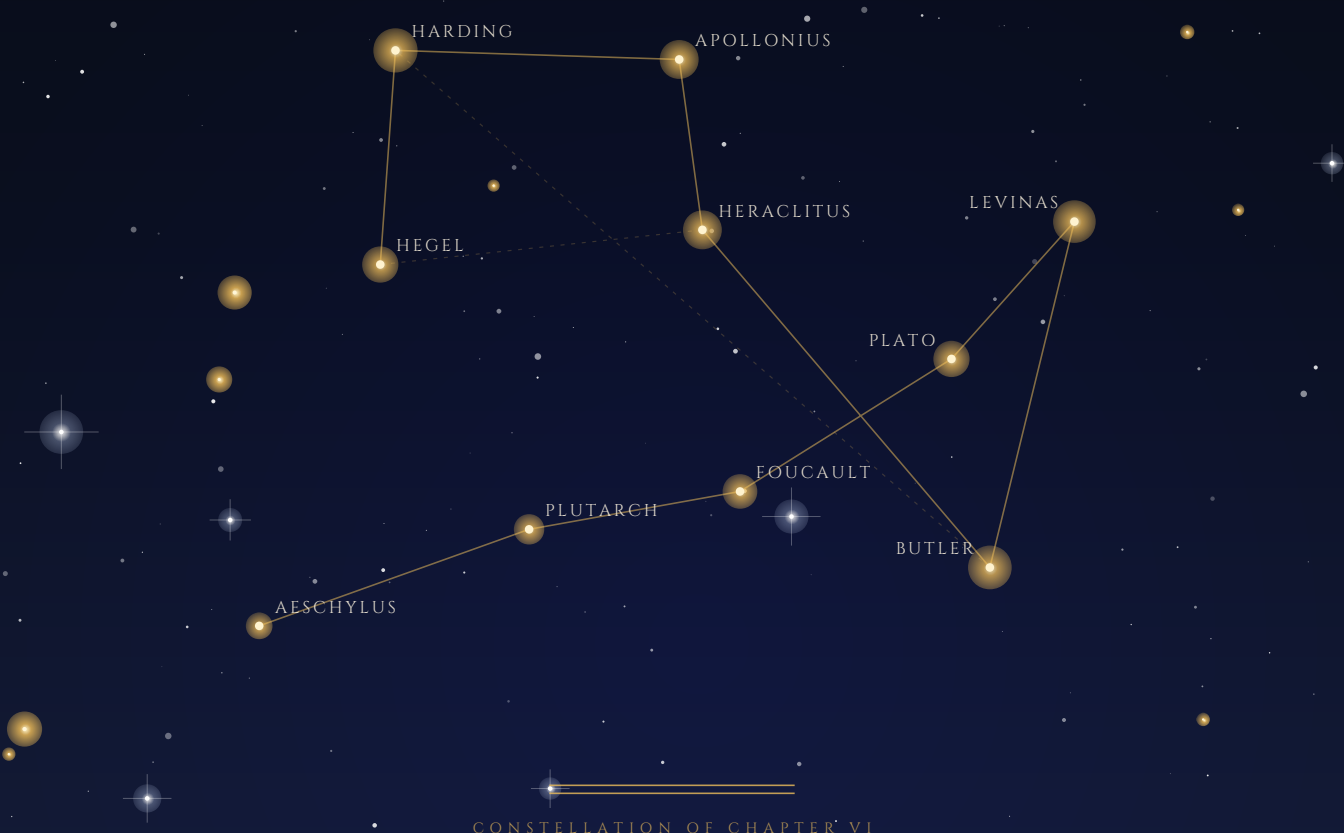


CHAPTER

VI

River

The Oracle, the Weapon, and the Ship of Fools



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER VI

River Tam is the corpus's most concentrated figure of the remainder: the subject whom the Alliance tried to perfect as an instrument and who survived as a knower. This chapter reads her through the history of madness and its confinement, Heraclitean oracularity, the epistemology of the damaged, the Cold War genealogy of brainwashing, the myths of Osiris and Antigone, Levinas's ethics of the face, and the speaking timber of the Argo. Its thesis is that River's damage is the condition of her knowledge, and that the corpus's central truth can be known only by the subject the system broke.

6.1

From the Great Confinement to the Ship of Fools

Foucault's *Histoire de la folie* (1961) opens with the *Narrenschiff*—Sebastian Brant's satirical poem of 1494, Bosch's painting, and behind them a historical practice in which the mad were entrusted to boatmen and sent along the rivers of the Rhineland and Flanders. The madman, in Foucault's account, became the passenger par excellence, a prisoner of the passage itself, and water and madness were bound together in the European imagination for centuries. The book then narrates the end of that regime: the Great Confinement inaugurated by the founding of the Hôpital Général in Paris in 1656, in which the age of reason enclosed unreason within walls.

The Academy is a Great Confinement conducted with neurosurgery. Simon breaks his sister out of it by shipping her as cargo in a cryogenic box, and she wakes aboard a wandering vessel. Her trajectory reverses the history Foucault narrated, from confinement back to the ship of fools. That the mad girl on the wandering ship is named River is a coincidence the corpus never remarks and the interpreter cannot ignore: she bears the name of the medium along which the mad were once sent. Brant's satire mocked its ship's passengers; the corpus reverses the valuation in a Pauline register, according to which the foolish things of the world were chosen to confound the wise (1 Cor. 1:27). Serenity's company of fools confounds the wisdom of the Core.

6.2

A Heraclitean Subject

Heraclitus supplies River's philosophical idiom. "It is not possible to step twice into the same river" (DK B91): the subject of flux, never identical with itself from one moment to the next, is River's condition after the Academy, her lucidity and her dissociation alternating without warning. "The lord whose oracle is at Delphi neither speaks out nor conceals, but gives a sign" (B93): River's speech is semiotic in exactly this sense. Her fragments—"two by two, hands of blue," a rhyme that names the gloved agents hunting her—neither declare nor withhold; they signify, and the crew must interpret. "Nature loves to hide" (B123); "a hidden harmony is stronger than a visible one" (B54). The Pax is a visible harmony, imposed; River is a hidden one, a coherence that ap-

pears as disorder to those who cannot read it. "War is the father of all" (B53): River was fathered by war, made by the Academy as a weapon. And yet "character is a person's *daimon*" (B119): her character survives the making, and it is her character, not her conditioning, that decides what she does with what she knows.

6 . 3

Cassandra, the Pythia, and the Standpoint of the Broken

In Aeschylus's *Agamemnon* (458 BCE), Cassandra, the captive prophetess cursed never to be believed, stands at the door of the house of Atreus and sees the blood within. River's warnings are similarly unheeded until they come true. Plato's Socrates, in the *Phaedrus*, insists that the greatest goods come to us through madness, when it is given as a divine gift (244a), and cites the prophetesses of Delphi and Dodona, who accomplished much good in their madness and little or nothing in their right minds. River's madness is given not by a god but by an institution; inspired mania is secularized as engineered damage. It nonetheless yields truth. Dostoevsky's holy fool, Prince Myshkin of *The Idiot* (1869), whose epileptic illness is bound up with moments of transcendent clarity, is a further ancestor.

Feminist standpoint epistemology supplies a modern account of why damage might confer knowledge. Nancy Hartsock (1983) and Sandra Harding (*Whose Science? Whose Knowledge?*, 1991) argued that subordinated positions can be epistemically privileged, because those who occupy them must understand both their own world and the world of those who dominate them, while the dominant need understand only their own; Harding called the resulting standard "strong objectivity." River knows Miranda because the Alliance displayed her, as a prize of its program, before members of the Alliance Parliament who held the secret, and she read it from their minds. The Operative, whose identification names only his office, Operative of Parliament, executes the doctor who ran her program, Dr. Mathias, for the breach. The secret entered her through the very procedure that made her a weapon. This is the corpus's epistemology of the broken: the remainder knows what the totality conceals, and it knows it precisely because it is the remainder.

6 . 4

Brainwashing: The Calque Comes Home

The English word *brainwashing* is a calque of the Chinese *xǐnǎo* (洗腦), introduced into American usage by the journalist Edward Hunter in a newspaper article of September 1950 and in his book *Brain-Washing in Red China* (1951). It named a Cold War terror: that Chinese "thought reform" could remake the minds of captured Americans. Richard Condon's novel *The Manchurian Candidate* (1959), filmed by John Frankenheimer in 1962, gave the terror its narrative form—an American prisoner programmed in Manchuria to kill on cue, his conditioning triggered by the sight of

the queen of diamonds. The American state's response included its own program of research into mind control, MKUltra, conducted by the Central Intelligence Agency from 1953 to 1973.

Serenity fuses the fear with its object. River is the Manchurian Candidate of a Sino-American state; the Fruity Oaty Bar commercial is her queen of diamonds; and the dread that America projected onto China is enacted by an Alliance that is both. The calque comes home. The figure also belongs to a pattern across Whedon's work, in which institutions manufacture weaponized young women: the Shadow Men who created the first Slayer by chaining a girl and forcing a demon's essence into her body against her will (*Buffy the Vampire Slayer*, "Get It Done," 2003), the Initiative of *Buffy*'s fourth season, the Actives of *Dollhouse* (2009–10). River is the pattern's most explicitly biopolitical instance, a lineage Michael Marano traced in "River Tam and the Weaponized Women of the Whedonverse" (2007), and Chapter 10 considers whether the corpus critiques the fantasy of the engineered female weapon or indulges it.

The pattern's cost should be named plainly in River's case. By Simon's account in the pilot she was fourteen when she was sent to the Academy, which her parents believed to be an elite school for gifted children. What was done to her there—repeated neurosurgery and conditioning to which she could not consent, carried out by the Academy's staff under Dr. Mathias in a program the Alliance government sponsored and members of its Parliament visited—was done to a child, and her coded letters to Simon were the only report of it to reach the outside. "War Stories" shows the product. During the rescue of Mal from Niska's station, River takes up a gun and kills three of Niska's men with her eyes closed while Kaylee watches in horror. The scene is staged as a revelation of competence, and its horror is the cost of that competence.

6.5

Osiris and Antigone: Simon's Labor

The Tams come from the Core world of Osiris. In Plutarch's *De Iside et Osiride*, Seth dismembers Osiris and scatters the pieces, and Isis, the god's sister and consort, searches them out and gathers them to restore him. Simon's labor is Isis's, without its conjugal dimension: the patient reassembly of a mind the Academy fragmented, conducted through scans, diagnoses, drug trials, and long observation. The sibling dyad at the heart of the corpus thus reaches back to the oldest Mediterranean myth of a sister restoring a dismembered brother, with the roles reversed.

The reversal points to a second myth. Sophocles's Antigone defies Creon's edict to bury her brother; Hegel's reading in the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) made her the bearer of the divine law of the family against the human law of the state, and called the bond of brother and sister the purest ethical relation, because unmixed with desire. Simon is a male Antigone. He defies the state for his sibling, choosing the law of kinship over the law of the polis, and the flashbacks of "Safe" show that the choice divided his own family: his father refused to credit the coded warnings in River's letters from the Academy and refused to help. Judith Butler's *Antigone's Claim* (2000) argued that Antigone's act unsettles both the authority of the state and the norms of kinship it pre-

supposes. Simon's act does the same. He becomes a fugitive from his class as well as his government, and his walking away from Omelas is the corpus's founding gesture.

6 . 6

The Face That Cannot Be Unfelt

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totalité et infini* (1961) opens with the observation that war suspends morality and reveals being as totality, a system in which every individual is reduced to a function of forces that exceed it. Against totality Levinas sets the face of the other, which resists every system and expresses, before any choice of mine, an ethical command not to kill. *Autrement qu'être* (1974) radicalized the account: the self is a hostage to the other, responsible before it is free, constituted by a substitution it did not choose.

The Academy stripped River's amygdala, and she can no longer filter what others feel. She is a literal hostage of every face, exposed without defense to the interiors of everyone near her. Her madness is the ethical relation without defenses, a Levinasian vulnerability made into pathology and then, under pressure, into knowledge. The Alliance is totality in Levinas's precise sense, a system that reduces persons to their function in a project; River is the infinite that breaks through it. In the film's climax the relation between the siblings reverses. River, who has been carried, steps through the blast doors to face the Reavers so that Simon, wounded, may live, telling him that he has always taken care of her and that it is now her turn. The hostage of every face becomes the one who answers for another.

Philip K. Dick imagined the voluntary version in *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968), whose citizens grip the handles of an "empathy box" to share in the suffering of the martyr Mercer, and let go when they choose. River cannot let go of the handles.

6 . 7

The Speaking Beam

In the *Argonautica* of Apollonius of Rhodes, Athena fits into the Argo's stem a beam of oak from Dodona, the oracle-grove of Zeus (1.524–27). In the fourth book the beam speaks, announcing Zeus's anger at the crew's crime—the murder of Medea's brother Apsyrtus—and directing them to seek purification from Circe (4.580–91). The first ship of Greek legend thus carried an oracle in its timber, and the oracle's office was to name the crew's guilt.

In "Objects in Space" River claims to have become the ship and speaks through it. She is Serenity's speaking beam: the oracle built into the vessel, its conscience and its sign. The Argo's beam named the crew's crime; River's voice names Early's and, in the film, the Alliance's. At the end of *Serenity* River takes the pilot's seat that Wash's death left empty, and the film's last images place the oracle at the helm. The ship of fools is now steered by the fool whose knowledge saved it.

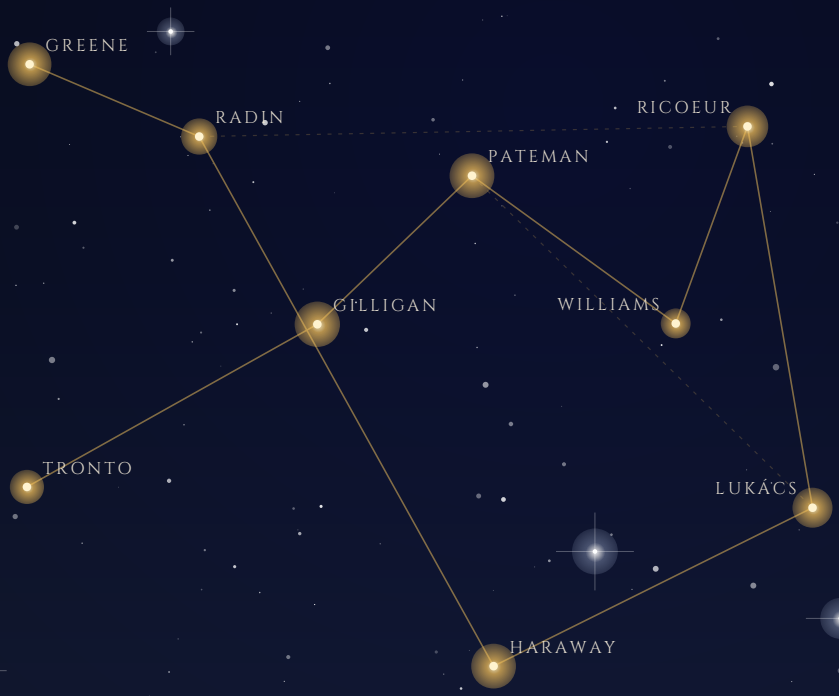
Chapter 8 returns to that image by way of Plato, whose parable of the ship of state reserves the helm for a stargazer the crew despise.

CHAPTER

VII

Companions, Shepherds, Mechanics

The Economy of Care



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER VII

If the Alliance governs by administering life, the crew survives by caring for it, and the corpus distributes that care among figures whose vocations the 'verse ranks very differently: a licensed courtesan, a preacher with a hidden past, a mechanic, a doctor, a confidence artist who parodies care in order to exploit it. This chapter reads each as a distinct modality of care and argues that their economy, rather than the captain's authority, is the true medium of the polity theorized in Chapter 8.

7.1

Inara and the Sexual Contract

The Companion Guild is a licensed, hierarchical, and honored institution. Companions are trained from youth in the arts of conversation, ceremony, music, and pleasure; they are registered and certified; and, crucially, they choose their clients. Inara's presence aboard Serenity confers a respectability the ship otherwise lacks, opening ports that would be closed to a smuggler, and Mal exploits that respectability even as he disparages its source. The figure is a composite of several historical types: the Athenian *hetaira*, of whom Aspasia, to whom Plato's *Menexenus* playfully attributes Pericles's funeral oration, is the emblem; the learned courtesans of Tang China, of whom the poet Xue Tao is the most celebrated; the *cortigiane oneste* of sixteenth-century Venice, of whom Veronica Franco was a poet of distinction. The Companion gathers into one institution the courtesan's double status, at once commodity and cultural authority.

Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) argued that the social contract of classical political theory presupposes a prior sexual contract establishing men's political right over women, and that prostitution is the public face of that right: the sale of access to a woman's body under the fiction of a contract between equals. The Guild may be read as an attempt to imagine the sexual contract rewritten, with the woman as the party who chooses and confers favor. The series tests the rewriting at its limit. In "Shindig," Atherton Wing seeks to convert Inara's contract into possession, to make her his permanent companion, and Mal fights a duel to defend her right to refuse—ironically, as the man who calls her a whore. In "War Stories" her client is a female councilor, and the Guild's economy appears unbound from the heterosexual frame that Pateman analyzed.

The critique remains forceful. The Companion is a fantasy of respectable sex work that abstracts from the coercions—economic, familial, institutional—that structure sex work everywhere else; the film shows Inara teaching young girls at a Companion training house, which places the start of the Guild's training in childhood for a profession that includes sexual service, and the film presents the house as a refuge without registering that fact; and the phrase "space hooker," adopted in the subtitle of the first collection of essays on the series, names the male fantasy the figure can serve. Mal's own contempt, finally, is not a critique of the Guild but a symptom: the Rim's puritanism, laced with jealousy. The corpus allows each of these readings and does not resolve them. What it insists upon is narrower and firmer: that Inara's sovereignty over her own person is real, and that every attempt in the series to convert her into property is defeated.

7.2

"Heart of Gold": The Brothel as Polis

Nandi, a former Companion who left the Guild to run a brothel on a frontier moon, summons Inara's help when Rance Burgess, the local magnate, claims as his own the child one of her women, Petaline, is carrying. Burgess's men drag the heavily pregnant Petaline out of the house so that he can take a DNA sample, and when the test confirms his paternity he moves to take the child. Inara tells Mal plainly that Nandi's women are whores, not Companions: outside the Guild, and therefore outside its protection. Nandi explains that Burgess keeps the town poor so that he can live out his fantasy of the Old West, and her own house has a history of liberation: she took it over from a man who kept half its workers dependent on drugs. Mal's crew defend the house through a siege. As Petaline gives birth, one of Nandi's women, Chari, lets Burgess in; Nandi and Inara take the newborn back, and Burgess shoots Nandi dead with his laser pistol. Mal rides down Burgess's fleeing hovercraft on horseback, knocks him out, and brings him back to the house, where Petaline shoots him dead.

The house is a commune of women and men in the sex trade: self-governing, mutual, armed, a polity whose sovereignty depends on its members' control of their own bodies and of what those bodies produce, and the episode gives the final act of that sovereignty to the mother whose child was claimed. Burgess embodies the perversion of the Lockean idea of property in one's person into a claim of property in another's: the child is his because his genes are in it, and its mother is the vessel of his claim. The genetic test is biopower in miniature, the body read as a title deed, and the drug dependency from which Nandi freed her house is Chapter 5's economy of the *pharmakon* at the scale of a brothel. The chase reverses Leo Marx's figure, the machine fleeing and the horse in pursuit. The episode's precedents are those discussed in Chapter 3—*McCabe & Mrs. Miller*'s madam crushed by a mining company, *Unforgiven*'s prostitutes pooling their wages against the men who mutilated one of them—but its political imagination is its own.

Nandi is Mal's double. Each lost an institution—she the Guild, he the army—and each built in its place a small polity of chosen companions on the frontier. Mal sleeps with her, and Inara, wounded, announces at the episode's end that she will leave the ship. The brothel and the ship are the corpus's two salvage polities, and the destruction of the first by a local tyrant measures the precariousness of the second.

7.3

Saffron: The Protean Negative

In "Our Mrs. Reynolds" Mal discovers, after a festival on the planet Triumph, that he has been ritually married to a young woman named Saffron, who presents herself as a submissive bride raised to serve. She is a confidence artist. She drugs Mal with a kiss, disables the ship, and sets it on

course for a salvage operation's net, where the crew would be killed and the vessel stripped. In "Trash" she returns under other names—Mal compresses them into a mocking composite—with a scheme to steal an antique laser pistol, the Lassiter, from a former husband's floating estate on Bellerophon; the weapon is smuggled out through the estate's garbage system, and the episode, which opens with Mal sitting naked on a rock in the desert, is named for the route.

Saffron is the trickster of comparative mythology (Radin 1956)—Hermes, Loki, Proteus—a figure of perfect adaptation to a predatory world. She is also the crew's negative. Like them she lives by *mētis*, the cunning intelligence of improvisation and disguise; unlike them she lives without a bond. Every relation is a con, every ship salvage, every name provisional. Her signature weapon is the patriarchal fantasy of the submissive wife, turned into a trap for the men who desire it. And her protean identity is the reified subject in Lukács's sense (*Geschichte und Klassenbewußtsein*, 1923), a self entirely converted into exchange-value and therefore without remainder. She is what the salvage polity would be if salvage were its only principle.

7.4

Book: Whisky Priest and Second Naïveté

Shepherd Derrial Book leaves Southdown Abbey, as he says, to see the 'verse. His past is withheld. In "Safe" an Alliance identity card secures him emergency treatment aboard a cruiser that would have turned away anyone else; he knows the tactics of criminals and the habits of soldiers; in "War Stories" he fights with professional skill and observes that Scripture, quite specific about killing, is rather vaguer on the subject of kneecaps. In the film he has settled at Haven, a mining outpost, and dies there when the Operative's forces destroy it. (A later graphic novel supplies his history; it is summarized below as a continuation, not as evidence.)

Graham Greene's *The Power and the Glory* (1940) supplies the type. Its whisky priest—cowardly, compromised, father of an illegitimate child—is hunted through the Mexico of the 1930s by an anticlerical revolutionary state. His pursuer, the lieutenant, is an ascetic idealist who loves children and wants to give them a better world, and who executes hostages to catch the priest. The lieutenant is the Operative; the whisky priest is Book. Greene's theology, in which grace travels in compromised vessels and is not compromised by them, is the corpus's theology of its preacher.

The graphic novel *Serenity: The Shepherd's Tale* (2010), scripted by Zack Whedon from Joss Whedon's outline, supplies the history the series withholds; because this dissertation brackets the comics, it is reported here as an authorized continuation rather than as evidence. Told in reverse, it shows Henry Evans, a boy from an abusive home who became a street criminal, joining the Independents and being sent among the enemy as a spy. He kills a young traveler named Derrial Book and takes his name, enters the Alliance's officer training, beats a prisoner under interrogation, and as an Alliance officer directs an operation whose failure costs thousands of lives—a failure the narrative implies was sabotage on the Independents' behalf. Stripped of rank and cast out, he drifts, finds faith in a monastery, and at last boards Serenity. Ron Glass had disclosed on the 2007 Brown-

coat Cruise, with Whedon's permission, that Derrial was the name of a man the Shepherd had killed. The continuation confirms what the identity card of "Safe" implied, and it strengthens two readings offered here. Book is the whisky priest in a stronger sense than Greene's: the vessel of grace is a man who killed for a cause, under a stolen name, in the uniforms of both sides. And his recognition of the Operative as a believer becomes self-recognition, which sharpens the Kierkegaardian problem of Chapter 2: Book's counsel to believe comes from a man whose first belief made him a killer, which is why the corpus cannot let commitment alone be the criterion.

In "Jaynestown" River sets about fixing Book's Bible, annotating its contradictions and tearing out what does not compute, and Book tells her that one does not fix faith; faith fixes you. The scene stages the confrontation between the Enlightenment's criticism of scripture—Spinoza's *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus* (1670), Strauss's *Das Leben Jesu* (1835)—and a faith that is not a set of propositions. Paul Ricoeur called the posture Book adopts a "second naïveté" (*La Symbolique du mal*, 1960): not a return to precritical belief but a hearing of the symbol again, through and after criticism. Book knows the contradictions; he does not need them resolved. Faith, for him, is a practice that forms the practitioner, closer to Pascal's counsel to begin by acting as if one believed than to any theology of proof. His office aboard the ship is that of a chaplain without a church: the keeper of a moral imagination the crew can borrow without sharing his creed.

7.5

Kaylee: Eros in the Engine Room

Kaywinnet Lee Frye enters the corpus, in the flashbacks of "Out of Gas," through sex and a repair: found in the engine room having sex with the ship's previous mechanic, Bester, she diagnoses and fixes the engine on the spot and is hired in his place. Her love of the ship is the series' most constant affect. She speaks of the engine as alive and of the ship as "she"; she weeps with joy over fresh strawberries in the pilot; at the ball in "Shindig" her ruffled pink gown draws the contempt of Core women and the delight of an elderly gentleman who wants to talk about engines. In "Objects in Space" she is the target of Early's threat; in the film she and Simon at last acknowledge one another.

Freud defined Eros as the force that binds living substance into ever larger unities. Kaylee is the ship's Eros, holding it together both mechanically and affectively, and she stands opposite the two faces of the death drive that Chapter 5 found in the Pax's products: the Nirvana of the Mirandans and the destructiveness of the Reavers. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) imagined kinship across the boundary between organism and machine, and *The Companion Species Manifesto* (2003) theorized "companion species" as beings co-constituted through relations of significant otherness. Kaylee and Serenity are companion species in Haraway's sense. The pun is the corpus's own: the ship carries a Companion in its shuttle and is itself its mechanic's companion, and companionship becomes the corpus's name for care across difference—sexual, machinic, familial. Kaylee's knowledge, finally, is *mētis* (Detienne and Vernant 1974): embodied, intuitive, adaptive,

the kind of intelligence that cannot be written down as a procedure. Chapter 9 finds its classical Chinese image in Zhuangzi's Cook Ding.

7.6

One Thought Too Many: Care Against Calculation

Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) distinguished an ethics of care, attentive to relationships and particular needs, from the ethics of justice that Lawrence Kohlberg's developmental psychology had treated as moral maturity. Nel Noddings (*Caring*, 1984) grounded ethics in the relational engrossment of caring; Joan Tronto (*Moral Boundaries*, 1993) distinguished the phases of caring about, taking care of, care-giving, and care-receiving, and argued that care is a political concept; Virginia Held (*The Ethics of Care*, 2006) systematized the field. The crew's ethic is an ethic of care: particular, relational, responsive to need. The Alliance's is impartial maximization—peace for the greatest number, secured by whatever the calculation requires.

Bernard Williams supplied the sharpest formulation of the difference. In "Persons, Character and Morality" (1976), he imagined a man who could save either his wife or a stranger and who, saving his wife, justified the choice by an impartial principle permitting partiality: such a man, Williams wrote, has "one thought too many." The motivating thought should be simply that it was his wife. In "Safe," when Simon asks why Mal came back for him and his sister, Mal answers that they are on his crew; pressed, he asks why they are still talking about it. Mal refuses the one thought too many. Loyalty, for him, requires no impartial justification, and to demand one is already to misunderstand it. The Operative, by contrast, has only impartial thoughts, and the corpus's indictment of him is Williams's indictment of a morality that has lost the capacity to be moved by particular persons.

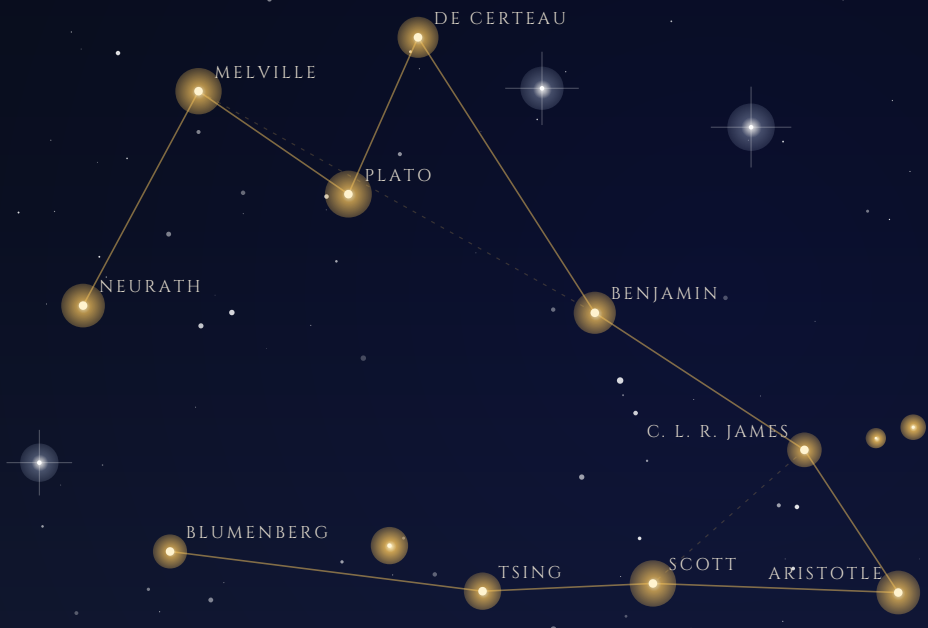
The economy of care is not soft. It includes a siege, a con, a man thrown into an engine, a woman who dies defending her house, a doctor who sedates the sister he loves. But it is the medium in which the crew's polity lives, and it supplies what the next chapter will need: an account of political community that begins not with sovereignty but with the particular attachments sovereignty either protects or administers away.

CHAPTER

VIII

The Vessel as Polis

From Plato's Ship to the Salvage Polity



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER VIII

The ship is the oldest metaphor of Western political philosophy, and *Firefly* returns the metaphor to literal use: its polity is a ship. This chapter reads Serenity against the canonical vessels of political thought and literature—Plato's ship of state, Aristotle's community of fellow-voyagers, the Ship of Theseus, Neurath's boat, Melville's *Pequod*—and against the arks and fleets of modern science fiction, then turns to James C. Scott's anthropology of state evasion and to the etymology that gives the chapter its concept. Its thesis is that the ship constitutes a *salvage polity*: an elective, mobile micro-sovereignty of care, bounded by the hull and constituted by repair.

8.1

Plato's Stargazer and the Drugged Shipowner

In the sixth book of the *Republic* (488a–489a), Socrates offers a parable. A shipowner, larger and stronger than anyone aboard but somewhat deaf and short-sighted and ignorant of navigation, is surrounded by sailors who quarrel over the helm. None has learned the art; each claims it cannot be taught. They beg the owner for command, kill or throw overboard their rivals, and at last bind the noble shipowner "with mandragora or drink" (488c), seize the ship, and feast on its stores. Whoever helps them to power they praise as a navigator; the true pilot, who attends to the seasons, the sky, the stars, and the winds, they call a stargazer (*meteōroskopos*) and an idle babbler (*adoleschēs*), useless to them (488e–489a).

The parable is anti-democratic in intent: it argues that the city should be steered by those who possess the knowledge of steering. Its darkest detail, however, is the drug. In Plato, the usurpers who lack knowledge drug the owner; in *Serenity*, the regime that claims knowledge does. The Alliance's experts bound the Mirandans with something stronger than mandragora, and the parable is fulfilled by the very class Plato trusted. Serenity's own helm belongs to a stargazer and a babbler in Plato's exact sense: Wash, who plays out melodramas with plastic dinosaurs on the console and is the ship's most beloved member. No one aboard claims the right to rule by knowledge. The captain's authority rests on competence, consent, and care, and when the playful pilot dies, the helm passes to the oracle.

8.2

Fellow-Voyagers and Fellow-Soldiers

Aristotle holds that friendship seems to hold cities together, and that lawgivers care more for it than for justice (*Nicomachean Ethics* 8.1, 1155a22–26). Friendship and justice, he adds, exist in every community, and people therefore address as friends their fellow-voyagers and their fellow-soldiers (*tous symplous kai tous systratiōtas*, 8.9, 1159b27–28). The two partial communities Aristotle chose as paradigms are the two that compose Serenity's crew: Mal and Zoe are fellow-soldiers; everyone

else is a fellow-voyager. The crew's friendship moves through Aristotle's three kinds in sequence, from utility (wages, jobs) through pleasure (banter, shared meals) to the friendship of character, which in the film is tested unto death. Aristotle's *Politics* adds that a city's identity depends not on its walls or its inhabitants but on its constitution, its *politeia*, as a chorus composed of the same men is a different chorus when it performs tragedy rather than comedy (3.3, 1276b1–13). Serenity's identity is its *politeia*: a way of life, not a set of persons or parts.

The ship is both *oikos* and *polis*, household and city: it has a dinner table, where the pilot's first shared meal establishes the crew as a family, and it has a sovereign, who decides. Aristotle distinguished political rule, exercised over free and equal persons, from despotic rule, the master's over the slave. Mal's rule is political, contested daily by Zoe, Inara, Book, and Simon, with despotic moments that the corpus examines rather than excuses. In "Ariel," having discovered that Jayne sold Simon and River to the Alliance, Mal shuts him in the airlock and prepares to space him; he relents when Jayne asks only that the others not be told what he did. The sovereign exception is exercised and suspended in a single scene, and mercy appears as the residue of sovereignty aboard the ship. Max Weber's three types of legitimate authority—traditional, legal-rational, charismatic (*Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, 1922)—fit Mal poorly. His authority is practical: renewed by each successful job and each act of loyalty, revocable by failure, and grounded in consent that must be won again tomorrow.

Hannah Arendt supplies the polity's political meaning. *The Human Condition* (1958) located freedom in the space of appearance that arises wherever people act and speak together, and *On Revolution* (1963) traced the "lost treasure" of the revolutionary tradition: the townships, councils, and sections in which ordinary people briefly governed themselves, which each revolution brought forth and its victors forgot. The preface to *Between Past and Future* (1961) borrowed from René Char, a poet of the French Resistance, the thought that such an inheritance is left without a testament. The Independents' defeat is the loss of that treasure at the scale of a star system. The ship preserves it in miniature: around its table and on its bridge a few people still act and speak together as equals and decide their own course, and that space of appearance, not the brown coat, is what the defeated have kept.

8.3

Theseus's Planks and Neurath's Sea

Plutarch reports that the Athenians preserved the ship of Theseus until the time of Demetrius of Phalerum, replacing its decayed timbers with sound ones, so that philosophers cited it as an example of the "growing argument" about identity through change (*Theseus* 23.1). Hobbes sharpened the puzzle by imagining the discarded planks reassembled: which, then, would be the ship? (*De Corpore*, 1655, 2.11.7). Serenity is a Ship of Theseus in continuous operation. Its parts are replaced as they fail—the catalyzer of "Out of Gas," the compression coils, the hull plating torn in the film—and its crew are replaced as well, Bester by Kaylee, Wash by River. Aristotle's answer

serves: the ship is the same because its *politeia* persists. Plutarch adds a detail the corpus could have written: Theseus unified the scattered communities of Attica not by war but by persuasion, promising them a commonwealth without a king (*Theseus* 24). The founding unification of Athens is the antithesis of the Alliance's.

Otto Neurath gave the ship a further philosophical office. We are like sailors, he wrote in "Protokollsätze" (1932), who must rebuild their ship on the open sea, never able to put into dry dock and reconstruct it from the best materials. Hans Blumenberg's *Schiffbruch mit Zuschauer* (1979) traced the history of the metaphor from Lucretius's spectator, who watches from the shore another's struggle on a storm-tossed sea (*De Rerum Natura* 2.1–4), to the modern condition in which there is no shore and no spectator; Pascal had already told the reluctant gambler of the wager that he had no choice, *vous êtes embarqué* (Lafuma 418). In the Black there is no shore. Earth is gone, there is no dry dock, and no one watches from safety. The salvage polity is Neurath's boat: anti-foundational, repaired at sea from whatever is at hand.

8.4

Isolatoes Federated Along One Keel

In the twenty-sixth chapter of *Moby-Dick* (1851), Ishmael announces that he will ascribe high qualities, though dark, to "meanest mariners, and renegades and castaways." In the twenty-seventh he describes the *Pequod*'s crew as "Isolatoes," each "living on a separate continent of his own," and exclaims: "Yet now, federated along one keel, what a set these Isolatoes were!" Serenity's crew are Isolatoes federated along one keel—a self-taught engineer from a backwater world, a mercenary, a fugitive physician and his ruined sister, a preacher with a secret, a courtesan, two veterans of a lost war, and a pilot who plays with dinosaurs.

The *Pequod* also supplies the polity's gravest danger. On the quarter-deck (ch. 36), Ahab binds his crew's will to his private vengeance against the whale, and only Starbuck objects. C. L. R. James wrote *Mariners, Renegades and Castaways* (1953) while detained on Ellis Island under threat of deportation, and read Ahab as the totalitarian personality and the crew as the democratic hope that his will consumes. The corpus stages its own Ahab temptation. After the massacre at Haven, Mal resolves to fly through Reaver space and orders the ship dressed as a Reaver vessel over his crew's horror; for a moment the captain's will threatens to absorb the crew's, and Zoe, who followed him through the war, protests. The moment passes into a collective resolve, and the speech that precedes the final assault is an appeal rather than a command. The difference between Mal and Ahab is the difference between a public truth and a private vengeance; Ahab's crew die with him, and Mal's, except for Wash, survive.

8.5

Arks, Fleets, and Rocinantes

The ark of Genesis is the first remnant-vessel: a hull carrying what survives a catastrophe into a world that does not yet exist. The reimagined *Battlestar Galactica* (2003–2009) made the ark a fleet, its survivors fleeing the destruction of their worlds in search of a mythical Earth under a divided military and civil authority, and its finale renounced technology on a new Earth discovered in humanity's remote past. *Firefly* refuses the *nostos* that *Galactica* pursues. There is no search for Earth, because Earth-That-Was was used up; there is no new Eden, only the Black. James S. A. Corey's *The Expanse* (novels 2011–2021; television 2015–2022) is the corpus's most direct heir. Its ship, the *Rocinante*, is named for Don Quixote's horse; its Belters speak a creole and labor at the edge of the system; its first great atrocity is a corporate experiment that releases an alien agent on the population of a station named Eros—a Miranda with a name out of Freud—and its captain broadcasts every truth he learns, whatever the consequences. *Cowboy Bebop* (1998) imagined bounty hunters adrift in a creolized solar system; *Blake's 7* (BBC, 1978–81) sent fugitives against a Federation and ended with its crew apparently massacred, the bleak counter-possibility of every ship of outlaws. *Star Wars* enlisted its smuggler's ship into a rebellion that won. Serenity's rebellion lost before the series began, and that difference is the condition of everything the corpus thinks.

8.6

Galactic Zomia

James C. Scott's *Seeing Like a State* (1998) analyzed the failure of high-modernist schemes—Le Corbusier's planning, Brasília, Soviet collectivization, Tanzanian villagization—and identified the conjunction of four conditions behind the worst disasters: the administrative ordering of nature and society, a high-modernist ideology, an authoritarian state willing to use its full power, and a prostrate civil society incapable of resistance. Miranda satisfies all four, and its civil society is prostrate in the most literal sense: it lay down. Scott's account of state simplification—cadastral maps, permanent surnames, standardized measures, the drive to make populations legible—describes the Alliance's identity cards and Cortex. Against legibility Scott set *mētis*, the practical knowledge that resists codification, and Chapter 7 found it in Kaylee.

The Art of Not Being Governed (2009) extended the analysis to Zomia, Willem van Schendel's name for the uplands of mainland Southeast Asia, whose peoples practiced what Scott called state-repelling arts: mobility, dispersal, shifting cultivation, oral rather than written culture, flexible identities, prophetic leadership, and reliance on the friction of terrain that made them costly to reach. The Black is a galactic Zomia, and its friction of distance is the Rim's defense. The crew practice every state-repelling art: they move constantly, carry false identities, transmit their history

orally (the mudders' ballad of Jayne is a Zomian epic), and harbor a prophet. Scott's earlier work supplies the micro-politics. *Weapons of the Weak* (1985) catalogued everyday resistance—foot-dragging, pilfering, feigned ignorance, sabotage—and *Domination and the Arts of Resistance* (1990) distinguished the public transcript of deference from the hidden transcript spoken offstage. The Unification Day brawl that opens "The Train Job" is the hidden transcript erupting into public. Michel de Certeau's *L'Invention du quotidien* (1980) distinguished the strategies of power, operating from a proper place, from the tactics of the weak, operating in the space of the other and seizing opportunities on the wing. The crew's jobs are tactics. Eric Hobsbawm's social bandit (*Primitive Rebels*, 1959; *Bandits*, 1969), the outlaw whom the peasantry regards as its avenger, is the type "Jaynestown" both literalizes and deflates.

8.7

Salvage

The English *salvage* derives, through Old French, from Late Latin *salvare*, to save; *salvation* (*salvatio*) shares the root. Maritime law recognizes the salvor's claim to a reward for saving property at peril on the sea, and distinguishes the derelict, abandoned by its owners, from the wreck. The corpus is saturated with salvage. After its prologue, the pilot's first job is a salvage operation on a derelict; "Our Mrs. Reynolds" threatens to reduce Serenity itself to salvage; "Trash" retrieves value through a garbage chute; "Out of Gas" narrates the purchase of a junker; and the film retrieves the truth from a dead world. Walter Benjamin's figure of the ragpicker, drawn from Baudelaire's *chiffonnier*, made the historian a collector of the refuse of history. In the ninth thesis "Über den Begriff der Geschichte" (1940), the angel of history would like to stay, to awaken the dead and piece together what has been smashed (*die Toten wecken und das Zerschlagene zusammenfügen*), but the storm of progress drives him on; the second thesis credits each generation with a "weak messianic power." Salvage is the secular form of that weak power: not the restoration of the whole but the piecing together of what has been smashed.

Anna Lowenhaupt Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) introduced a necessary qualification. "Salvage accumulation," in Tsing's analysis, is the process by which capitalism draws value from relations and labor it did not organize, at the peripheries, as matsutake gathered by itinerant pickers enter global commodity chains. The crew's labor feeds the Core's markets through Badger and Niska, and it is salvage accumulation in Tsing's sense. The salvage polity exceeds it. What it saves is not only value but persons—River, the miners of Paradiso, the truth of Miranda—that the system has written off. The chapter's concept can now be stated. The *salvage polity* is an elective, mobile micro-sovereignty of care, bounded by the hull and constituted by repair, whose characteristic act is to save what the totality has abandoned: to salvage, in both senses, the remainder.

CHAPTER

IX

Daoist Undertow

Re-reading the Sino-American 'Verse Against Its Orientalism



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER IX

The 'verse is premised on the fusion of the two great powers of the early twenty-first century, the United States and China, and its texture is visibly bilingual: Mandarin on signs, packaging, and garments, Mandarin in the mouths of every character. The fusion has been justly criticized as ornament. This chapter accepts the criticism and then reads the show's Chinese layer against itself, arguing that the classical Chinese philosophical archive—Laozi, Zhuangzi, Mencius, the Legalists, the mythographers of the *Huainanzi*—supplies, unbidden, the most exact critique of the Alliance available anywhere in the corpus's intellectual inheritance.

9.1

The Decorative Orient and Calibanic Mandarin

Mandarin in *Firefly* is spoken chiefly in curses and exclamations, delivered at speed and often rendered in ways native speakers have found hard to recognize; Chinese characters furnish the set dressing; and East Asian performers are nearly absent from the principal and recurring cast. Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) described the Orient as a Western representation in the service of domination, and the concept of techno-Orientalism (Morley and Robins 1995; Roh, Huang, and Niu 2015) names a specific modern variant in which Asia supplies the texture of the future, as in the Los Angeles of *Blade Runner* (1982). *Firefly*'s is a retro variant: Asia as the texture of a future that looks like the American past. The critique is sound, and nothing in this chapter withdraws it; Leigh Adams Wright's "Asian Objects in Space" (2005) pressed it early, asking whether a world furnished with Asian objects makes room for Asian people.

The structure of the bilingualism nonetheless repays analysis. Caliban tells Prospero that he was taught language and that his profit from it is that he knows how to curse (*The Tempest* 1.2). The Rim speaks the empire's second language chiefly to curse. The pattern reproduces a familiar feature of colonial bilingualism—the subordinate's appropriation of the dominant language for profanity, irony, and the hidden transcript—while exoticizing it for an audience that does not understand the words. Both readings stand: the Mandarin of the series is Orientalist ornament and Calibanic speech at once. The remainder of this chapter turns from the language the show uses to the philosophy it does not cite.

9.2

The World Is a Sacred Vessel



天下神器
DAODEJING 29

The twenty-ninth chapter of the *Daodejing* warns those who would seize the world and act upon it that they will not succeed: 天下神器，不可為也。為者敗之，執者失之—"the world is a sacred vessel; it cannot be acted upon. Whoever acts upon it ruins it; whoever grasps it loses it." The fifty-seventh observes that the more prohibitions there are, the poorer the people become, and gives the sage's counsel: 我無為，而民自化—"I do nothing, and the people transform themselves." The sixtieth compares governing a great state to cooking a small fish, which falls apart if stirred (治大國，若烹小鮮). The seventy-fifth diagnoses why the people are hard to govern: 以其上之有為—"because those above them act," that is, interfere. The seventeenth describes the best rulers as those of whom the people know only that they exist.

River's protest in the film's opening classroom—that people do not like to be meddled with, that the Alliance is meddlesome—is a precise statement of the seventy-fifth chapter. The Pax is *youwei* (有為), purposive interference, carried to its limit: the world acted upon at the level of breath, and ruined. The image of the twenty-ninth chapter could not be more apt. A vessel (器) is what Serenity is, and what Miranda was before it was made into something. Edward Slingerland's study of *wu wei* (*Effortless Action*, 2003) cautions against reading it as passivity: it names an action that does not coerce, the skilled spontaneity of one who moves with the grain of things. That is the sense in which the crew's politics is Daoist and the Alliance's is its antithesis.

9.3

The Usefulness of Uselessness

In the first chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Huizi complains of a great tree whose trunk is too gnarled and whose branches are too twisted to be of use to any carpenter, and Zhuangzi advises him to plant it in the village of Nothing-at-all and wander idly beside it: no axe will shorten its life, because nothing about it is useful. In the fourth chapter, the carpenter Shi passes a huge oak serving as a shrine and dismisses it as worthless timber; that night the oak appears to him in a dream and explains that it has long sought to be useless, because the useful trees are cut down. The chapter ends: 人皆知有用之用，而莫知無用之用也—"everyone knows the usefulness of the useful, but no one knows the usefulness of the useless."

The Firefly-class transport is obsolescent, a model nobody wants; in the flashbacks of "Out of Gas" Mal chooses this junker over a better ship. The crew's survival depends on remaining beneath the Alliance's notice, too marginal to be worth the trouble. They are useless to the state's carpenters, unfit to be shaped into citizens, soldiers, or subjects of a program. River, whom the Academy made useful as a weapon, is hunted precisely because of her usefulness. Uselessness is the remainder's survival art, and Zhuangzi's useless tree restates in Chinese the Epicurean maxim of Chapter 1: live unnoticed.

9.4

Small State, Few People

The eightieth chapter of the *Daodejing* sketches the sage's polity: 小國寡民—"let the state be small and the people few." Though they have boats and carriages, they have no occasion to ride them; they find their food sweet, their clothing beautiful, their dwellings secure, their customs joyful; neighboring states lie within sight, and the sounds of their cocks and dogs can be heard, yet the people grow old and die without visiting one another. Serenity is a nomadic version of this polity: a small state of few people whose boat is in constant use only because the great state will not leave it alone. Laozi's sedentary community is forced into motion, but its ethic survives the motion—the sweetness of food, in Kaylee's strawberries and the crew's shared table; the security of a dwelling, in a hull kept airtight by repair.

The eleventh chapter supplies the polity's metaphysics: 埏埴以為器，當其無，有器之用—"knead clay to make a vessel; it is in its emptiness that the vessel's use lies." The ship's use lies in its hold, the space it keeps open for whatever cargo or passenger comes; the Black's emptiness is the condition of its motion. The salvage polity is, in Laozi's terms, the use of the empty: a community defined less by what it contains than by the room it keeps for what the 'verse would otherwise discard.

9.5

The Tortoise in the Mud

In the seventeenth chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, the philosopher is fishing in the Pu River when two officials arrive from the king of Chu to offer him the administration of the realm. Without turning from his rod, Zhuangzi asks them whether the sacred tortoise of Chu, dead three thousand years and kept wrapped in a box in the ancestral temple, would rather be dead and honored or alive and dragging its tail through the mud. Alive in the mud, they concede. "Go away," says Zhuangzi: "I will drag my tail in the mud" (吾將曳尾於塗中).

"Jaynestown" is a parable of the same choice. The mudders of Canton, indentured laborers of Magistrate Higgins, have raised a statue to Jayne, and the living man, confronted with his monument, is profoundly uncomfortable in it. When a young mudder dies throwing himself in front of a shotgun blast meant for Jayne, Jayne topples the statue. Mal's coda—that every man who ever got a statue was one kind of scoundrel or another, and that the statue was never about Jayne but about what the mudders needed—combines Durkheim's insight that the totem is society's worship of itself (*Les Formes élémentaires de la vie religieuse*, 1912) with Zhuangzi's preference for life in the mud over enshrined death. The corpus consistently prefers the living to the monumental, and the remainder to the statue.

9.6

Heaven Sees as the People See

King Xuan of Qi asked Mencius whether it was true that Tang had banished Jie and King Wu had struck down Zhou, and whether a subject might kill his sovereign. Mencius answered that one who mutilates benevolence is a thief, one who mutilates rightness is a ruffian, and such a man is merely "a fellow": he had heard of the punishment of the fellow Zhou, but not of the murder of a sovereign (*Mencius* 1B8). The doctrine of the Mandate of Heaven makes legitimacy conditional: a ruler who brutalizes the people forfeits the mandate and ceases, in the moral sense, to be a ruler. Elsewhere Mencius quotes the *Great Declaration*: 天視自我民視，天聽自我民聽—"Heaven sees as my people see; Heaven hears as my people hear" (5A5).

The broadcast of the Miranda record is the Mencian mechanism of the Mandate made literal. When the people see, Heaven sees. The film does not depict the Alliance's fall; it depicts its mandate placed under judgment by the sight of what it did. Against Mencius stand the Legalists. Han Fei's "two handles" (二柄) of reward and punishment, Shang Yang's reforms, and the Qin unification of 221 BCE, which standardized script, weights and measures, axle widths, and coinage and was followed in 213 BCE by the burning of books, form the paradigm of what Scott calls legibility. The Chinese political term for unification, 統一 (*tǒngyī*), names the Alliance's war, and for a Mandarin-speaking audience it carries a further charge: it is the term in which the People's Republic of China frames its claim to Taiwan. Whether or not the series intended the resonance, it gives the Independents' cause—self-government for outlying worlds against a unifying center—a contemporary analogue that cuts across the show's own Sino-American premise, though the analogy has limits, since the Alliance fuses two powers rather than standing for either. The Alliance is a Legalist state with Confucian manners and a technocratic vocabulary. In October 2006 the Sixth Plenum of the Chinese Communist Party's Sixteenth Central Committee made the building of a "harmonious socialist society" (社會主義和諧社會) official policy, the period's most explicit governmental idiom of harmony, and administrative idioms of stability and cohesion elsewhere share its aspiration. The Pax is the *reductio* of any politics that treats harmony as an administrative output rather than a social achievement: harmony produced by removing the capacity for discord, which is to say, by removing the people. The Confucian tradition supplies its own verdict: "the gentleman harmonizes but does not make uniform; the small man makes uniform but does not harmonize" (君子和而不同，小人同而不和, *Analects* 13.23). The Pax produces *tong*, sameness, and calls it *he*, harmony.

9.7

Cook Ding and the Nourishing of Life

In the third chapter of the *Zhuangzi*, Cook Ding carves an ox for Lord Wenhui with movements as rhythmic as a ritual dance. His knife, he explains, has carved thousands of oxen in nineteen years and is as sharp as on the day it left the whetstone, because he follows the heavenly pattern of the ox (天理), sliding the blade through the spaces between the joints; when he comes to a difficult knot, he slows, concentrates, and moves the blade with the slightest touch. Lord Wenhui exclaims that from Cook Ding's words he has learned how to nourish life (養生).

Cook Ding is the patron of the crew's knowledge: Kaylee's sense of an engine, Wash's piloting through debris, River's combat, which the film stages as dance. Marcel Detienne and Jean-Pierre Vernant's *mētis* and Zhuangzi's skill converge on the same epistemology, embodied, adaptive, attentive to the grain of things. The chapter's title term, *yangsheng*, nourishing life, names a relation to life opposite to biopower's. To nourish life is to follow its pattern; to administer it is to override that pattern in the name of an end. The Pax is the anti-Cook Ding, a blade driven straight through the bone.

9.8

Gonggong and Nüwa: Two Responses to Defeat

The *Huainanzi* (presented to the Han throne in 139 BCE) preserves two myths that the corpus never cites and that state its ethic exactly. In the third chapter, Gonggong, contending with Zhuanxu for rule and defeated, in his fury butts his head against Mount Buzhou, a pillar of heaven, and breaks it, so that the sky tilts toward the northwest and the earth sinks toward the southeast. In the sixth, in an age when the four pillars had broken and the world had fallen into chaos, the goddess Nüwa smelts stones of five colors to patch the azure sky, cuts the legs of a great turtle to set up the four pillars again, and stills the flood.

These are two cosmogonic responses to defeat. The defeated god breaks the sky in rage: that is the Reaver's response, and the Lost Cause's, destruction as the defeated's revenge on the order that defeated it. The goddess repairs the sky with stones of many colors: that is salvage. The theme ballad's sky cannot be taken, but the corpus shows that it can be broken, and that it must sometimes be mended. Nüwa's patchwork of five-colored stones is the image of a heterogeneous crew—Isolatoes federated along one keel—holding up a sky that a war tore. The remainder of the Unification War could become Gonggong or Nüwa; the corpus's whole ethical labor is to show the second as possible without denying the reality of the first.

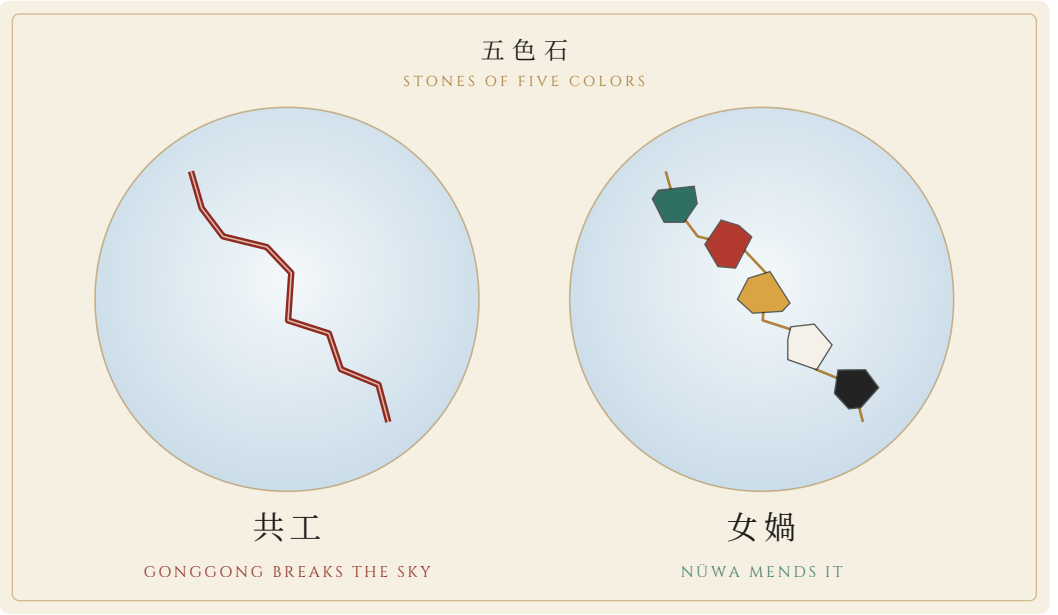
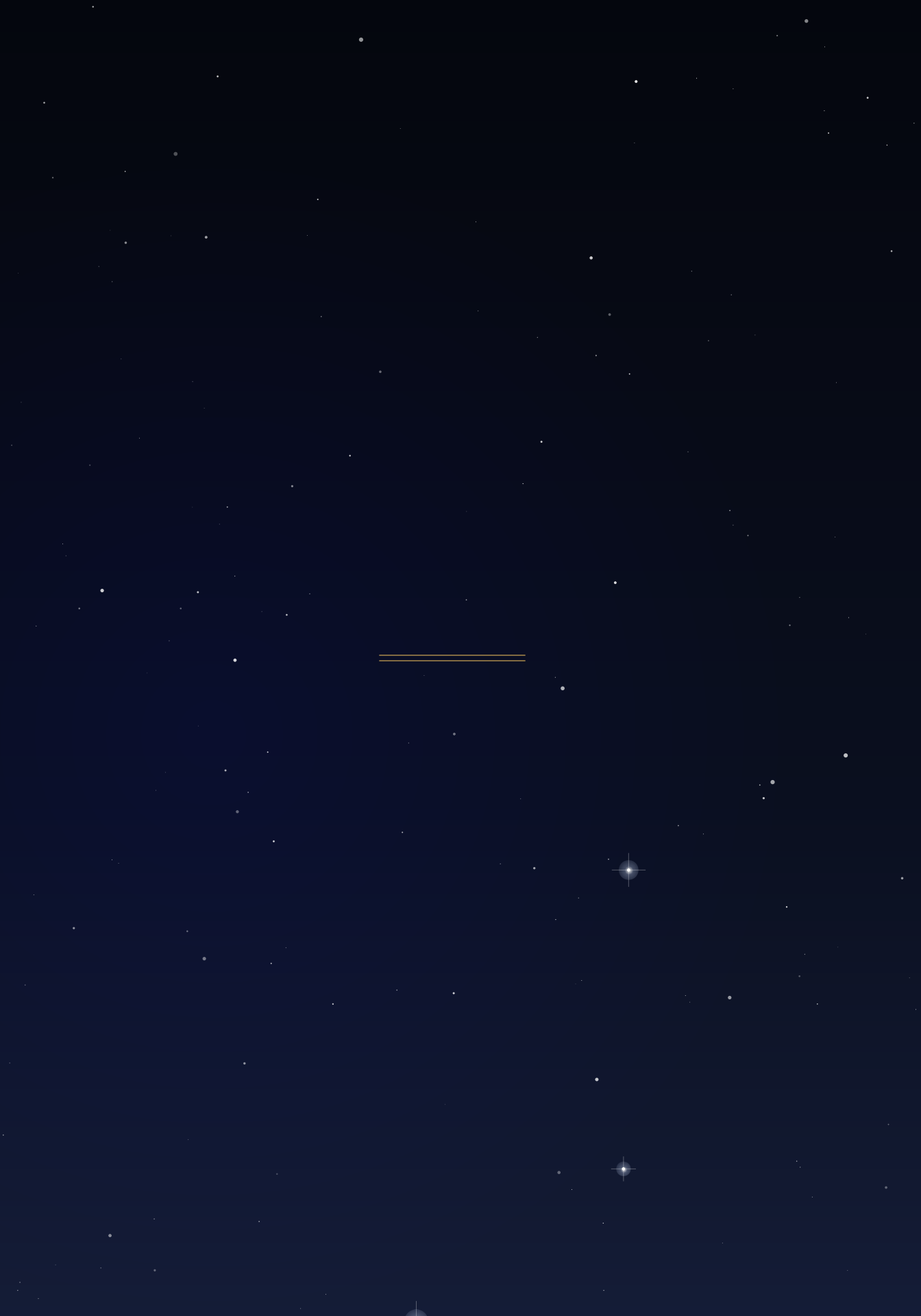


FIGURE 8 *Two responses to defeat.* From the *Huainanzi*: the defeated Gonggong breaks a pillar of heaven in his rage, and the goddess Nüwa patches the sky with stones of five colors. The remainder of a lost war can break the sky or mend it.

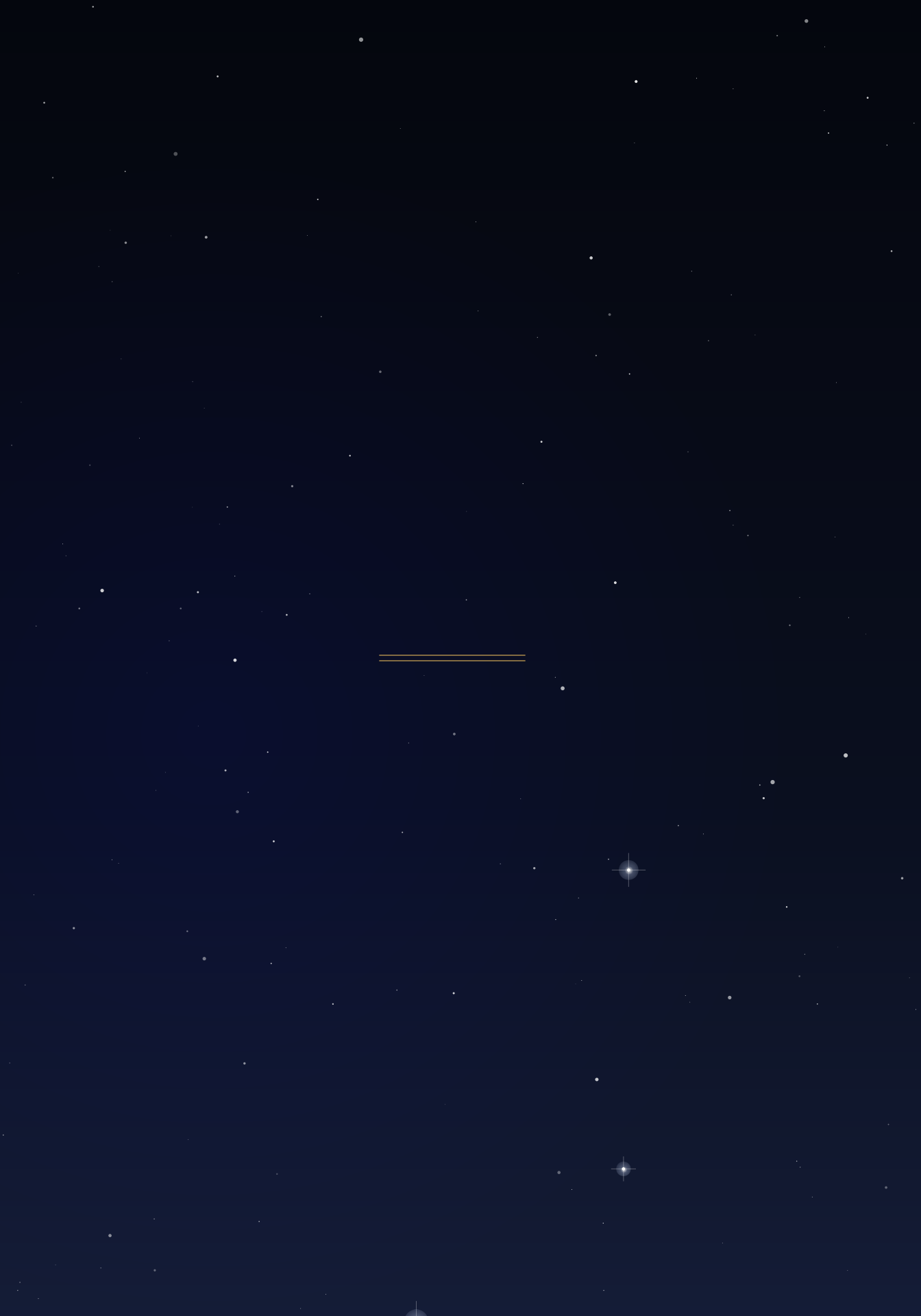


PART THREE

Synthesis

Part Three assembles the preceding analyses into a theory of the remainder, formulates the principles of the salvage polity and the ethics of enough, and confronts the objections that limit the argument.





CHAPTER

X

The Serenity of the Remainder

A Theory



CONSTELLATION OF CHAPTER X

The preceding chapters have read the corpus through many lenses. This chapter argues that they disclose a single structure: a totalizing order that seeks a society without remainder; a remainder that survives in four registers, each shadowed by a monstrous double; and a set of practices—gathered under the names of the salvage polity and the ethics of enough—by which the remainder can live without becoming its double.

10.1

The Four Remainders and Their Doubles

REGISTER	FIGURE IN THE CORPUS	MONSTROUS DOUBLE	REDEMPTIVE PRACTICE	PRINCIPAL INTERLOCUTORS
Historical: the defeated	Mal, Zoe, the Independents	Lost Cause revanchism (Jubal Early; Gonggong)	Memory without myth: the ship's name	Lucan, Tacitus, Milton, Benjamin, Bloch
Cosmological: the post-terrestrial	The Black; Earth-That-Was	Nihilism: the abyss of the series' Reavers	Lucidity without despair: revolt and measure	Pascal, Nietzsche, Camus
Biopolitical: the excess of perfection	River; the tenth of one percent	The Reaver: the Pax's absolute disturbance	Care without cure: Simon's labor	Foucault, Agamben, Freud, Derrida
Ontological: the superfluous	Things, and persons priced as cargo	Reification: Early, Saffron	Investment without fetish: Kaylee's "she"	Sartre, Heidegger, Lukács, Haraway

Each register produces a remainder that can become monstrous, and the doubles are not external enemies but possibilities internal to the remainder itself. The defeated can harden into revanchist myth; lucidity before the void can collapse into nihilism; the excess the system cannot integrate can return as pure destruction; the superfluity of things can be answered by reducing persons to things. The corpus's ethical labor is discrimination: to show, case by case, the difference between the remainder and its double, and the practices that keep them apart.

10.2

The Two Serenities

The antithesis announced in Chapter 1 can now be stated formally. The *administered serenity* of the Pax is total in scope, external in source, chemical in means, extinguishing in its relation to the passions, abolitionist in its relation to the remainder, and anticipatory in its temporality—imposed in advance of conflict so that conflict will never occur. Its products are the two faces of the death drive: the Nirvana of the quiet dead and the frenzy of the Reavers. The *achieved serenity* of the crew is partial in scope, internal in source, practiced in means, integrative in its relation to the passions, acknowledging in its relation to the remainder, and retrospective in its temporality—won

after defeat, carried as a name. It is compatible with grief, rage, desire, and humor, and it is mortal. The film titled *Serenity* names both and decides between them. Its decision is not that tranquillity is an illusion, but that only the tranquillity that leaves a remainder is compatible with life.

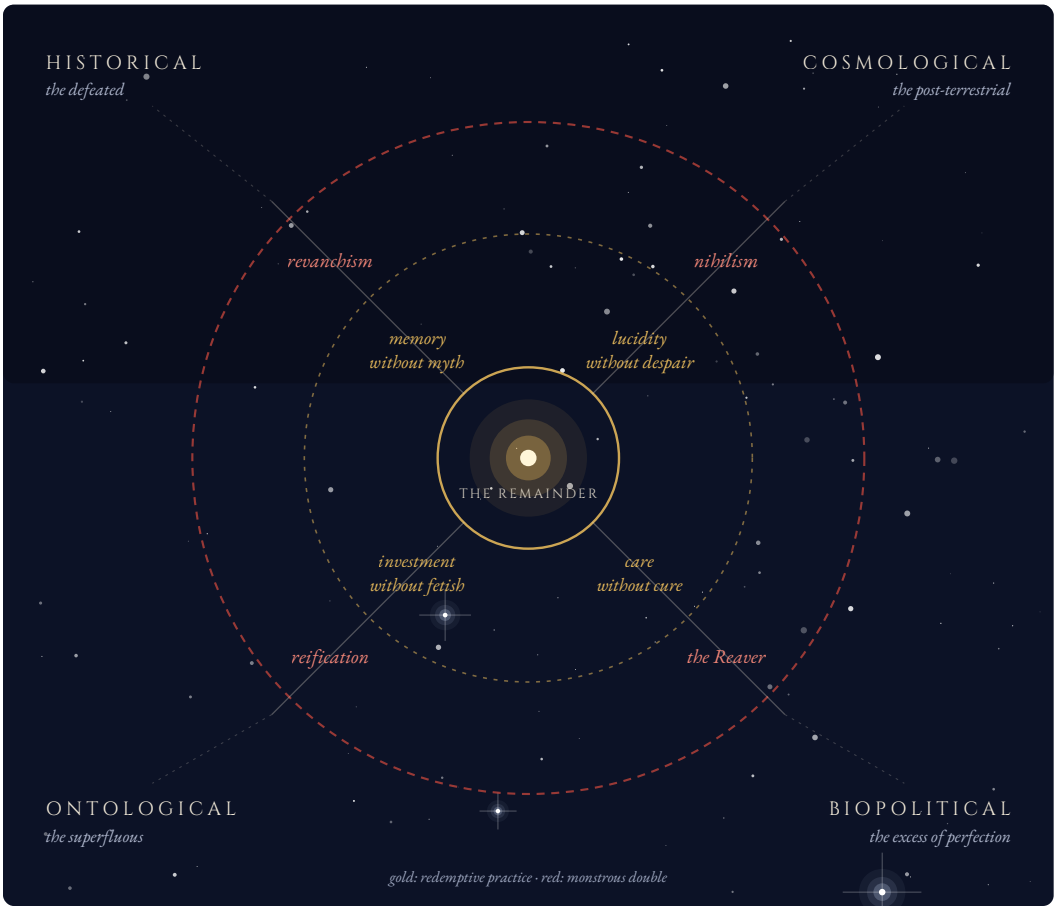


FIGURE 9 *The four remainders.* Each register of the remainder with its redemptive practice (gold, inner ring) and its monstrous double (red, outer ring), after the table above.

10.3

The Reaver Mask

After the massacre at Haven, Mal has Serenity dressed with the corpses of the settlement's dead and painted to pass as a Reaver vessel, so that the crew may fly through Reaver space to Miranda. The crew's horror is the film's own, and Zoe, his oldest comrade, protests outright. Nietzsche's warning (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §146) is the obvious gloss: whoever fights monsters must take care not to become one. Jean-Pierre Vernant's essay on "the beautiful death and the outraged corpse" (1982) supplies a sharper one. Homeric heroism, Vernant argued, is organized around the

kalos thanatos, the death that fixes the hero's beauty in memory, and its supreme degradation is *aikia*, the mutilation of the corpse—Achilles dragging Hector behind his chariot. The Reavers' signature is *aikia*. In dressing his ship with the dead, Mal commits the Reavers' crime upon the bodies of Haven in order to save the living.

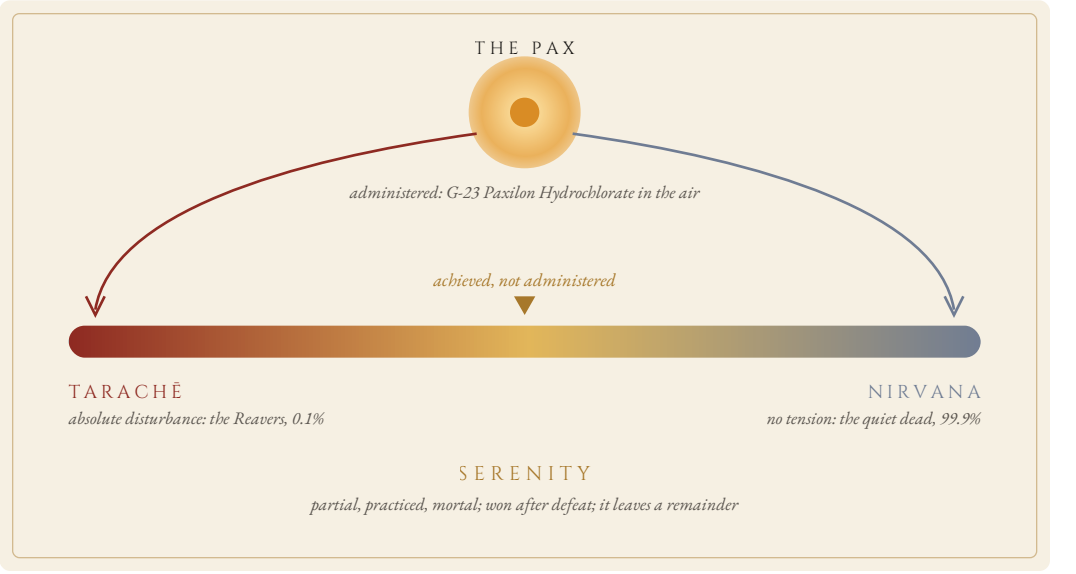


FIGURE 10 *Two serenities.* The administered serenity of the Pax leaves no remainder and drives life to one extreme or the other. The achieved serenity of the crew is partial, practiced and mortal, and it is won after defeat.

Whedon's own humanism located the danger in the same place. Accepting the Outstanding Lifetime Achievement Award in Cultural Humanism from the Humanist Chaplaincy at Harvard and the Harvard Secular Society in April 2009, he argued that the enemy of humanism is not faith but hate, fear, and ignorance—the darker part of human nature present in every humanist and every person. The Reaver mask stages that claim. The monster is not outside the crew but available within it, which is why the corpus cannot secure the crew's goodness by contrast with the Reavers and must secure it instead by practice.

Machiavelli told his prince that he must learn to be able not to be good (*Il Principe*, ch. 15). Michael Walzer's "Political Action: The Problem of Dirty Hands" (1973) argued that a political actor may be obliged to do wrong in order to do right, and that he must nonetheless acknowledge the wrong as wrong; Sartre's *Les Mains sales* (1948) had staged the same predicament. Mal's hands are dirty, and the film does not wash them. It then compounds the act. Mal leads the Reaver armada into the Alliance fleet waiting at Mr. Universe's moon, and the Pax's two products—the state that made the monsters and the monsters it made—destroy one another overhead. The return of the repressed is literalized as a battle; the remainder turns the monstrous remainder back upon its author, in a miniature of what Hegel called the cunning of reason. The act is fraught: Mal uses monsters as weapons, an instrumentalization the corpus does not sanitize.

What distinguishes the remainder that wears the mask from the remainder that becomes it? The film's answer is mourning. The mask comes off; the crew bury and burn their dead. The *Iliad* ends not with a victory but with Priam in Achilles's tent, ransoming Hector's body, and with Hector's funeral: the epic of wrath closes by restoring the honor of the corpse it had outraged. *Serenity* moves from *aikia* to funeral along the same arc. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) asked whose lives are grievable, and argued that the distribution of grievability is political. The broadcast makes Miranda's dead grievable; the funeral makes the crew's dead grievable to them. The criterion that keeps the remainder human is not purity but the capacity to mourn.

10.4

The Salvage Polity: Eight Theses

I Belonging is elective and renewed by practice. The polity is an encounter that took hold (Althusser), a community of fellow-voyagers and fellow-soldiers (Aristotle), whose consent must be won again with each job.

II Sovereignty is bounded by the hull. It is limited, mobile, and exercised under the discipline of mercy, as in the airlock scene of "Ariel."

III Repair precedes replacement. The polity is Neurath's boat and Theseus's ship, rebuilt at sea from what is at hand; its cosmogony is Nüwa's, not Gonggong's.

IV Uselessness is a right. The polity survives by remaining beneath notice and unfit for the state's carpentry (Zhuangzi; Scott; the Epicurean *lathe biōsas*).

V Care is owed without the promise of cure. Simon does not fix River; he keeps her alive and lets her become who she is (Tronto; Williams).

VI Violence regenerates nothing and must be mourned. Slotkin's third term is refused, and every death is buried (Vernant; *Iliad* 24).

VII Truth is cargo. The polity is obliged to carry the testimony of the remainder and to deliver it to those it concerns (Benjamin; Mencius; the signal).

VIII Enough is the measure. The polity seeks sufficiency, not perfection, and knows when to stop (Epicurus; Laozi; Camus).

10.5

The Ethics of Enough

"Nothing is enough for one to whom enough is little" (Epicurus, *Vatican Sayings* 68). Self-sufficiency, *autarkeia*, is for Epicurus a great good—not so that we may always make do with little, but so that, lacking much, we may be content with little (*Letter to Menoeceus* 130). The *Daodejing*

states the same ethic in its own idiom: 知足者富, "one who knows what is enough is rich" (33); 知足不辱，知止不殆, "know what is enough and you will not be disgraced; know when to stop and you will not be endangered" (44); and the dissertation's fourth epigraph, that no calamity is greater than not knowing what is enough (46). Aristotle distinguished household management, whose true wealth has a limit, from chrematistics, the art of acquisition, which has none, and rejected Solon's line that no bound of wealth is set for men as false of true wealth (*Politics* 1.8–9, 1256b–1257b). The Alliance is a chrematistics of the soul. Its *imperium sine fine* is a melioration without end: the comparative "better" made infinite, and therefore never satisfied until nothing remains to improve.

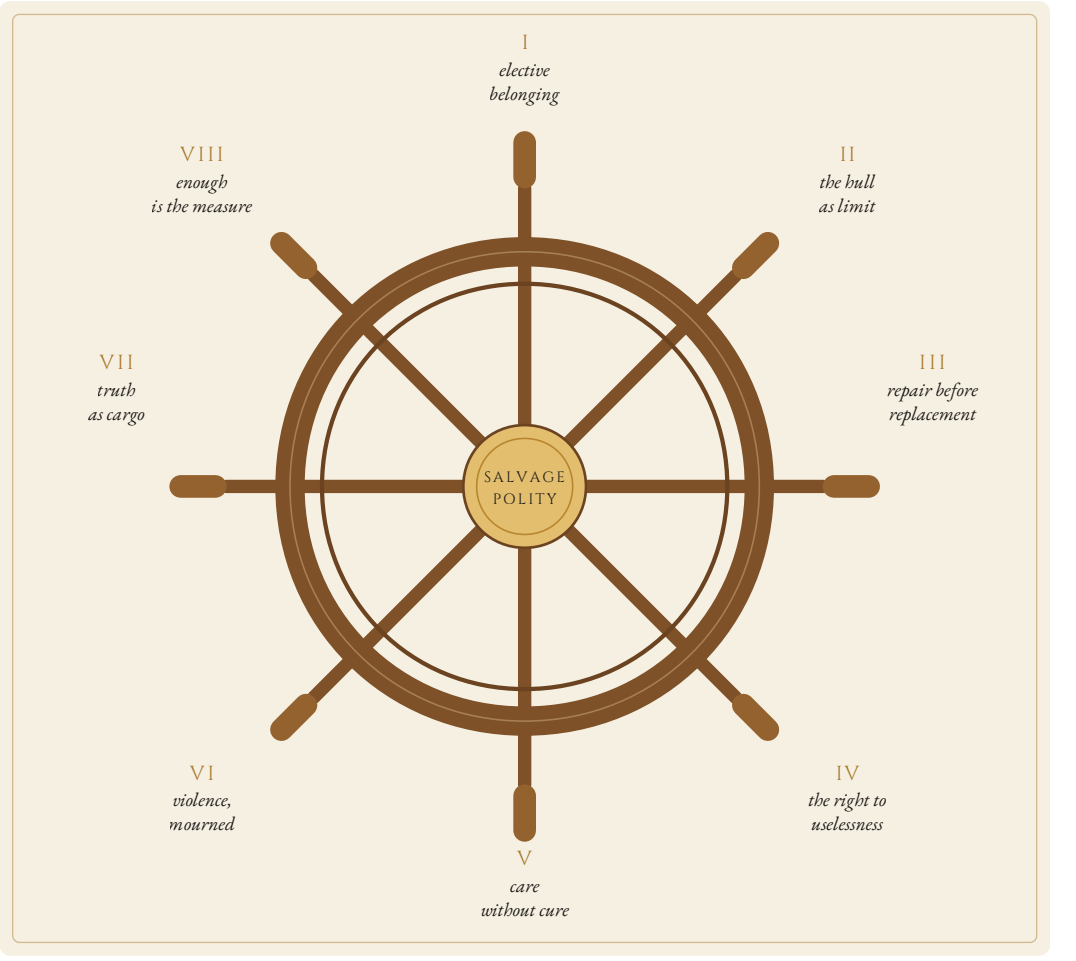


FIGURE 11 *The helm of the salvage polity.* The eight theses set as the spokes of a ship's wheel: the polity is steered by all eight at once, and loses its course if any one is let go.

Camus closed *L'Homme révolté* by invoking Nemesis as the goddess of measure rather than vengeance, and by insisting that rebellion remains rebellion only while it keeps its limit. Vasily Grossman, in *Life and Fate* (completed 1960, published 1980), gave the ethic its most moving modern

statement through the holy fool Ikonnikov, whose manuscript distinguishes the great Good of ideologies, in whose name blood is always shed, from the senseless, unwitnessed kindness of ordinary people, which survives every ideology. Michael Oakeshott's "On Being Conservative" (1956) described a disposition that prefers the familiar to the unknown and the sufficient to the superabundant. The third petition of the Serenity Prayer, the wisdom to distinguish what can be changed from what cannot, is in its practical form the knowledge of enough. Mal's credo before the final assault—that the Alliance will try again to make people better, and that he does not hold to that—is the ethics of enough stated as a refusal of the better. The pilot's last exchange states it as an affirmation; the Conclusion returns to it.

10.6

The Remnant and the Signal

Giorgio Agamben's commentary on the Letter to the Romans, *Il tempo che resta* (2000), argues that the Pauline remnant (*leimma*, Rom. 11:5) is not a numerical portion of a people but the impossibility of any whole coinciding with itself: a division that divides divisions, which Agamben calls the cut of Apelles. Its mode of life is the messianic "as not" (*hōs mē*) of 1 Corinthians 7:29–31—they that weep as though they wept not, they that use this world as not abusing it. The crew use the Alliance's world as not: they trade in its goods, carry its cargo, and dock at its ports without belonging to it. The remnant does not restore the Independent whole that was lost at Serenity Valley; it ensures that the Alliance's whole can never close upon itself.

The signal is the remnant's proclamation, and Jacob Clifton's "Signal to Noise" (2007) has read the film as a parable about media: who controls the channel, and how a signal is separated from noise. Mr. Universe's broadcast is a *kerygma* in reverse, bad news that saves; it exercises Benjamin's weak messianic power; it is the occasion on which, in Mencius's phrase, Heaven sees as the people see. It does not overthrow the Alliance. Mal expects the Alliance to try again, the Operative warns that the Tams may still be hunted in retribution, and the film's realism on this point is essential. The signal is not a revolution but a remainder made visible: the intermittent light of the firefly, in Didi-Huberman's sense, which does not abolish the searchlight but reveals what it was hiding.

10.7

Beyond Libertarian and Progressive Readings

The libertarian reading captures the corpus's hostility to administration—the Libertarian Futurist Society's 2006 citation praised the film as "pro-freedom" and its heroes as fighters against "oppressive collectivism"— and Hayek's argument that no central planner can command the dispersed local knowledge on which social coordination depends ("The Use of Knowledge in Society," 1945) is a respectable gloss on Miranda, as is the "framework for utopia" Robert Nozick proposed in 1974: a

minimal state within which voluntary communities pursue their own conceptions of the good, which is exactly what the ship needs from the 'verse and does not get. It misses that the Rim's markets are as predatory as the Core's administration—Niska tortures for debts, Higgins holds his workers in bondage, Burgess claims a child as property—and that the crew's bonds are care rather than contract. "Collectivism" also misnames the target. The crew is itself a collective, and what distinguishes it from the Alliance is not individualism but the difference between a community entered by choice and held together by care and one imposed by administration. Progressive critiques of the Lost Cause trace, the techno-Orientalism, and the gender politics are sound, and Section 10.8 adopts them; but they sometimes read the corpus's anti-statism as reactionary and so miss that the Alliance's sin is meliorism, not government as such, and that the corpus's moral center is an ethic of care.

Each tradition the corpus touches captures a facet of its politics: the conservative skepticism of Burke's distrust of rational reconstruction (1790), of Oakeshott, and of Kant's crooked timber, the anarchism of Laozi, Scott, and Kropotkin's *Mutual Aid* (1902), Niebuhr's Christian realism, Camus's measure, the Epicurean garden. What unites the facets is not a view of markets or states but a refusal of totalization and an affirmation of limit. The corpus's politics may therefore be described as a *transideological constellation of limit*. It belongs to no party because it is organized around a remainder no party represents.

The corpus's reception shows the same plurality. The brown coat has been claimed by libertarians, conservatives, and progressives, each reading the defeated cause as its own, and the fandom's politics are as heterogeneous as the corpus's readings. One of the show's own actors became a central figure in an unrelated online movement: in August 2014 Adam Baldwin, who played Jayne, coined the hashtag #GamerGate for a campaign that its participants framed as a protest about ethics in games journalism and that journalists and researchers widely documented as involving organized harassment of women in the games industry. The remainder's iconography is available to many uses, and the corpus cannot control which of them its audience makes.

10.8

Objections and Limits

Five objections limit the argument without refuting it. First, the Confederate trace: the genealogy of the Independents traced in Chapter 3 changes the terms of the objection, but it does not erase the decision to model the defeated on the losing side of a war fought over slavery, and the corpus's refusal to name chattel slavery—it encodes the slave catcher's office in Jubal Early without naming it—remains a real limitation. Second, the Reavers: their iconography—face paint, mutilation, cannibalism, rape, the raid on the isolated settlement—reproduces the Western's image of Native peoples as savage marauders, whose construction Robert Berkhofer anatomized in *The White Man's Indian* (1978) and whose cinematic template is *Stagecoach*'s Apaches. That image did political work. It accompanied, and was invoked to justify, the dispossession and killing of Native na-

tions by the United States and its settlers: the Indian Removal Act signed by Andrew Jackson in 1830, under whose policy the United States forcibly removed the Cherokee westward in 1838–39 at a cost of thousands of lives; the killing of Cheyenne and Arapaho people, most of them women, children, and the elderly, by Colorado volunteers under John Chivington at Sand Creek in 1864; and the killing of Lakota people by the Seventh Cavalry at Wounded Knee in 1890. Agnes B. Curry notes that Whedon was explicit about the parallel between the Reavers and Hollywood's Indians (Curry 2008). Terraforming produced a frontier without natives that nonetheless required a savage. The film's revision turns the trope partly against itself, revealing the savage as the civilization's manufacture, but the corpus exploits the trope's effects while critiquing its cause.

The concept on which this dissertation's conclusion leans sharpens the objection. Before Didi-Huberman, the Anishinaabe writer and theorist Gerald Vizenor made *survivance*—survival joined to resistance—the name for Native peoples' active presence against the narratives of absence and victimry that the Western told about them (*Manifest Manners*, 1994). The 'verse is the precise antithesis of Vizenor's survivance: a frontier from which Native presence was removed in advance by terraforming, and whose only figure in that place is a savage manufactured by the state. To speak of the firefly's survivance without acknowledging Vizenor's would repeat, at the level of theory, the erasure the 'verse performs at the level of its world.

Third, the absent Chinese: the Daoist undertow of Chapter 9 is the interpreter's discovery, not the show's achievement, and reading against the grain does not absolve the grain. Fourth, gender: the critique of the Companion stands, including the Guild's training of children for its profession; River's infantilization and weaponization repeat a pattern across Whedon's work that risks reproducing the fantasy of the engineered female weapon it means to indict, and Laura Mulvey's analysis of the male gaze ("Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema," 1975) bears on the film's staging of her combat. Fifth, authorship: the allegations set out in the Introduction—Kai Cole's in 2017; Ray Fisher's and Gal Gadot's concerning *Justice League*; Charisma Carpenter's, Michelle Trachtenberg's, and others' concerning *Buffy* and *Angel*; and the *Firefly* writer Jose Molina's concerning Whedon's treatment of writers—most of which Whedon has disputed, while acknowledging the affairs Cole described, have unsettled the reputation as a feminist auteur on which much early Whedon criticism relied. They bear directly on the fourth objection: the corpus's most celebrated women, a courtesan and an engineered weapon, were long read through their author's self-presentation, and Molina's account places the question inside the room where the corpus was written. The remainder thesis applies here reflexively. The corpus is collaborative, and it survives its author's diminishment as a remainder he cannot reclaim. Taken together, the objections show that the corpus is itself a remainder of contradictory materials—which is a limitation of the work and a confirmation of the thesis.

10.9

Coda: The Cancelled Show as Remainder

The corpus's material history performs its argument. A network aired it out of order, broadcast its pilot last, placed it in a slot reserved for programs expected to fail, and cancelled it after eleven episodes. Its audience—self-named for the defeated army—bought the DVDs, campaigned for a film, and, from 2006, organized the "Can't Stop the Serenity" charity screenings benefiting Equality Now. Michel de Certeau described readers as poachers who make their own uses of texts they did not author, and Henry Jenkins's *Textual Poachers* (1992) made the description the founding concept of fan studies. The Browncoats' poaching was salvage: they pieced together what had been smashed. Prospero's epilogue asks the audience to set him free with its indulgence—"As you from crimes would pardon'd be, / Let your indulgence set me free"—and the series was freed in exactly that way. Didi-Huberman's fireflies survive the searchlight not by outshining it but by persisting beneath it. The conquering cause pleased the network; the conquered, the Browncoats.

CONCLUSION

It's Enough



The pilot ends with a short exchange on the bridge. Mal, having brought his ship and his strange new company through Reavers, a double-cross, and an Alliance cruiser, sums up their achievement: "We're still flying." Book observes, not unkindly, "That's not much." Mal answers: "It's enough." The whole philosophy of the corpus is folded into those seven words, and this dissertation has been an attempt to unfold it.

The argument can be restated in a paragraph. *Firefly* and *Serenity* are an art of the remainder: an inquiry into what persists after defeat, after the exhaustion of Earth, after the death of God, and after the state's attempt to perfect the human. Their form is the Lucanian Western, an epic of the vanquished in the episodic mode of romance. Their antagonist is an Augustan imperium whose pacifying agent literalizes Tacitus's desolation called peace, counterfeits Epicurean *ataraxia*, and splits the death drive into the quiet dead and the Reavers. Their decisive event is the relocation of evil from the abyss to the administrative state, a passage from Lisbon to the camps. Their privileged knower is the subject the system broke, whose damage is the condition of her knowledge. Their medium is an economy of care; their institution is the salvage polity, an elective micro-sovereignty bounded by the hull and constituted by repair; their unintended critic is the Chinese archive they quote only in curses; and their ethic is the serenity of enough, opposed to the infinite comparative of the better.

Kant wrote that out of timber so crooked as that from which man is made, nothing entirely straight can be built. The corpus does not dispute him. It answers that a ship can be built from crooked timber, that it will fly crooked, and that it will fly. That answer distinguishes Serenity from Dante's Ulysses, whose company also made wings of their oars for a mad flight beyond the limit of the world in pursuit of *canoscenza*, and who foundered within sight of the mountain. Serenity's crew found the knowledge they sought and returned, for three reasons the corpus makes explicit. Their flight knew when to stop. Their knowledge was carried back to be shared rather than possessed. And their company was bound by care rather than by glory. Dante's fireflies glowed in the valley of the fraudulent; these glow in a valley named Serenity, and their light, intermittent and minor, has survived.

Lucan's line opened this dissertation: the conquering cause pleased the gods, and the conquered pleased Cato. *Firefly* offers the conquered a third possibility, neither to please the gods nor to die like Cato, but to keep flying—which is not much, and is enough.

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